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Goings On

- ## Justine Kurland’s Photographs Keep Us on Edge

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***By** Vince Aletti, Mengfei Chen, Brian Seibert, Sheldon Pearce, Emily Nussbaum, Zoë Hopkins, Richard Brody, **and** Hilton Als*

October 2, 2026

As one of the most arresting, provocative, and unpredictable photographers around, **Justine Kurland,** at fifty-six, deserves to have her mid-career retrospective in a museum. Instead, it’s at the small, scrappy gallery Osmos, in the East Village (through Nov. 21), where it is both comfortably at home and quietly overwhelming. The gallery describes Kurland as seeing her subjects “through a queer feminist lens,” which is immediately evident in the works on view, but can’t begin to account for their range, wit, or depth of feeling. She’s not always subtle—see the collage series she calls the “*SCUMB* Manifesto,” after Valerie Solanas, in which she cuts up the work of white male artists—and is far too present in the moment to be a cool observer. Even the classic Western landscape images that include the trains her young son was obsessed with are more dream than document: wonder realized, simply sublime.



“Blood Sisters,” from 2000.

Photograph by Justine Kurland / Courtesy Osmos

The show opens with two pictures from the color series that introduced Kurland to the world and became known as the “Girl Pictures”—cinematic shots of adolescent girls playing at being runaways. Under the photographer’s rapt gaze, theatricality melts away and we’re caught up in the sweet, casually intimate camaraderie of girls on an adventure. Although most of the other women here are naked, the vision isn’t always Edenic. Communal life, a frequent subject, includes hard work; motherhood, even in a seemingly idyllic group of ten women with babies, isn’t any easier. Hung between these larger color photographs are smaller black-and-white images that feel like diary entries. In one, Kurland is lying naked with her mother; in another, she’s masturbating, body contorted, head thrown back, suspended between agony and ecstasy. Throughout her show, Kurland keeps us both fascinated and on edge—anywhere but in our comfort zone.—*Vince Aletti*

About Town

Broadway

A spiky analogue to American teen films, Jocelyn Bioh's **"School Girls; Or, The African Mean Girls Play"** is set at a boarding school in Ghana in 1986, where a clique of excitable students has been gearing up to compete in the Miss Ghana pageant. Their cruel leader is Paulina (an excellent, layered Denée Benton), who is sure the crown is hers until a light-skinned newcomer from the U.S. (the fabulous Jasmine Amy Rogers) steals her followers and her thunder. With its fusillade of queen-bee zingers and blunt-force plot mechanics, "School Girls" is an unabashedly didactic project, its themes of colorism heavily underlined. But, under the crisp, fluid direction of Whitney White ("Liberation"), the cast achieves impeccable chemistry, allowing each actress—including sweet standouts such as Erin Morton, as the shy Nana—to shine. When they harmonize on "The Greatest Love of All," you could almost hear Whitney herself cheer.—*Emily Nussbaum (Samuel J. Friedman; through Nov. 15.)*

Dance

A mute ballet about a master of verbal wit such as Oscar Wilde might seem an odd idea, but the appeal of the subject for the choreographer Christopher Wheeldon, who's scaled the heights of ballet and Broadway, lies in the possibility of creating something all too rare: a full-length narrative ballet centered on romance between men. Created in 2024 for the **Australian Ballet,** which now gives the work its New York première, Wheeldon's "Oscar" braids parts of Wilde's life with two of his writings, "The Nightingale and the Rose" and "The Picture of Dorian Gray." The forty-eight-piece Orchestra of St. Luke's plays Joby Talbot's score live.—*Brian Seibert (New York City Center; Oct. 8-11.)*

Alt R. & B.



Kelela.

Photograph by Spencer Sisselman

For much of her career, the progressive artist **Kelela** has toyed with the idea of genre in an intuitive way, hardwiring electronic music into the DNA of an R. & B. sound. Across several records, she has conscientiously adapted her music to fit its context, letting both margin and intention dictate its immediate form. Her latest album, “new avatar,” ventures further, blending shoegaze and grunge into her existing palette. Influenced by her days in Washington, D.C.,’s indie scene, the record compels her practice toward a more guitar-driven substratum of her intersectional songcraft, seeking to expand the parameters of what “alternative” can even mean.—*Sheldon Pearce (Brooklyn Paramount; Oct. 9-10.)*

Art

We’ve stepped into some kind of deep, three-dimensional painting: in the exhibition “You Red the Shirt Off My Back,” **Eric N. Mack** leads us through layer after layer of fabric, cutting a nimble economy of angles and gestures across the gallery floor. Huge swaths of cloth play between differing registers of opacity and transparency. The shape most prevalent in the gallery is caused by

gravity, the parabolic curve of fabric sinking toward the ground: cloth is tempted to droop and fall, weight traces a line in the air, the physics of lightness and heaviness become formal elements. In several of the pieces, Mack drapes fabric from steel armatures that resemble bodies. The works lay claim to our own bodies, their drapery becoming adornments sweeping from limb upon limb.—*Zoë Hopkins (Paula Cooper; through Oct. 24.)*

Off Broadway



Elf Lyons, at SoHo Playhouse.

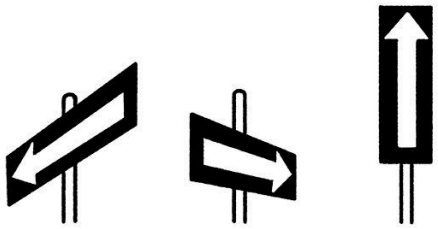
Photograph by Carol Rosegg

In **“Elf Lyons Is the Woman on the Edge,”** Lyons, a virtuosic physical performer who trained as a clown, uses the breakup, via WhatsApp, of her engagement as a starting point for her latest show, which débuted at this year’s Edinburgh Festival Fringe. With smoke wafting from the décolletage of her cocktail dress, a bewigged Lyons, balancing on her toes like a life-size doll (a feat of arch endurance with a payoff), runs at a rapid clip through genres of performance and registers of emotion. She channels a Hitchcockian lady in distress and riffs on the movie “Apollo 13”;

there are two banana phones and a brilliant running bit about the opera “Pagliacci.” The show is a genuine, absurd, and furious exploration of love and heartbreak.—*Mengfei Chen (SoHo Playhouse; through Oct. 18.)*

Movies

The formidable artistry of Dakota Johnson and Anne Hathaway is squandered in their stalwart efforts to keep **“Verity”** afloat. This melodrama, based on a novel by Colleen Hoover, involves an obscure young novelist named Lowen (Johnson) who is hired to complete a series of books by the famous titular author (Hathaway), who has been left catatonic after a grave accident. Lodged in Verity’s rural home to study her preliminary notes, Lowen becomes romantically involved with the incapacitated writer’s husband (Josh Hartnett) while starting to suspect Verity of a crime, and deciding to administer punishment. The setup is strong, but the working-out is absurd, and the director, Michael Showalter, neither builds a world nor fleshes out the characters; all that’s left is star power in a dim void.—*Richard Brody (In wide release.)*



Pick Three

Hilton Als on the art of Jessica Lange.

1. In 2016, I was one of the folks lucky enough to see Jessica Lange’s extraordinary performance in Eugene O’Neill’s **“Long Day’s Journey Into Night.”** It taught me what was at the core of Lange’s greatness—her authenticity. As one of the four “haunted”

Tyrones, Lange's matriarch, Mary, was torn by her dream of family and her equally strong desire to be alone. Moving between guilt and recrimination, flirtatiousness and despair, Lange played Mary largely with her back to the audience. Now Lange stars in the film adaptation (currently in L.A.). By turns furious and ravishing in her beauty and need, Lange is so distinctly American in her understanding of loneliness that she stuns you with Mary's self-knowledge—and her, at times, smug martyrdom.

2. The real reason I started watching **"American Horror Story"** again is to see Lange do what her brilliance directs her to do: bring a level of reality to whatever situation she finds her character in, no matter how surreal. Lange is a very physical actress; her hands speak as she speaks, sometimes contradicting what her character is saying by seeming to wave things away while she plots something else. She finds the truth of character, and her physicality, in playing with the words, not in anticipation. That would be mugging, and where's the truth in that?

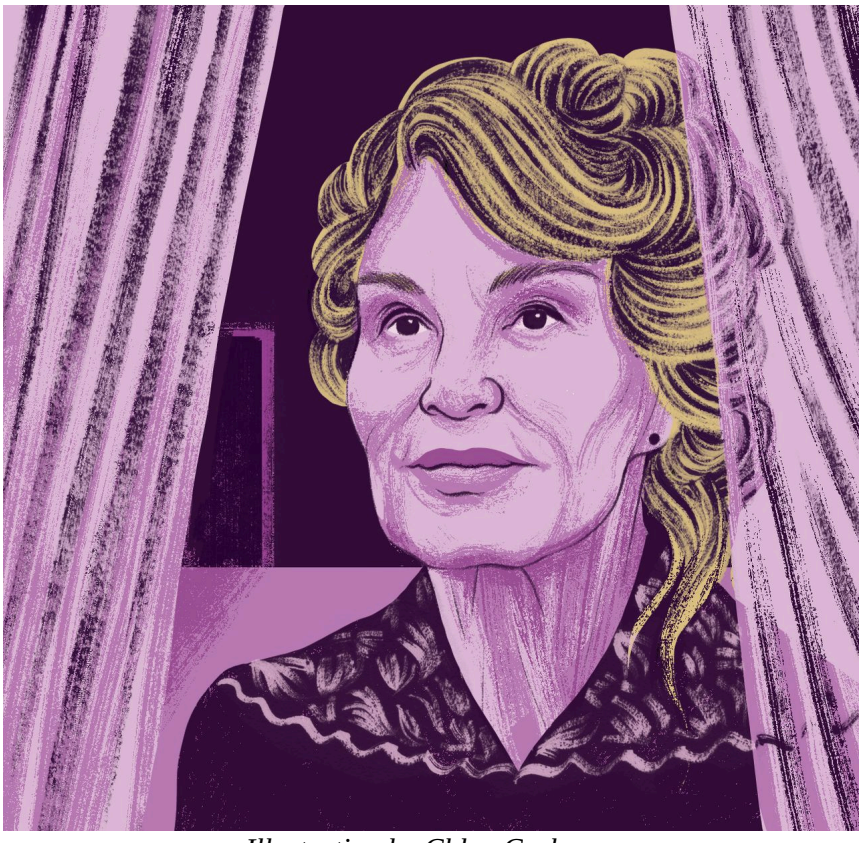


Illustration by Chloe Cushman

3. On a recent episode of “The View,” Lange talked about how, as a little girl, she would act out various parts of “Gone with the Wind,” and about how she always longed for community. All of her characters want to connect, if they only knew how. In 2023, Lange published a book of photographs she took during *COVID*, called **“Dérive.”** (I contributed an introduction.) There, in the photographs, was Jessica’s sensibility as a performer, too: haunting and haunted, as lonesome as a breeze.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- Behind the scenes at the baths
- “Girls,” by Sophie Kemp
- *Lucy Dacus and Hannah Einbinder are free agents now*

Vince Aletti is a photography critic and the author of “Issues: A History of Photography in Fashion Magazines.”
Mengfei Chen is a former member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.
Brian Seibert has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of “What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing,” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.
Sheldon Pearce is a music writer for The New Yorker’s Goings On newsletter.
Emily Nussbaum, a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2011, is the magazine’s theatre critic. Her books include “Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV.”
Zoë Hopkins is a contributor to Goings On who writes about art.
Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of “Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard.”
Hilton Als, a staff writer at The New Yorker, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin.”

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https://www.newyorker.com/culture/goings-on/justine-kurlands-photographs-keep-us-on-edge

Photo Booth

The Teen Portraits That Captivated Sofia Coppola

Joseph Szabo's pictures capture American adolescents' spontaneous presence and loose-limbed, insouciant grace.

***By** Margaret Talbot*

September 26, 2026



Photographs by Joseph Szabo

The photographer Joseph Szabo's pictures in the new book "American Teen" look timeless in certain ways—the crisp black-and-white of the images, the stately framing, the instantly recognizable, casual but charged, proximity of teen-agers hanging out, arms slung over their friends' shoulders, heads tipped together, close enough to smell one another's shampoo. Here they are, crammed together in the random corners they stake out on a big high-school campus, or thigh to thigh on a patchwork of beach towels, or whispering in one another's ears, thick as thieves, magnetized by one another as by nobody and nothing else.

But there is also a sense in which these images belong, ineluctably, to the time in which most of them were made, the nineteen-seventies and nineteen-eighties, after Szabo had begun teaching

photography and photographing students at Malverne High School, on Long Island. It's not just the styles his subjects favor—abundant, feathered hair, high-waisted, slouchy jeans, ringer T-shirts, platform shoes, puka-shell necklaces. (In any case, some of their looks would read as hip today.) It's not even the fact that the photos frequently show kids smoking cigarettes (though that's certainly striking to see). The adolescent subjects of Szabo's photos project something else: nearly all, even the ones who look shy or awkward or sidelined by their peers, have a kind of spontaneous *presence*, the loose-limbed, insouciant grace, even swagger, of subjects who have not been making and curating images of themselves and one another for as long as they can remember. As the musician and artist Kim Gordon writes in a short introduction to "American Teen," Szabo "captures not just what it looks like to be that confusing age, but what it felt like in a pre-filter-polished world before Instagram, AI, and TikTok, all these contemporary mirrors that define you through algorithms with every glance."

Szabo was in his early thirties, and had recently earned an M.F.A. in photography at the Pratt Institute, when he moved to Long Island. In 1973 he started teaching darkroom-photography classes at Malverne High. He found that showing kids how to make their own prints, the inextinguishable magic of watching pictures emerge from a chemical developer, was a way to spark interest and connect with students who often seemed more disaffected from school than he remembered ever having been himself. "They'd be, like, I'm *staying* in *this* class; I've got to be able to do this thing with a camera," Szabo, who is now eighty-two, told me recently. The students were natural subjects for him, too—always there, curious to see their lives reflected back to them, with the understated grandeur of black-and-white film. Szabo started taking pictures for the school yearbook and carrying a camera around the school with him all the time. "The kids would say, 'That's Szabo, don't worry about him. He's all right. He's not going to take you to the principal's office for smoking outside—or inside—the school.' "

Eventually, he started turning up at other locations: the deli where some Malverne students gathered, Jones Beach, a Rolling Stones concert in Philadelphia, a bar in town co-owned by the actor and former boxer Tony Danza, even—with parents' permission—some of the students' houses as they prepped for nights out.

"American Teen" is published by Important Flowers, an imprint of the art-book publisher Mack, founded by the director and screenwriter Sofia Coppola, another dedicated observer of adolescent self-presentation. Coppola told me that she first saw a photograph of Szabo's on the cover of the 1991 album "Green Mind," by the proto-grunge band Dinosaur Jr. It shows a young girl—maybe twelve years old—standing on the beach, with long dark hair, gimlet eyes, and a partially smoked cigarette in her mouth. She looks both vulnerable and curiously self-possessed. Her name was Priscilla, and Szabo never saw her again. Coppola, who collects photography, told me that she was instantly taken with the image. Years later, when she launched Important Flowers, she thought of Szabo's work immediately, especially after she noticed that some earlier books of his were now out of print and selling for five hundred dollars or more online.

Coppola told me that she admires how Szabo's images can feel intimate without seeming intrusive. His subjects "feel comfortable with him, you can tell," she said. "The photos don't seem self-conscious or posed. The kids don't have their guards up. You don't feel he's *peering* at them." He made several pictures of couples making out or gazing besottedly into each other's eyes, surrounded by other teen-agers who show a funny kind of delicacy—they haven't moved out of the couples' force field, but they're not gawping at them, either. In "American Teen," there's a picture that shows three girls seated at their desks. The one in the middle is blowing a bubble, with her legs stretched out and propped up on the chair of the girl in front of her. She is looking down at the papers on her desk, and she seems like she's concentrating—not

deeply engaged but not bored, either, at ease in the classroom like it was a satellite of home, and seemingly at ease in her own skin, too.

I went to high school in the late nineteen-seventies myself, and "American Teen" made me nostalgic for how hanging out felt then, powered by the implicit guarantee that between classes or after school you would find your friends posted in their usual spots, and they would have time for you, so much time. It reminded me, pleasantly, too, of a kind of low-key, free-to-be-you-and-me androgyny that I associate with that era. In Szabo's pictures, the guys and girls alike wear jeans a lot; many of the boys have shoulder-length hair; the clothes are often loose and layered (big sweaters, denim jackets, overalls, plaid shirts over tank tops), and nobody looks hellbent on perfection. That scruffier, cozier version of androgyny coexisted in the culture with the more flamboyant gender-bending of glam rock. The seventies were fun that way. Flipping through the book, I thought of the Replacements song "Androgynous," from 1984, with the hopeful lyrics "Now, something meets boy, and something meets girl / They both look the same, they're overjoyed in this world / Same hair revolution, unisex evolution / Tomorrow, who's gonna fuss?"

As it happens, the fussing—about gender identity, about teen-agers and their anxieties—has only got louder in recent decades. Szabo's photos, by contrast, are remarkably free of fretting or judgment. They are a reminder of how cool teen-agers can be, in their own tribes, on their own time. ♦

Margaret Talbot joined The New Yorker as a staff writer in 2004. She is the author, with David Talbot, of "By the Light of Burning Dreams: The Triumphs and Tragedies of the Second American Revolution."

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https://www.newyorker.com/culture/photo-booth/the-teen-portraits-that-captivated-sofia-coppola

The Talk of the Town

- ## ICE Is Everywhere and Acting with Impunity
  By Jonathan Blitzer | Arrests have reached a record high—nearly fifty-one thousand in August alone—with agents conducting operations nationwide at hospitals, at airports, and outside schools.
- ## How to Fight Your Landlord, the Heel
  By Dan Greene | In Williamsburg, wrestlers dressed like Zohran Mamdani and a cockroach take turns in the ring. Their opponent? The big, bad Slumlord.
- ## Olive Garden Is the Real True North
  By Zach Helfand | Two guys created a compass that points to the restaurant's Times Square location. On a trek rivalling the Odyssey—and with breadsticks on the line—they navigate all the way from Staten Island.
- ## Ellen Allien's Hill of Sound
  By Nick Paumgarten | On a trip to the Cooper Hewitt museum, the techno d.j. reflects on her latest album, "New Life," and on how Michael Jackson and ABBA haunted her Berlin childhood.
- ## Ernie Bushmiller's Sunday Morning, Live
  By Emma Allen | In 1976, the artist behind the "Nancy" comic was slighted on "S.N.L." A new Off Off Broadway show tells the tale of the day after.

Comment

ICE Is Everywhere and Acting with Impunity

Arrests have reached a record high—nearly fifty-one thousand in August alone—with agents conducting operations nationwide at hospitals, at airports, and outside schools.

By Jonathan Blitzer

October 4, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

It has taken the Trump Administration less than two years to make violent encounters with federal immigration agents a regular fact of American life. On a single day late last month, a citizen and a noncitizen—one in Illinois, the other in Texas—became the most recent examples of this new reality. That morning, in Evanston, a Black man walking to a pharmacy was left injured and bleeding by the side of a road after a group of *ICE* officers, mistaking him for an immigrant "fugitive," threw him to the ground and tried to

handcuff him. Once the agents realized that he was a U.S. citizen, they said that they offered him “assistance,” then drove off. A few hours later, in Austin, an *ICE* officer shot a Venezuelan delivery driver in the back as he tried to flee in his car. He was detained, and partial paralysis had set in before doctors removed the bullet, several days later. Last Tuesday, the Department of Justice announced that it was charging the man with assaulting the officer who shot him.

Almost as alarming as the incidents themselves has been the government’s refusal to acknowledge a pattern of abuse that is clearly metastasizing at the Department of Homeland Security. Since Donald Trump took office last year, agents from D.H.S. have shot at some two dozen people in the United States, killing six of them. The deaths of Renee Good and Alex Pretti during Operation Metro Surge, in Minnesota last January, were a turning point in the public’s awareness of the problem, but their deaths were not the first. Ten months earlier, in South Padre Island, Texas, Ruben Ray Martinez, a twenty-three-year-old U.S. citizen, was shot and killed by an *ICE* officer—something that the government didn’t disclose for nearly a year, until American Oversight, a nonprofit group, obtained the incident report. In one week this past July, *ICE* agents killed Lorenzo Salgado Araujo, a Mexican national who had lived in this country for thirty-five years, raising a family and running a building company, and Johan Sebastián Durán Guerrero, a twenty-five-year-old Colombian with a wife and toddler. These incidents were documented as officer shootings. But how, for instance, should news outlets categorize the death, on July 14th, of a Mexican man visiting family in Florida, on a tourist visa, who was hit by a tractor-trailer as he ran from immigration agents?

Not only has no *ICE* officer been federally charged in these deaths, but the agency has made a habit of casting blame on the people it has appeared to victimize, turning impunity into another form of aggression. The most common claim is that immigrants attempting to escape arrest are “assaulting” officers and, in particular, that

motorists are “weaponizing” their vehicles. In many cases, video evidence seems to contradict such accounts; in others, officers weren’t wearing their body cameras. The *Times* found that the Administration had filed assault charges against more than five hundred and fifty people and that, in about half of the roughly four hundred cases that have been resolved, “juries acquitted defendants, judges threw out charges, or prosecutors withdrew them.”

Because the federal government has largely forsworn—and, indeed, actively blocked—independent investigations of its agents, states have tried to bring their own cases. In August, prosecutors in Minnesota were seeking the extradition of Christian Castro, an *ICE* agent being held in Texas, who was wanted for shooting a Venezuelan national in the leg during Operation Metro Surge. When Greg Abbott, the Texas governor, refused Minnesota’s request, Castro was released. The Justice Department then charged Castro with making “false statements”—he claimed that he’d been attacked with a broom and a snow shovel before firing—a considerably lesser charge than the ones he could have faced. An Assistant U.S. Attorney in Minnesota, Matthew Evans, told the victim’s lawyers that he’d “objected in the strongest possible terms,” but that the decision had been made in Washington. Evans was fired and is now being investigated for allegedly leaking information about the case.

This all comes at a time when *ICE* arrests have reached a record high—nearly fifty-one thousand in August alone—with agents conducting operations nationwide at hospitals, at airports, and outside schools. Past calls by Democratic lawmakers for D.H.S. agents to end the practice of wearing masks in public were ignored, and this summer the department announced that it would be purchasing for its personnel twenty million dollars’ worth of gloves that deliver powerful electric shocks. Flush with cash from Congress, D.H.S. is planning to hire five thousand more *ICE* officers by the end of the year. Recently, it signed seven billion

dollars in construction contracts to build more detention centers. Meanwhile, in all but one of the existing two hundred and thirty-nine immigration jails across the country, the A.P. reported, *ICE* has stopped listing in its online database, known as the detainee locator, the whereabouts of people in custody who have final deportation orders. If people's names don't show up in the locator, their family members and lawyers won't immediately be able to find them. In July, sixteen thousand people arrested by *ICE*, or about a third of those entering detention that month, had final deportation orders.

Given the lack of accountability at D.H.S., it should come as little surprise that Homeland Security Investigations, a branch of *ICE*, has taken the lead in prosecuting one of Trump's principal obsessions: searching for evidence that noncitizens might vote in the midterms next month. Noncitizen voting is virtually nonexistent, as D.H.S.'s own figures show. Since last year, on the President's orders, the department has pursued some sixteen hundred voter-fraud cases, only a hundred and sixty of which even led to arrests. (There are about a hundred and seventy-four million registered voters in the country.) This hasn't stopped the Administration from trying to coerce states to hand over their voter rolls. It has sued thirty of them, as well as Washington, D.C., and threatened officials with prosecution if they don't comply. Trump told the states that, if they failed to coöperate, D.H.S. would withhold tens of millions of dollars' worth of federal funding, including money for disaster relief and counterterrorism operations. Over the summer, Markwayne Mullin, the Secretary of Homeland Security, announced that some sixteen thousand noncitizens were on the voter rolls in Nevada. But a subsequent review by the Nevada secretary of state's office of a list of voters provided by D.H.S. found that they were all U.S. citizens.

Deploying government agencies without regard for facts or consequences is, of course, a hallmark of authoritarianism. Last week, it emerged that the White House used part of the D.H.S.

budget appropriated by Congress to make ads that celebrate the President. They carry a disclosure that doubles as a warning: “Paid for by the U.S. Government.” ♦

Jonathan Blitzer is a staff writer at The New Yorker. His book, “Everyone Who Is Gone Is Here,” received the Hillman Prize and the Robert F. Kennedy Book Award in 2025.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/ice-is-everywhere-and-acting-with-impunity

Clashing by Night

How to Fight Your Landlord, the Heel

In Williamsburg, wrestlers dressed like Zohran Mamdani and a cockroach take turns in the ring. Their opponent? The big, bad Slumlord.

By Dan Greene

October 5, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You're reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

Pro-wrestling narratives are often driven by the villain, or heel—what Roland Barthes called "the bastard." This figure "takes refuge behind the law when he considers that it is in his favor," Barthes

wrote, “and breaks it when he finds it useful to do so.” The other evening, at the Brooklyn Monarch, an industrial space in East Williamsburg, a copywriter named Jacob Knight-Thomas was preparing a wrestling-based production with a familiar urban archetype as its Big Bad. The show’s name: “The Fight Against Slumlords.” “You know what my landlord’s name is in my phone?” Knight-Thomas, a renter, asked. “Lame Ass Fuck.”

Knight-Thomas, who wore a green T-shirt with a yin-yang symbol on the back, was sitting by the stage with a MacBook, reviewing a slide deck. He was a novice event planner (“I don’t even really throw myself birthday parties,” he said), but, as a wrestling fan reared on political satire and MTV’s “Celebrity Deathmatch,” he’d hatched an idea for a night of topical comedic combat, carried out by locals. His first show had been called “The Fight for the Epstein Files.” Among its matches: Redacted vs. Redacted—two grapplers outfitted in black Lycra. Another was a “Last Island Standing” battle royale between the files’ big names. “Trump kept showing up in there, so we had, like, five Trumps,” he said. “Two of them started making out. He loves himself.”

At his laptop, Knight-Thomas reviewed story beats. “The slumlord’s gonna start victim-blaming him,” he explained. In the first match, the good guy would prevail, before a run of villains’ victories. “I want the audience to feel the harsh reality,” he said.

Beside a sign reading “*NO FIGHTING*,” a woman with green hair fit a bald cap onto a wrestler known as Cheeseburger, who would be portraying Eric Adams. Knight-Thomas had bought a plastic trash can for an ersatz Oscar the Grouch. Someone asked what he would do with it afterward. “I have the receipt,” he said.

“Where’s Mamdani?” Knight-Thomas asked—meaning Abraham Khan, a bearded millennial of Pakistani descent who’d be wrestling as Hizzoner. Josh Alba, a comedian playing the titular Slumlord, shrugged. Alba wore a suit with an open-collared shirt and had

slicked back his hair. As a kid in Brooklyn, he said, “eight hundred bucks was rent for an entire apartment.” He’d remained a New Yorker till two weeks earlier: he’d moved to Philadelphia to get more bang for his renting buck. “I still commute to Manhattan three days a week,” he said.

Khan strolled in with a roller bag and an iced coffee, shook a series of hands, and conferred with Alba. Khan said that he typically performs as an antagonist. “When I play heel, I’m always virtue-signalling,” he said.

The crowd trickled in; the vibe was thrifted, power-clashing, pierced. In the show, when a wrestler named Delightful Dan the God Damn Candy Man shooed away a woman in a cockroach costume, she accused him of gentrifying his new hood. “I thought this city was built on immigrants,” he answered. The crowd seemed torn. A tag-team match ensued, which the roach and a man in rat garb won, to cheers. In another clash, Cheeseburger’s Eric Adams, billed as “straight from Turkey,” paid off an official with a cash-filled potato-chip bag. Later, a spate of bids for one of the Slumlord’s listings escalated into a six-person “gentrification scramble.”

Lex Rountree, of the New York State Tenant Bloc, watched while distributing pamphlets to showgoers. She wore a leather skirt and a T-shirt that said “*ASK ME ABOUT TENANT POWER*.” Knight-Thomas had reached her through Hot Girls Organize, formerly Hot Girls 4 Zohran. It was her first wrestling show. “I’m learning a lot,” she said. “There’s a catharsis to it.”

During the main event, as Alba’s Slumlord got into it with Khan’s Mamdani—slacks, tie, white button-down with pushed-up sleeves—another wrestler, in a fleece vest, stepped in to reveal himself as the Slumlord’s puppet master: Private Equity. In the chaos, the Mayor was slammed by two nepo babies, then saved by a duo in blue “Tenants for Zohran” tees. (Rountree whooped.) Khan hit his

finishing move; the announcer shouted, “Rent Freeze! Rent Freeze!” The Mayor won the match and an oversized key to the city. The audience chanted, “Block by block!” Khan punctuated a victory speech by shouting, “Free Palestine!” The crowd roared.

Afterward, Khan, who has a day job in finance, posed for photos. “I’m very neutral on Mamdani,” he confessed. “I’m a middle-of-the-road individual.” Knight-Thomas said there would be another show soon. The theme: dating. ♦

Dan Greene is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/how-to-fight-your-landlord-the-heel

Emerging-Tech Dept.

Olive Garden Is the Real True North

Two guys created a compass that points to the restaurant's Times Square location. On a trek rivalling the Odyssey—and with breadsticks on the line—they navigate all the way from Staten Island.

By Zach Helfand

October 3, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You're reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

A lot of people recently have been wondering whether our technology will murder us all. But it's not all bad. Earlier this year, Jason Goldberg and Steve Nasopoulos, two friends and advertising guys in their thirties, launched a gizmo they'd spent two years developing: a compass that only points to the Olive Garden in Times Square. Five thousand people signed up to order one. "Which we did not expect," Goldberg said the other day. "It was a joke."

Like a lot of emerging tech, the compass ran afoul of I.P. law. Olive Garden's lawyers reached out. "First, thank you for being a fan of Olive Garden," they wrote. Then they demanded the removal of all references to the brand. (Someone from marketing subsequently messaged, "hey! ignore the cease and desist marketing team loves the compass." The lawyers won.) The compass consisted of a G.P.S. module, a motor, and a power source—"I think it's a vape battery," Goldberg said—initially engineered by a guy in California named Josh. It was encased in brass and etched with "Not all who breadstick are lost." "That's a Tolkien line," Nasopoulos said. "I figured it was public domain, but I was wrong. We're fielding multiple lawsuits at all times."

The men ceased and desisted, but they did not give up. They started over. Meanwhile, they'd lost Josh. "He got accepted into Harvard for engineering, and he was, like, 'I can't do this anymore,' " Goldberg said. They'd found a new engineering partner, Glub Glub Labs, which signed on pro bono. Finally, a new prototype was ready. But would it work?

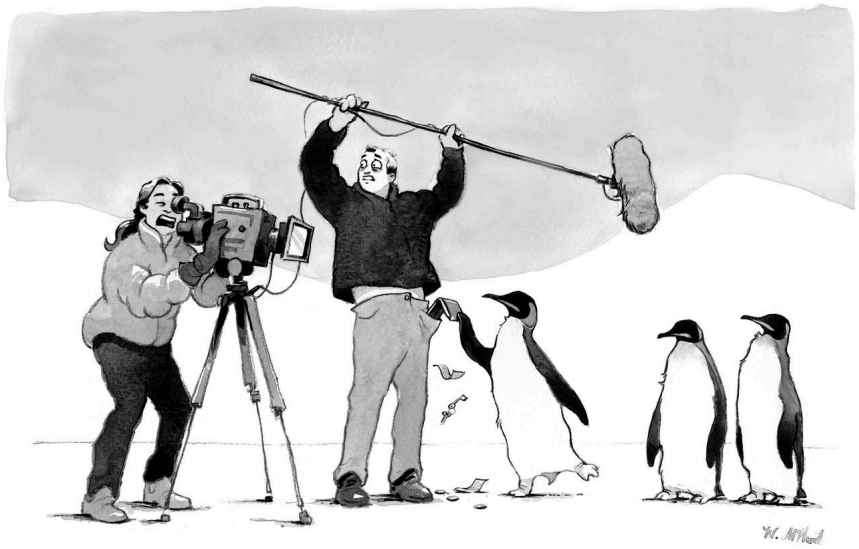
One recent morning, the pair convened in Brooklyn for a test excursion. They would be blindfolded and driven to a remote location and attempt to navigate to the Olive Garden for lunch. (They plan to pick a new destination, but for now the prototype is still calibrated to Olive Garden.) A Lyft arrived. The men put on sleep masks and groped their way into the car.

“It started with the Times Square Applebee’s,’ ” Goldberg explained. “It turns out there are two,” Nasopoulos said. So they pivoted—a lucky break. “So many people were attached to that Olive Garden,” Goldberg said. “People reached out, like, I want to get engaged there, and I want to use your compass.”

The Lyft reached its destination, and the men stumbled out. They removed the blindfolds. A large bird strutted toward them. “Oh, my God, there’s a turkey,” Goldberg said. “Shall we turn this puppy on?” They began walking, following a red pointer on the compass over hills, past boats on blocks, and by some clucking chickens. Near a driveway flanked by lion statues, Nasopoulos ventured, “I think we’re in New Jersey.”

Then they passed a sign for the Staten Island Mental Health Society. “That makes me think we’re on Staten Island,” Goldberg said. Now there was the problem of the sea passage. Goldberg approached a couple on a bench. “I’m trying to get to the Olive Garden in the middle of Times Square,” he said. “I’ve got a compass that points me there. But there’s obviously water.”

The man answered, “You take this path straight past the baseball stadium, you get on the Staten Island ferry. You take the ferry, and you end up at the Battery. You take Broadway straight up to approximately Forty-seventh Street, and you’re at the Olive Garden.”



“Just let it happen. We can’t interfere with nature.”
Cartoon by Will McPhail

“Fantastic,” Goldberg said.

After their crossing, they walked up Broadway for a bit, then hopped on Citi Bikes. Talk turned to Olive Garden’s cease-and-desist. The public had rallied to their cause. “For months, every time Olive Garden would post on their own channels, the comments would be flooded with people saying, ‘I don’t know how to get to your location! Please help me!’ ” Goldberg said.

They hadn’t yet decided on the alternative. Burger King wanted in. A mortuary school sent a pitch. (“We are located above the hard rock Café in Times Square. I shit you not.”) Ripley’s Believe It or Not! was interested—“They want to put us in the book,” Nasopoulos said—as was someone representing the country of Bosnia. Their favorite was the Times Square Margaritaville. The men had encouraging discussions with the company but then got ghosted.

What if Margaritaville resurfaced? “I mean, do we respect ourselves?” Goldberg asked.

The compass hand twitched, and the men found themselves outside the Olive Garden. They entered an empty bar area and then took an

escalator to the dining room. At the host stand, Goldberg announced, “We followed a compass to get here!”

“From Staten Island,” Nasopoulos said. “We saw a turkey!”

“All right, your table’s gonna be right over here. Enjoy,” the hostess said.

“She didn’t care at all,” Goldberg said. “Not one bit.” The men tore into some breadsticks. The compass sat on the table. The needle flicked back and forth. ♦

Zach Helfand is a staff writer at The New Yorker.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/olive-garden-is-the-real-true-north

In the Clubs

Ellen Allien’s Hill of Sound

On a trip to the Cooper Hewitt museum, the techno d.j. reflects on her latest album, “New Life,” and on how Michael Jackson and ABBA haunted her Berlin childhood.

By **Nick Paumgarten**

October 5, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You’re reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

Ellen Allien is an electronic musician, d.j., and producer who has adopted the mantle “the matriarch of Berlin techno.” In 1992, she was one of the first women to play a set at Bunker, known as the “hardest club on Earth,” situated in a former Nazi bomb shelter (which now, completing the cycle, houses a private art collection). She also had residencies at the foundational clubs E-Werk and Tresor. She launched her own label, BPitch Control, in 1999, and continues to make records and to stage parties around the world, as a committed maven of the nocturnal underground.

So it was beguiling to see her out in the sunlight on East Ninety-first Street on a recent afternoon, walking past the Spence School for girls, and close enough to the Russian consulate to hit it with a currywurst. She was with a friend named Markus Stich; they started a fashion line together twenty years ago. Allien had on black running shoes, billowy black *hakama* pants, and a black T-shirt that read “Sexy Genius.” She had a silver stud between her front teeth and blond pigtails and assorted tattoos. Stich—dark beard, curly hair—wore custom-cut denim and a purse over his shoulder.

Allien was in town to launch a new album, “New Life,” and to perform at Public Records, in Gowanus, but she’d been lured to the Upper East Side to see two exhibits at the Cooper Hewitt museum: one of industrial photography (machines, masses of shiny metal) and another called “Art of Noise,” full of bygone devices for listening to music. Together, the exhibits approximated a strand of techno’s origins.

“So someone was living here, in this house?” she said, as they entered the museum, which was formerly Andrew Carnegie’s mansion. A local tried to explain the concept of the robber baron. “This man was so rich, *ja*?”

In 2016, Allien performed a free concert in Cuba. “They all thought because I’m a d.j. I was born rich,” she said. “Keyboards,

equipment, records, everything is so expensive. But you don’t have to be rich to be a musician.”

Allien, born Ellen Fraatz, grew up in West Berlin, before the fall of the Wall. Her father left when she was two, and so she and a sister were reared by her mother, who worked in social services and often left them home alone.

“My mom got us an electric organ,” Allien said. “I was singing and trying to find the notes. Wasn’t correct always, but it was fun. It is where my hobby started. I was, like, six or seven. I was listening to a lot of American music. My mother was listening to Pink Floyd, Cat Stevens. Also Nina Hagen, an important singer from the East. I listened to Michael Jackson, ABBA, all this pop music on TV.” She went on, “I remember the eighties. I felt like I was in a cage, because West Berlin was surrounded. I could hear shooting in the forests, military exercises.” In 1988, while spending an uncaged year in London, she came across the acid-house scene and heard electronic music for the first time. Soon after she returned to Berlin, the Wall came down, and the music and the ethos took root in the derelict tracts of the newly unified city. She made a life of it.

Techno wasn’t like rock or hip-hop; women weren’t so widely overlooked or scorned. “The scene was very queer. The women were very respected in Germany, because it was all women after the war,” she said. “My favorite d.j.s are women.”

Upstairs in the Carnegie mansion, Allien and Stich peered at old stereo equipment. A 1970 Brionvega cable radio receiver, like a silver cake box with knobs, stopped her cold. “I want to touch it,” she said. She leaned in toward an egg-white 1963 Dieter Rams radio-and-phonograph combo. “That’s an eye-catcher. I used to see it in the secondhand shops.”

Downstairs, in Carnegie’s wood-panelled library, an artist named Devon Turnbull had set up a “listening room,” with a handmade

stereo system at one end. Allien and Stich sat on a bench in front of gigantic speakers, out of which came lush, hypnotic minimalist music.

“Steve Reich,” Stich said. “ ‘Music for 18 Musicians.’ I love this one. Very genius.” They listened intently. After ten minutes, they stood. A woman by the door gasped: “Ellen Allien! Oh, my God, I can’t believe you’re here.” Her name was Ruyin, and she was going to Allien’s gig the following night. She asked Stich to take a photo of them together.

When they’d parted, Allien said, “I think I’m going to start my set tomorrow with Steve Reich. Something to open the heart and to open the brain. It’s like climbing a hill of sound.” ♦

Nick Paumgarten, a staff writer, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2000. He is the author of “The Intangibles: Friendship, Fatherhood, and the Love of the Game” (November, 2026).

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/ellen-alliens-hill-of-sound

The Boards

Ernie Bushmiller’s Sunday Morning, Live

In 1976, the artist behind the “Nancy” comic was slighted on “S.N.L.” A new Off Off Broadway show tells the tale of the day after.

By **Emma Allen**

October 5, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You’re reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

Usually, an appearance on “Saturday Night Live” is a validation of cultural relevance, even coolness. Less so if your name appeared on the show in a list, from 1976, of “people who dolphins are definitely more intelligent than.” Among the sub-dolphinites were Prince Charles, Joe Louis’s accountant, and Ernie Bushmiller, the artist behind the beloved, then maligned, and recently re-celebrated comic strip “Nancy,” which he drew every day for nearly fifty years.

A new play—one-man-plus-one-woman, Off Off Broadway, at the Mark O’Donnell Theatre, in Brooklyn—takes place the morning after the “S.N.L.” slight. It depicts Bushmiller, aged seventy, desperately trying to cook up cartoon ideas despite various zany interruptions.

The other day, the writer and star of “A Morning with Ernie Bushmiller,” Tom Gammill (who previously wrote for “S.N.L.,” “Late Night with David Letterman,” “It’s Gary Shandling’s Show,” “Seinfeld,” “The Simpsons,” and is himself a cartoonist), prepared to rehearse in his Greenwich Village pied-à-terre.

“I bought my first original Bushmiller in 1983, at the Armory,” Gammill, who has a husky Yogi Bear-ish voice, recalled. It features a self-portrait of the cartoonist interrogating his characters (Nancy, her pal Sluggo, and her aunt, Fritzi), and cost three hundred bucks. The caption: “Who’s got a gag for me today?” “In the eighties, nobody took Bushmiller seriously,” Gammill went on. His wife would only let Gammill hang his collection in a dedicated Ernie Bushmiller room.

Gammill said, “He drew the strip for the gum-chewers, but now it’s really the intellectuals and the hipsters who are into it.”

“It was slobs over snobs originally, but now it’s actually snobs appreciating slobs,” Owen Kline, the thirty-four-year-old director of the play, agreed.

Gammill relayed Bushmiller's biography: "Ernie dropped out after the eighth grade and then he flipped a coin. He was either going to work on a cruise ship or at a newspaper." He became an "office boy" at the New York *World*—"one of his first jobs was doing the grids for crossword puzzles, so he got good at drawing straight lines." He also dropped out of art school, where he'd labored over a bust of Dante and was rivals with Reginald Marsh.

Gammill, who wore a loose gray suit and Bushmiller's own wide striped tie, snapped into character: "It sure is dusty living here in 1976!" A TV played a slideshow of "Nancy" cartoons and archival photographs that corresponded to lines in the script. "Now, I know what you're thinkin'," Gammill-as-Bushmiller continued. "Why did this crumb-bum cartoonist, this ink-stained idiot, this nitwit with a pen nib invite us here?"

He puffed a fake cigarette, then sang a tune titled "Who's Got a Gag for Me Today?": "Sluggo lives by himself. Nancy's his goil. He was feeling all alone, then in dropped a squoil!" When he gets a call from the cartoonist Dik Browne ("We don't joke about his name") regarding the "S.N.L." list, Gammill's Bushmiller exclaims, "It just proves my point—TV stinks!" He later refers to himself as "the Lawrence Welk of cartoonists."

Fast-forward through a lot of sound effects and prop work and a Dewars-induced dream sequence in which a violent, ventriloquist-dummy Sluggo shrieks, "Live from New York, you're dumber than a dolphin, Ernie!" Throughout, the actress Lauren Servideo comes and goes, playing Nancy, a hippie, Bushmiller's wife, an editor, a coed, a turtle, a teen-aged Tom Gammill, a rat, and a visitor from the future.

Finally, the dagger to Bushmiller's heart: he receives a copy of "The World Encyclopedia of Comics," which states, "Bushmiller's work is best read from the start until 1940, when *Nancy* began. . . . The remainder will always be on tap at an institution or two for the

stalwart and devoted research student: the rest of us would be happier forgetting it.”

After rehearsing, Servideo and Gammill took a bow, to applause from Kline and Steve O’Donnell, a prolific TV-comedy writer who is co-producing the play. Gammill and O’Donnell (and O’Donnell’s late twin, Mark, for whom the Brooklyn theatre is named) met at the *Harvard Lampoon*, fifty years ago. There, they cold-called Bushmiller (his wife picked up) and Fred Gwynne, a Poonie who became famous playing Herman Munster.

“He was a great cartoonist, too,” Kline said, of Gwynne. “Incredibly lavish drawings.” Kline previously wrote and directed “Funny Pages,” a movie from 2022 about the perils of meeting your cartoon heroes, and is also a cartoonist. He’d doodled during the rehearsal. “That’s my Tom,” he said, pointing at his pad. “Looks more like Harold Ramis.”

O’Donnell reminisced about loving “Nancy”: “As a teen-ager, I knew that you were supposed to sneer at it, but it has a place in your heart that’s hard to shake.”

At the end of the play, Princess Sluggo Fritzi Blixblip III travels back from the year “exety-ex-exty,” to tell Bushmiller that future civilizations adore him. Not only that, she assures him: “By the time Chevy Chase is the age you are now, a new generation of comics will hate him.” ♦

Emma Allen is The New Yorker’s cartoon editor and edits humor pieces on newyorker.com.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/ernie-bushmillers-sunday-morning-live

Reporting & Essays

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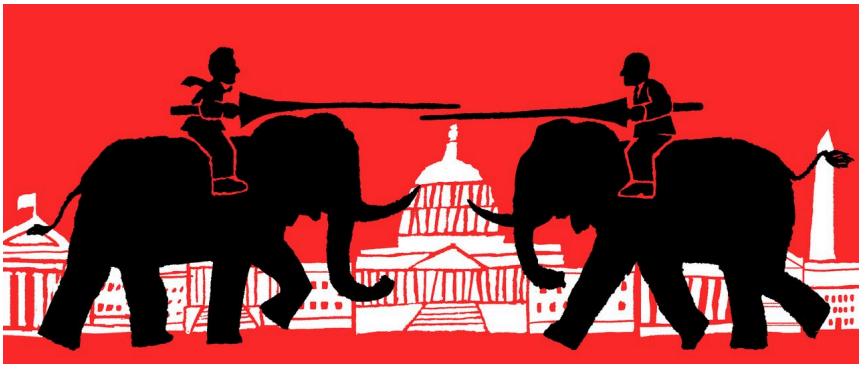
The Political Scene

The Battle for the Post-Trump Right

For decades, the Heritage Foundation was a conservative powerhouse. Can it stay relevant in the influencer age?

***By** Emma Green*

October 5, 2026



"This is a civilizational moment for this republic," Kevin Roberts, the president of Heritage, said. Illustration by Ben Hickey

A group of neatly dressed young people gathered in the auditorium of the Heritage Foundation headquarters this summer to observe the cherished rituals of the D.C. internship. Most of the girls had long skirts and updos; the boys wore suits that didn't quite fit—still trying Washington on for size. From a low stage, Kevin Roberts, the president of Heritage, bantered with them about the constants of D.C. life: their softball team, the ice-cream social scheduled for that afternoon. Then he launched into a professorial discourse about the nature of conservatism. The interns scribbled intently in Heritage notebooks, branded with the Liberty Bell.

For decades, a very specific kind of right-wing kid has dreamed about working at Heritage. "I would look at the building in awe," a former member of the management team told me. The organization has an annual budget of about a hundred million dollars, and more than four hundred million in reserves. Its properties take up an entire city block on the Senate side of the Capitol. Heritage is the

undisputed giant of the conservative-think-tank world—less a tank than an aircraft carrier.

When Roberts took over as leader, five years ago, he was eager to adopt an aggressive posture. Suddenly, managers were speaking in sports metaphors (*We're going to move the football!*) or martial ones (*We're here to do battle!*). A longtime Heritage scholar named Mike Gonzalez told me, earnestly, "What I say about Kevin—it's kind of like watching 'Braveheart' every morning."

Roberts is tall and bald, with the permanently gregarious manner of someone who, in another life, could have been a politician. Several people described him to me as a man's man: he drives a black diesel pickup and wears cowboy boots to formal functions. When the *Guardian* reported old allegations that he had killed a neighbor's noisy dog, he took to making jokes about knowing how to use a shovel (though he denies killing the dog). He is skilled at selling Heritage to donors, and also at cultivating right-wing staffers in Washington. Lately, however, the latter crowd has been causing him trouble.

As one former Heritage executive put it, the young people who came to D.C. used to be the good kids—teachers' pets, class presidents, suck-ups. Now the right-wing dreamers deride their elders as "Reagan Zombies" and "BoomerCons." They're sick of the establishment program of forever wars and free trade, open borders and kowtowing to China. Their movement—known as the New Right, or sometimes as the Realignment—is virulently antiwar, eager for mass deportations, and less interested in lowering corporate taxes than in helping families afford houses and cars and kids. "It's Elizabeth Warren in the streets, economic nationalism and strong Christianity in the sheets," one D.C. think-tanker told me. The kids these days don't watch Hannity; they follow Tucker, or maybe Nick Fuentes, the young white nationalist who mocks women and calls Hitler "cool." "Everyone in the mainstream on the right is puzzled about what to do about the

angry young men," a former Heritage scholar told me. "It creates nasty fractures in the coalition."

An intern at the event this summer asked Roberts what he thought about Carlson and Fuentes. "Never heard of them," Roberts joked, to laughter. Then he acknowledged that their appeal was something "we have tried to grapple with here." He said that it was a reaction to "what is perceived to be the inauthenticity of institutions, that institutions can't be trusted." He mentioned colleges, churches, and the government—not think tanks, but perhaps it was implied. "The way some people, a few people, make sense of that is a burn-it-all-down mentality," he said.

Once the midterms have passed, the conservative movement will have to reckon with its impending post-Trump reality. Different factions want vastly different futures—and, in recent years, these factions have been fighting for control of Heritage. One important dividing line is whether you're under or over the age of forty-five. Roberts's hope is to influence the next generation: to disciple them, to direct their anger, to correct their excesses. "This is a civilizational moment for this republic," he told me recently. "Whatever battles exist out there, whether they're political battles, ideological battles—God forbid, more real battles—let them be in my lifetime, right now, so my kids don't have to fight them."

Heritage was founded in the nineteen-seventies—an age of relative institutional stability, when it was taken for granted that experts could shape history. For decades, it was the clubhouse of the conservative movement, and its alumni took powerful positions across D.C. "It's almost like we were missionaries," one former staffer told me. "We were so driven by the belief that what we were doing was important and meaningful." In 2010, the organization launched Heritage Action for America, a lobbying group that enforced ideological purity on Capitol Hill by shaming apostate Republicans. "There was a consensus, in the 2000-to-2012 era, of what principled conservatism stood for," Tim Chapman, a former

head of Heritage Action, told me. It was more or less the Heritage mission statement: limited government, free enterprise, individual freedom, traditional values, and a strong national defense.

When Donald Trump gained political prominence, in 2016, Heritage leaders recognized his potential—yet the organization slumped during his first term. Kay Coles James, who took over the foundation in 2018, was an uninspiring fund-raiser, and her politics were, as one senior think-tank leader put it, "bog-standard Republican establishment." During the protests of 2020, James, who is Black, called racism "a fatal wound" in America's history. Tucker Carlson helped lead a push for her ouster.

The board of trustees wanted Heritage to be relevant again, and Roberts seemed to offer *MAGA* credibility. He had been the president of a Catholic college in Wyoming and the head of the Texas Public Policy Foundation—an "America First" guy who understood the grass roots. He came up in the populist wing of the Republican Party; as a young man in Louisiana, he organized a rally for Pat Buchanan, the nationalist Presidential candidate. For a time, Roberts changed course, cheering for the Iraq War, but now he describes himself as a "recovering neocon."

The details of Roberts's policy preferences weren't necessarily that important to Heritage's supporters. The foundation has a lot of small and mid-tier donors: the Midwestern plumber who sold his business to private equity, or "retired parents who got involved because of their woke grandchild's public school," as one former Heritage analyst said. They know what they believe: Reagan was good. Free markets are good. Trump is good. They do not follow baroque conflicts online, or "sit around and think about the ultimate questions," the former member of Heritage's management team said. As long as you could mail out pictures of Roberts with Trump, it seemed, the donations would keep flowing.

D.C. Republicans, however, were watching Roberts for signs of his true loyalties. One of the leading New Right groups is National Conservatism, or NatCon. After taking over, Roberts declared at a NatCon conference, “I come not to invite National Conservatives to join our conservative movement but to acknowledge the plain truth, that Heritage is already part of yours.” His book “Dawn’s Early Light,” from 2024, reads like a tribute to the Party’s restless young populists, full of scornful references to “wax-museum conservatives.” He insists that American life has become rigged against working people. “The U.S. economy today bears the same resemblance to a system of free enterprise as a movie set does to a real stock exchange,” he writes.



“Look, when our parents tell us to get off our devices and go outside, they’re basically telling us to raise hell.”
Cartoon by Colin Tom

In 2023, Roberts invited Carlson to give the keynote speech at Heritage’s fiftieth-anniversary gala. Carlson spoke on the importance of political bravery. “You look with disdain and sadness as you see people you know become quislings,” he said. “You see them going along with the new new thing, which is clearly a

poisonous thing, a silly thing, saying things you know they don't believe, because they want to keep their jobs."

For all Roberts's populist leanings, he has been preoccupied with restoring Heritage's role as the convener of the conservative movement. "One of the big themes that haunts Dr. Roberts is *the big tent*," a former researcher at the foundation told me. A Trump Administration official with close ties to Roberts said that Heritage was roughly divided into the same factions as the rest of the conservative movement. There were the *MAGA* types, who were inclined toward nationalism and cultural conservatism. There was the wing known as *MIGA*, a dismissive shorthand for Make Israel Great Again: scholars who favored a hawkish, pro-Israel foreign policy. And there were the Freedom Conservatives, libertarians with a religious streak.

Roberts tried to appease them all. After Hamas attacked Israel in 2023, for example, he agreed to let Heritage host a new conservative task force on antisemitism. But taming the organization proved difficult. Heritage shared the unruly qualities of a liberal-arts college: legacy fiefdoms, ornery academics, outright defiance of authority. Scholars guarded their territory fiercely; there aren't many jobs that pay conservative intellectuals generously to write books and argue about ideas. To Heritage veterans, it was obvious that the institution's president should defer to in-house experts. But that left Roberts trying to coax nearly four hundred employees into alignment. "There are not a lot of people who are loyal to the management," a second former staffer told me. "They're loyal to the brand of Heritage."

The organization's culture involves a great deal of process fetish, a predilection more closely associated with socialists than with suit-coat conservatives. The most telling example is its "one voice" policy. Traditionally, when Heritage was preparing to put out a paper or take a position, staff would assemble in a conference room, where the lead authors would present their view and then get

hammered with questions. The ritual could be gruelling—occasionally, there was shouting—but, once Heritage took a position, no one at the organization was allowed to criticize it in public. In previous eras, “there would be one or two, maybe three positions that would come out in a year that I didn’t like,” John Malcolm, a former head of Heritage’s legal center, told me. After Roberts arrived, Malcolm started disagreeing with two or three a month.

Roberts pushed Heritage to promote a pro-family culture, dignified work, an America First national-security policy, and “a virtuous, patriotic citizenry.” He was particularly preoccupied by the declining birth rate. “A family should not be a luxury good,” he writes in his book. He asked Heritage scholars for a major paper on how the government could encourage people to get married and have kids.

The cultural conservatives in the domestic-policy office loved the idea, but the free-market economists were resistant. Richard Stern, who was then the head of the econ office, was charged with mediating between the teams. There were endless meetings, which often devolved into freshman-dorm-level debates about first principles. Stern told me that some of his colleagues “view the ultimate goal of human life as to serve some kind of collective,” adding, “I really can’t justify spending my time and effort serving collectivist ends.” Roberts grew impatient. A former high-level Heritage employee recalled a tense meeting: “Kevin slams his hand down on the table, and he says, ‘Give me my fucking policy paper!’ And Richard Stern just sort of sits there, smiling, and proceeds to tell him all the reasons why he wasn’t going to.”

As the internal resistance deepened, the circle around Roberts grew tighter. Many people left or were fired. The legal center, which leaned toward free-market ideas, had its budget frozen and was forbidden to replace employees who left. A former policy staffer recalled going to work on a Monday morning and finding that a

handful of colleagues were simply gone—casualties of the campaign to eliminate what one executive called the Heritage deep state.

Since the Reagan years, Heritage has proposed policies for each potential Republican Administration. For the 2024 election cycle, Roberts envisioned a sprawling initiative called Project 2025. The goal was to unite the conservative movement; more than a hundred organizations eventually contributed. The plan grew to include a database of prospective hires and some nine hundred pages of policy proposals—but its ambition ended up being a liability. “It was a great, unifying project,” a former Heritage staffer who now works at a competing shop said. “Yet it was obnoxiously branded in the public with the bell.” Roberts aggressively advertised his supposed influence in Trumpworld, saying that Heritage was “institutionalizing Trumpism” and guiding such efforts as abolishing the Department of Education and deporting illegal migrants. At some point, Democrats decided that Project 2025 made a great campaign pitch for their side. Kamala Harris called it “a plan that would return America to a very dark past.” Trump distanced himself, claiming, “I know nothing about Project 2025.”

After Trump was reëlected, Heritage found itself in a difficult position—because of Project 2025, and also because Roberts had supported Ron DeSantis early in the Presidential primary. As think tanks jockeyed to place people in the Administration, Heritage seemed marginalized. “I’m sure we got résumés from them,” a former senior White House official told me. But “arm’s length, at best.”

Heritage wasn’t entirely aligned with the new Administration on policy. Roberts was resolutely pro-life, and Trump had backed away from a federal abortion ban. Heritage had also become a vocal opponent of Big Tech, even as tech C.E.O.s sat onstage at Trump’s Inauguration. “Kevin and the leadership at Heritage really decided that, look, President Trump is President,” a conservative

leader told me. “To be on the team, you’re not allowed to criticize Donald Trump.”

All this internecine disagreement was largely invisible to outsiders. Thanks in part to Democratic messaging, liberals had come to see Heritage as the malign force behind the new Administration. A comedian from North Carolina named Cliff Cash started recording earnest YouTube videos arguing that Trump had stolen the election. “Project 2025 is really sinister,” he told me. “I haven’t read the entire thing. But, when you look at the policies that real Americans hate the most right now, it’s all from the Heritage Foundation.”

Cash began assembling protesters at Heritage’s headquarters, in what became weekly gatherings. Employees recalled that demonstrators used racial slurs, insulted a staffer’s weight, and even told one young woman, as she headed to Mass, that they hoped she got raped in the ass by a cactus. Cash filmed himself trailing a young man in khakis, shouting, “Looks like we’ve got another pretty-boy Nazi fascist.” Cash told me, “I don’t have any grace or patience or forgiveness for anyone working there. I don’t care if they’re twenty-eight or they run the fax machine.”

On protest days, Heritage arranged for black S.U.V.s to shuttle staff through the crowd. Roberts rallied employees by blasting “The Star-Spangled Banner” at the demonstrators. Inside the building, the protests created a sense of unity. “Nothing brings people together more than this feeling of us versus them,” the former policy staffer told me. But the agitators outside also distracted from the divisions inside. “When everyone is screaming at you, ‘You’re all Nazis,’ you don’t look around at people in the building who you don’t know very well and be, like, ‘So what do you think of Nick Fuentes?’ ” the staffer said. “It turns out, maybe we should have.”

In October, Carlson invited Fuentes to his home in Maine. The two had been feuding, after Fuentes accused Carlson’s father of being in the C.I.A. Now they recorded a podcast episode in Carlson’s

barn, under an eighteenth-century Scottish deer-antler chandelier, and afterward they posed for a photo with Carlson's arm draped paternally around Fuentes's shoulder. The backlash was immediate across the conservative movement. "No to the groypers," the podcast host Ben Shapiro wrote on X. "No to cowards like Tucker Carlson, who normalize their trash."

Heritage didn't have an obvious connection with the controversy. Earlier that year, though, it had signed an advertising contract with Carlson, who had agreed to read out potted endorsements on air. ("It's not just thinking, it's doing, and if you want to support it go to Heritage dot-org slash Tucker.") By the time of the Fuentes interview, the deal had expired, but no one at Heritage had removed the page promoting the partnership. As criticism grew, someone in donor relations panicked and took the page down. A few sharp observers called Heritage out on X for distancing itself from Carlson.

The official narrative of what happened next—which has been the subject of furious debate in Washington—hinges on a man named Ryan Neuhaus, Roberts's chief of staff. Neuhaus is a devout Mormon who got married while at Brigham Young University and later became a staffer for the Utah senator Mike Lee; now, in his early thirties, he has four children. "He's a big-brother figure to younger kids in the Realignment," the former researcher told me. Behind the scenes, though, he also has a reputation for scrapping. One former Republican Senate staffer told me, "His view was that the hard-line approach was always right." When Neuhaus joined Heritage, in 2025, he showed little patience for those who resisted the new regime. He liked to respond to critiques by quoting aloud from Roberts's book.

After the Fuentes interview, Neuhaus started seeing criticism of Heritage online and "got Kevin riled up," according to the second former staffer. In a meeting the next morning, Neuhaus told senior staff that the foundation should make a statement. Some were

confused about why that was necessary, but they agreed to have Neuhaus propose language for approval. Instead, according to leaders at Heritage, he wrote a draft and took it directly to the foundation's video-production team. Roberts recorded a video, and it went online.

For those who hadn't been following the Carlson-Fuentes controversy, the video was likely hard to parse. "I want to be clear about one thing: Christians can critique the State of Israel without being antisemitic," Roberts tells the camera. "Of course, antisemitism should be condemned." But, he adds, conservatives shouldn't have to support a foreign government, no matter "how loud" the "mouthpieces" of the "globalist class" are in Washington. "We will always defend our friends against the slander of bad actors who serve someone else's agenda," he says. "That includes Tucker Carlson." He condemns "the venomous coalition" that is "sowing division" by attacking Carlson. He abhors Fuentes's ideas, he adds, "but cancelling him is not the answer."

At first, New Right leaders circulated the video approvingly. "Kevin's a leader for this moment, and I've never been more excited about where our movement is headed," Nick Solheim, the C.E.O. of American Moment, which trains conservative staffers, wrote on X. Curt Mills, the editor of The *American Conservative*, told me that the video was "a forthright statement in defense of free speech" and an avowal that "anti-Zionism is not ipso facto antisemitism."

Others on the right thought that Carlson had gone too easy on Fuentes, and that Roberts had covered for him. Some found Roberts's language to be rife with antisemitic tropes: "globalist class," "venomous coalition." Still others felt that the response had been strategically dumb. "It was like killing a gnat with a sledgehammer," the former staffer who's now at a competing shop said.

In my conversations with right-wingers who remain angry about Roberts's video, though, the most prevalent concern was about Carlson himself. On his podcast, he focusses relentlessly on Israel's sins and has interviewed Holocaust deniers. "Tucker is the leading promoter of antisemitism on the right," Yoram Hazony, a founder of the NatCon movement, told me. "This isn't about foreign policy. It's about causing people to hate Jews."

At Heritage, the leadership was surprised by the intensity of the reaction. Roberts put out another lengthy statement on X. "Nick Fuentes's antisemitism is not complicated, ironic, or misunderstood," he said. "It is explicit, dangerous, and demands our unified opposition." The replies were divided between trollish memes and a repeated question from movement conservatives: *Thanks, but what about Tucker*?

As the argument festered, a Heritage tax expert named Preston Brashers tweeted a Norman Rockwell painting of a lone dissenter in a town meeting, and captioned it "*NAZIS ARE BAD*." Brashers was nervous about speaking out—"I was shaking as I tweeted," he told me—but colleagues supported him. "Almost half a million Americans died defending this very simple premise," Amy Swearer, a Second Amendment expert, chimed in. On the other side, Brian Darling, a lobbyist who used to work at Heritage, tweeted that "virtue signalling employees" should resign, adding that their departure would be "addition by subtraction." Neuhaus retweeted this.



“We could try that new sidewalk that opened up in midtown.”
Cartoon by Ellis Rosen

The conflict had transformed from a fight over a tweet about a podcast to a replay of the supreme moral conflict of the twentieth century. Nearly everyone on the board recognized the need to act, according to one former member. Roberts called Neuhaus and confronted him. Within days, Neuhaus had resigned.

Soon afterward, Roberts spoke about the episode at an internal town hall. “I made a mistake, and I let you down,” he said. “And I am sorry for that. Period. Full stop.” He confessed to not knowing that much about Fuentes. “I actually don’t have time to consume a lot of news,” he said. “I consume a lot of sports.” Yet, even as he gestured at magnanimity—“The buck stops on the desk in my office”—he didn’t entirely accept the blame. “When the script was presented to me, I understood from our former colleague that it was approved,” he said. The implication was clear: Neuhaus had lied, and he had to go.

Many on the right seemed happy to accept this story. Josh Hammer, a conservative commentator, told me that the video “was dripping with such blatant antisemitic overtones that it really does raise the

obvious question as to how no one had realized this. Or was it actually the intention of the individual who wrote it, Ryan Neuhaus?”

But at certain happy hours, in certain group chats, a different story emerged. In this version, Roberts’s phone had been deluged after the Fuentes interview with messages pushing him to respond, and he wanted to make a statement immediately. Although Heritage leaders later suggested that Neuhaus went rogue to make that happen, several people told me the organization was too tediously bureaucratic for that to be possible. “There was no way for a product like this to move without significant review,” the former researcher said. I heard from a number of people that senior leaders had been on a Signal chat, editing the script and then vetting the final video.

Within the New Right, the situation came to be viewed as something like a coup attempt. Mike Howell, a visiting scholar at Heritage who also runs a group called the Oversight Project, told me, “It was about the Republican establishment attempting to take back Heritage, because they had lost it.” The grandest theory was that it was a manifestation of the fight over the Presidential nomination in 2028: Carlson had been an early supporter of J. D. Vance, and so the attacks on Heritage were really an attack on Vance and his allies. Among leaders of right-wing institutions in Washington, the senior think-tank leader added, “there was an understanding that it was very important for Kevin to survive this.”

Several people told me that Neuhaus signed an N.D.A. before leaving; he was a young father with a mortgage, and he needed the severance. But that meant the official version of events was left without rebuttal. Especially in the New Right’s young-guy group chats, this was an epochal event. “It lingered for months of us talking about how much we hate Heritage,” the former researcher told me. “I will not go to a Heritage event ever again.”

Despite the controversy, Roberts never took the video down, and he never actually disavowed Carlson. The number of Heritage's media appearances plummeted, from more than a hundred a week to a handful. A kind of paralysis set in among the trustees, the former board member said. Six left, including Abby Spencer Moffat, an heiress whose family had given generously to Heritage.

Members of the antisemitism task force that Roberts had approved decided to break ties with the foundation. One Jewish donor told me that he had originally supported Heritage because it framed antisemitism as incompatible with the American way of life. But, he said, "anyone that supports Tucker I cannot associate with."

The fiercest critics of Heritage were those who had spent years waging ideological war within the organization. Former staffers recall that, at one meeting, Robert Rector, a longtime anti-welfare expert, said, "I don't know why we have all these little Nazis around." Emma Waters, a staffer in her twenties, shut her laptop and walked out, choking back tears. (Rector, who was summoned to H.R. afterward, says that he called only one person a Nazi, and that he was joking.)

Stern, the economist, started quietly talking with colleagues about leaving, and so did Malcolm, the head of the legal department. When Heritage found out, it fired Malcolm and one of his deputies. Stern mounted a mass exodus: fourteen people, constituting almost three full departments.

All of them had arranged new jobs at Advancing American Freedom, a small think tank founded by the former Vice-President Mike Pence after the events of January 6th put him at odds with much of his party. In December, 2025, alone, A.A.F. raised fifteen million dollars to hire unhappy Heritage staffers. When I visited its headquarters, the atmosphere was triumphant, at least for an office. On one wall, a giant screen displayed media appearances by Malcolm and by Swearer, one of the "*NAZIS ARE BAD*" tweeters.

Pence wasn't around, but his office was convincingly staged: framed family portraits, a heavy wooden desk, a Windsor chair from the White House. Tim Chapman, the former Heritage Action leader, is now the president of A.A.F., and I met him in his office across the hall. He's forty-eight, but his décor evoked an earlier time, with posters of Calvin Coolidge and The *Saturday Evening Post*. "There's an institutional impulse, always, to be perceived as hip, or on the cutting edge," he told me. "We're overweighting the influence of young people." He pointed to a poster behind his desk of "Ronbo"—Ronald Reagan's head superimposed on the body of Sylvester Stallone. "At some point I was, like, You know what, if they're going to call me a Zombie Reaganite, lean in," he said.

During the first Trump Administration, there were well-publicized battles between *MAGA* and the Never Trumpers. Chapman wasn't really part of those squabbles. After the events of January 6th, though, he rejected what he saw as a growing attitude on the right: that "power politics was the way to go if you wanted to save the country."

Howell, the Heritage visiting fellow, refers to A.A.F. as "Mike Pence's retirement home." The organization is generally viewed with skepticism by movement conservatives. "I wish the mass exit of people didn't go to Mike Pence," the former member of Heritage's management team told me. "The best and the brightest of the conservative movement are saying Heritage is too New Right," but their argument was undermined "because it was Pence, and he has such a mixed reputation."

A.A.F. has picked fights with the President, but they're not the ones you'd expect from the Never Trump crowd. During the 2024 Republican National Convention, when the Party downplayed its opposition to abortion, A.A.F. pushed for a more pro-life stance. The effort was unsuccessful, but A.A.F. demonstrated that it was willing to brawl. In some ways, its existence proves that it's still possible to fund-raise off the hope that the G.O.P. will return to a

previous version of itself, and that the think-tank ecosystem can thrive without any obvious policy results. “We’re not trying to project to everybody that we’re having meetings over at 1600 Pennsylvania on a weekly basis,” Chapman said. “You have to be really realistic about where we are right now. Principled conservatives are not in the driver’s seat of the Republican Party.”

After Carlson interviewed Fuentes, he retreated to his hunting camp and disconnected from the outside world. About twelve hours later, though, he checked his phone and saw a supportive text from Roberts: *I will never forsake you.* Carlson told me that the two of them were friendly, but not exactly friends; they had gone hunting together once. “It’s not his job to stand up for me,” Carlson said. But then, “the next thing I know, he’s taking it all back. And I felt like, Boy, I wish I’d talked to him.”

Carlson is the embodiment of a certain ethos on the right: a wartime mentality of trusting your trench mates and ceding no ground. He maintained that Roberts should have stuck to his initial statement, saying, in essence: “ ‘Look, I don’t agree with everything Tucker Carlson says, but he’s my friend. And, moreover, if you don’t like what he said, let’s debate it. We’re not going to cancel people.’ ” Carlson told me, “If he’d said that and gotten fired by the board anyway, he would have had a lot of opportunities to go from there, and a lot of money to fund them with. Cowardice is punished. And that’s what that was. That was cowardice.”

Carlson famously got ejected from Fox News—and thus from the conservative establishment—in 2023. Since then, he has been free to pursue his apparent obsessions, including the existence of demons, the evils of Christian Zionism, and Vladimir Putin. He has also become a fierce critic of institutional conservatism; this summer, he announced that he is leaving the G.O.P. “The academic guys, they’re always quoting Churchill, Roosevelt, ‘The Man in the Arena,’ ” Carlson said. “They speak in martial language, which is

always a tip that they have no experience of violence.” Heritage, he said, exists primarily to sustain itself: “It’s an electric windmill. It’s a self-licking ice-cream cone.”

The drama around Heritage nearly obscured the interview that inspired it. The episode goes on for two hours, and Carlson spends the first half gently teasing out Fuentes’s story and his sense of grievance. At several points, Carlson disavows antisemitism (“Going on about the Jews helps the neocons”), but he doesn’t ask Fuentes to do so. This outraged listeners, but Carlson told me that his approach was strategic, a way of getting a reflexive troll like Fuentes to engage. He pointed to an interview that Piers Morgan did with Fuentes around the same time. “Fuentes is faster, because he’s younger—that’s just biological,” he said. “But he also has a grasp of postmodern irony that Piers doesn’t. Piers is, like, *You question the Holocaust*, and Nick goes, ‘Well, is it too soon?’ ” Carlson argued that, if he’d confronted Fuentes, the interview would have devolved into spectacle. “It’s pretty easy to get suckered into a situation where you devalue your own case, sap your own moral authority, and basically look like some geezer lecturing the kids on how hip-hop is evil.”

For Carlson, the more important exchange comes toward the end of the conversation. Fuentes is going on about how women are “frumpy” and “obnoxious” and “overweight.” Women, he argues, are “very simple.”

“Have you ever lived with one?” Carlson says. Fuentes admits that he has not—and then listens, seemingly intent, while Carlson explains the virtues of actual relationships.

Carlson told me that he didn’t press Fuentes on his admiration of Hitler and Stalin because he thinks Fuentes is not credible when he talks about history. But, he said, if Fuentes’s young male fans think that “women are all bitches, or sluts, or whatever, that’s way more real than, like, your opinions on Hamas.”

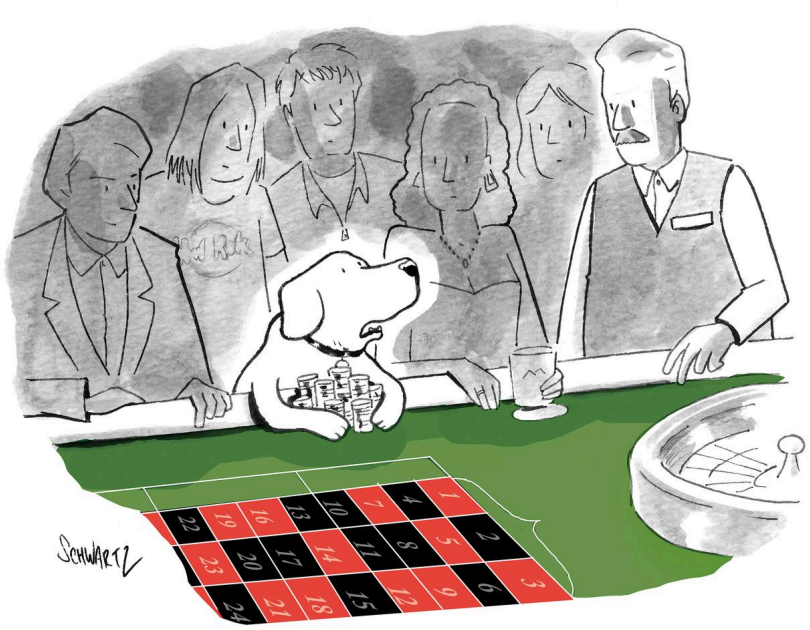
Carlson's network claims that his podcast episodes draw an average audience of fifty-six million across platforms. His fans don't necessarily care that he hosts offensive guests, or that he has reversed some of the opinions he previously expressed on Fox; his willingness to violate the pieties of mainstream media is part of his appeal. In a low-trust environment, Carlson said, "it's O.K. to be wrong. But any kind of lying or deceit or cloaked motives or falseness is just not acceptable."

One night in D.C., I had dinner with Chris DeMuth, who spent two decades as the president of the American Enterprise Institute. He picked the restaurant: Ocean Prime, an expense-account spot with leather booths, where the cheapest steak on the dinner menu is sixty-six dollars. DeMuth, who is eighty, seems like precisely the kind of old-school Washington type young conservatives mock these days. Instead, he's spent the last stretch of his career as an unlikely leader of the New Right.

Over dinner, DeMuth described becoming disenchanted with ideas that he'd advocated for decades. "I would have told you, 'What we want is free trade and globalization, and we'll all get rich, and we'll take that money and we'll spend it on job training for men who have been thrown out of work,' " he said. "I had these little talking points. But they didn't really lead anywhere." He grew more concerned about what he saw as the erosion of American culture, with mass migration, the hollowing out of communities, and the weakening of marriage and gender norms. "Young people look at the old people and say, 'Look at the world you left us,' " he told me. "They think conservatives didn't fight hard enough. And I've come to the view that they're right."

People across the political spectrum feel that parts of adult life that used to be taken for granted—a house, a spouse, stable employment, children—are now out of reach. The former Republican Senate staffer told me that there's a pervasive feeling among his young colleagues on the right: "You've been lied to."

Received political dogmas ring hollow; instead, young conservative intellectuals are reaching for traditional faith, or for transformative legislative agendas. There's a lot of worry in Washington about the extent to which the right has been infiltrated by Catholic monarchists and Fuentes devotees. But even less radical young people are grappling with who they can trust and what they believe.



"Put it all on gray."
Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

Hazony, the NatCon leader, told me that conservatives "find themselves in the crossfire between a genuinely anti-Jewish, antisemitic movement in one corner of the Party and a pro-Jewish, pro-Zionist wing that is often overreaching in its rhetoric." He sees Heritage, inflected by Roberts's populist sensibilities, as crucial for guiding the movement to "where the majority of the Republican Party is": they "want to see a rejuvenated American nationalism which is not bigoted and hostile to important communities." Hazony, an Orthodox Jew who lives in Jerusalem, remains concerned about antisemitism on the right. But he resists panicking that Gen Z antisemites will take over. "I don't think it's anywhere near time to give up on that generation of Republicans," he said. "There's a very good chance that Tucker is going to lose."

Soon after the Heritage video came out, Hazony contacted Roberts and offered to help. The two have a long-standing relationship; Roberts has called Hazony “my closest Jewish friend in the world.” In the past year, Hazony said, people at Heritage have come to “understand what their role is, which is to hold together and build out the Protestant-Catholic-Jewish alliance at the center of the Party.”

This spring, I visited Roberts at Heritage. His office was the size of a comfortable studio apartment, with cream-colored drapes and walls the hue of orange wine. Hints of Roberts’s Texas background poked through the formality: a cowhide pillow on the couch, a giant Alamo flag over the desk. Roberts, wearing his signature cowboy boots, greeted me with practiced warmth, but he was unmistakably nervous. Not long into my visit, his assistant poked her head in, to make sure he didn’t want to bail on the interview.

When I’d spoken to Heritage staffers, they’d frequently used the words “move on” about the video. But it was clearly on Roberts’s mind. He brought up “videogate” before I did. “Obviously, I stepped in it,” he said. I asked why, after all these months, Heritage still hadn’t taken the clip down. “I’m a historian,” he said. And, besides, “if I were to take it down, it would still exist.”

Roberts acknowledged a larger problem. “There’s a very troubling rise of antisemitism on the right,” he said, adding that he intends to “really make sure Heritage continues to be a vital institutional player in that work against antisemitism.” In think-tank fashion, the organization has initiated studies on the origins of right-wing antisemitism, the first of which is expected this month; it plans to hold events and possibly propose legislation around the findings. Roberts told me that he had called up the presidents of Catholic colleges—he wouldn’t tell me which ones—and “privately excoriated” them for hiring professors he sees as antisemitic. This spring, Heritage hired Luke Moon, a Christian pastor who co-chaired the antisemitism task force, as a visiting fellow. When I

asked Roberts whether he had been persuaded that Carlson is exacerbating antisemitism in America, he smiled, as though he had been waiting for the question. “Yes,” he said.

The consensus in Washington is that Heritage has been weakened by the events of the past few years. Although its fund-raising e-mails describe sweeping influence—“The Trump administration has already implemented the majority of our policy recommendations”—the former senior White House official dismissed these claims as “preposterous on every level.” He added, “They’re not coming in and doing briefings. No one’s paying attention to what they’re saying.”

Yet a number of insiders argued that the crisis consolidated Roberts’s power. The senior think-tank leader told me, “The low-key win in all of this for Kevin is now he gets to remake everything.” This spring and summer, Heritage announced a series of big hires, and in May the board gained four new members, all allies of Roberts: Hazony, two businessmen, and Mollie Hemingway, the editor-in-chief of the conservative publication The *Federalist*. The board seems to be sticking by Roberts. “This is a hard job, and he’ll probably make other mistakes,” Larry Arnn, the president of Hillsdale College, who is a trustee, told me. “He will do what Churchill said: proceed from failure to failure to ultimate success.”

In December, Heritage quietly débuted what it calls its Cornerstone principles. The foundation has always issued grandly named bullet points summarizing its agenda. But the Cornerstones downplay many of its longtime watchwords—individual liberty, limited government, free enterprise. Instead, they emphasize the “civilizational” questions that Roberts is interested in.

After years of delay, Roberts’s family-policy paper came out in January. Heritage scholars proposed a marriage “bootcamp” for cohabiting couples, government-seeded investment accounts with a

special benefit for those who marry before the age of thirty, and child-care tax credits for married stay-at-home parents, something that Vance has recently championed. Roberts said that the paper demonstrated a restoration of the one-voice policy. He told me, “When we say, ‘This is one of our priorities,’ you may not work against that priority while you’re at Heritage. And that was happening, and that’s not tolerated here.”

Roberts told me that he is trying to use his influence in Washington differently now. “I learned late last year I don’t have to comment on everything,” he said. “There can be real power in speaking truth to power—whispering.” Unlike many right-wing populists, Roberts has completely backed Trump’s war in Iran. “No president in the 47-year history of the Islamic Republic has been willing to take it on like President Trump,” he tweeted in June. (Last month, Trump hailed him as “a fabulous guy.”)

Heritage is already working on Project 2029, and the staff sent me some promising fund-raising numbers: Roberts, they say, raised ninety-seven million dollars in 2025, outperforming previous years. Yet the foundation still has to contend with the increasingly uncertain role of think tanks in Washington. Ideas travel differently now; it’s not clear that panel discussions and policy briefs actually drive the political agenda. There’s a lot of focus on influencers as the true source of political power. Eric Teetsel, a former Heritage executive, told me that “think tanks need to think of themselves more like management companies.” The podcast may be the white paper of our time.

Not everyone wants to entrust the movement to social-media personalities. Chapman, the head of A.A.F., told me, “The correction for today’s craziness is for people to go and look for institutions that they trust.” Delano Squires, a Heritage scholar whom Roberts described to me as a future face of the right, offered a similarly institutionalist view. “Among the influencer class, I’ve definitely seen the embrace of a robust white-identity politics that

has served as a counterweight to what people would call woke politics," he said. But Squires, who is Black, argued that a lot of the toxicity on the right lives exclusively online. "Exercising discernment in how we engage in the influencer class is a sign of wisdom," he said.

Institutions like Heritage face a puzzle. They want the kind of audience loyalty that someone like Carlson generates—yet much of Carlson's appeal lies in being anti-institutional. Roberts told me that Heritage's solution to the problem of "solid, faithful, daily-Mass-attending guys listening to nonsense" is to create "better things to follow and to watch and to listen to." Heritage hopes to cultivate its own internet stars, by using in-house experts to move public opinion. "My job is to help build a platform for those people," he told me. The specifics are still a little vague, though —"that's what we're trying to figure out," he said.

During the intern event at Heritage, Roberts called for an incremental approach to winning over the next generation. Ultimately, he said, America will change as its people change—as citizens live lives of virtue, build families, lift their communities. This kind of plan is "not quick enough for the people who want to burn it all down," he acknowledged. But Heritage wants to persuade young people "that there's hope ahead." He showed only the slightest hint of uncertainty: "Let's say that we at Heritage are wrong about that." About the possibility of hope, or of persuading young people, it wasn't clear. "We're still going to do the same thing," he said. "What other option is there?" ♦

Emma Green is a staff writer at The New Yorker who covers politics and academia.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/the-battle-for-the-post-trump-right

Our Local Correspondents

Year of the Horse

After a young tourist was killed in a Central Park carriage accident this summer, the City Council is considering whether to ban horse-drawn carriages forever.

By **Michael Schulman**

October 5, 2026



Carriage horses are unique in the urban menagerie. They aren't wildlife, and they aren't on display in the zoo. They are neither pets (dogs, cats) nor pests (rats, roaches). They are workers. Illustration by Tomi Um

Romanch Mahajan, an eighteen-year-old from Pathankot, India, visited New York City with his family in June to celebrate his high-school graduation. A tall, ambitious kid who loved cars, playing guitar, and collecting Jordans, Romanch dreamed of expanding his father's travel business. On the third day of their trip, the Mahajans went to Central Park and took a ride in a horse-drawn carriage.

The carriage—white, with tufted seats—was pulled by a seven-year-old horse named Samson, who had been working in the Park for just six weeks. The carriage paused at Cherry Hill, a plaza with a cast-iron fountain (originally a drinking spot for horses). The driver, Ertan Gokdepe, stepped out to take a photo of the family in their seats. Suddenly, Samson bolted. The Mahajans screamed for help, and as they rounded a corner Romanch's mother was thrown to the ground. Shouting, "Mom!," he lunged to save her and fell out. He landed on his head.

The horse ran south toward Tavern on the Green, where the carriage collided with another and toppled over, smashing to pieces. Hours later, Romanch was pronounced dead, from blunt-force trauma. Samson was retired, and Gokdepe was put on indefinite suspension. "We lost a gem," Romanch's shell-shocked father, Deepak, told me. "We were four, and we came back as three."

The tragedy couldn't have come at a worse time for the Park's carriage industry, which has weathered a series of fiascoes. One hot day in August, 2022, a carriage horse named Ryder collapsed in Hell's Kitchen, en route to his stable. As cops sprayed him with water, onlookers took videos, aghast at his emaciated ribs. Ryder was sent to a farm upstate, where, after a seizure, he was euthanized; a necropsy revealed that he'd had leukemia. His driver, Ian McKeever, was tried and acquitted for animal cruelty. At the time, a bill to ban carriage horses was before the City Council. After the incident, it was renamed Ryder's Law.

The industry tightened its equine-first-aid protocol, but the disasters kept coming. In May, 2025, a runaway horse crashed into a fleet of parked pedicabs. That August, a mare named Lady died of an aortic rupture at an Eleventh Avenue intersection. Days later, the Central Park Conservancy, which had remained neutral on the issue of carriage horses, formally endorsed the ban, citing hazards to public safety, damage to the roadways from horseshoes, and

sanitation problems (manure). Nevertheless, Ryder's Law died in committee.



Christina Hansen, the carriage industry's most vocal champion, with her horse Oreo. "Horses have been with us for six thousand years," she says. "Civilization as we know it is a partnership, and what you're seeing is an attempt to sever this partnership."
Photograph by Lucia Vazquez / NYT / Redux

This past January, an elderly horse named Destiny, apparently spooked by an e-bike with a cargo trailer, darted into Sixth Avenue traffic. In May, a startled horse reared and knocked over a carriage. On June 9th, a horse named Deniz nibbled from a Japanese-yew bush, which is highly toxic to horses, and dramatically expired. But it was Romanch's death, a week later—the only human fatality from a New York carriage accident in modern memory—that juiced the political momentum. The revived ban, now called Romanch's Law, is headed for a vote this month and would phase out the carriages by June, 2028. It has twenty-nine co-sponsors and the support of the Council's speaker, Julie Menin; Mayor Zohran Mamdani is likely to sign it. The Mahajans are suing the city for a hundred and five million dollars. (Their lawyer, Sagar Chadha, is a co-founder of Hindus for Zohran.) In July, a crowd gathered at Cherry Hill for a memorial. Deepak, calling from India, told the mourners that his son, a vegetarian, had "sacrificed his life for the animals."

Carriage horses share Central Park with owls, blue jays, red-tailed hawks, mallards, red-eared sliders, chipmunks, Virginia opossums, raccoons (who make cameos at Shakespeare in the Park), a small and elusive community of coyotes, and more than two thousand Eastern gray squirrels. But they aren't wildlife, and they aren't on display, unlike the snow leopards, sea lions, and penguins at the Central Park Zoo. They are neither pets (dogs, cats) nor pests (rats, roaches), making them unique in the urban menagerie. They are workers.

Perhaps that's why our relationship with them is so fraught. To those who want the horses liberated, they're indentured servants, forced to haul tourists around in a Sisyphean loop. To others, horse-drawn carriages, like cobblestone streets, are charming throwbacks to New York's past, enshrined onscreen in "Barefoot in the Park" (Jane Fonda and Robert Redford), "Sex and the City" (Carrie and Mr. Big), and "The Muppets Take Manhattan" (Kermit and Miss Piggy). If they disappeared, after more than a hundred and sixty years, what would we lose?

After Romanch's death, a poll sponsored by the Conservancy found that sixty-eight per cent of New Yorkers favored a carriage ban. "There are always people who have a nostalgia for the clip-clopping, but the Park is way, way beyond that now," Betsy Smith, the head of the Conservancy, told me. The pandemic, she explained, "supercharged" use of the Park, which now hosts forty million visitors a year. Carriages compete with joggers, bicyclists, whizzing e-bikes, and Alicia Keys-blasting pedicabs, all of which can startle a horse.

For a quirky municipal issue, the battle over carriage horses has had an outsized impact. This summer's flurry of horrors is the latest chapter in decades of warfare, with millions of dollars spent, a mayoral election swayed, and opposing sides that are dug in and combative. In July, the City Council held a public hearing on Romanch's Law that lasted nine hours. Among the speakers were

the Mahajan family, animal-rights activists, the actor Edie Falco, the perpetual mayoral candidate Curtis Sliwa, a drag clown, a woman who read a poem from the perspective of the horses (“Hey, man, take a look at what you’ve done / Beat us, ride us, so you could have fun”), and carriage drivers in top hats, including Christina Hansen—a shop steward for Transport Workers Union Local 100, which represents the drivers—who informed the Council, “Horses helped build this very building two hundred years ago.”

Weeks later, I met Hansen at Clinton Park Stables, on West Fifty-second Street, the largest of the industry’s three remaining stables, with ninety horses in residence. Built in the eighteen-eighties, it was once owned by George Washington Plunkitt, the Tammany Hall figure who coined the term “honest graft.” The carriages, festooned with Knicks decals and artificial flowers, are custom-built, mostly in Indiana. Up a ramp were two floors of horse stalls. “The animal-rights people say, ‘Oh, the poor horses are forced to walk up the steep, steep ramp!’ ” Hansen said. “In the wild, it’s called a hill.”

It was a steamy August day, so the horses were benched: they cannot work when the temperature is above eighty-nine or below nineteen degrees. They must be between five and twenty-seven years old, and each gets two annual vet checkups, plus five weeks of mandated vacation at pastures outside the city. They work nine-hour shifts, so most carriages have two or three rotating horses. Since the Second World War, there has been a fixed number of medallions—sixty-eight—which get sold (they’re roughly three hundred thousand dollars apiece) or inherited. There are around a hundred and eighty licensed carriage horses and about a hundred and fifty regular drivers; some own medallions, while others, like Hansen, are independent contractors who split their earnings with their employers. Hansen drives three horses: Sherman, Oreo, and Joker, who was on break in Pennsylvania.

On the second floor, horses were munching hay in their stalls, which are required to be at least sixty square feet, large enough for them to turn around and lie down. (Most carriage horses come from Amish country and are already trained to pull vehicles.) Hansen led me down a hallway, horse eyes staring blankly from either side, and up to the “manure room.” The manure is a source of compost for the Giorgi Mushroom Company, in southeast Pennsylvania. “If you have eaten mushrooms on the East Coast, you can thank a carriage horse,” Hansen said brightly.



“Wow, this could drastically reduce drug prices if it ever falls into the wrong hands.”
Cartoon by Paul Noth

Hansen had a long ponytail and the weariness of a battle-tested warrior. The daughter of a sociologist and a journalist, she was raised in Lexington, Kentucky. “I didn’t grow up having horses, but I grew up loving horses,” she said. She learned to ride when she was in grad school, at U.N.C.-Chapel Hill, where she studied French history. She considered writing a dissertation on horses and French national identity after the Revolution, but instead she followed her husband, an architectural historian, to Philadelphia, and answered an ad for carriage drivers. During her first week, in 2006, she was driving her horse Bud near Independence Hall when a woman in a car yelled, “Animal cruelty!” “It just stunned me,” Hansen recalled. “Who would ever look at this horse, happily

walking down the street—Bud was a workaholic, he loved his job—and feel like there's anything wrong with that?"

Hansen became "a working-horse advocate," she said. She started by arguing with people online, but it became clear that the main fight was in Central Park. Her new driver friends in New York had identified their enemy—a well-funded group called New Yorkers for Clean, Livable, and Safe Streets, or *NYCLASS*—and wanted to infiltrate a meeting. Since Hansen was from Philly and unknown to the activists, the drivers asked her to go undercover.

One night in 2011, she arrived at 520 Eighth Avenue and gave an alias. She was surprised to find that the location was the A.S.P.C.A.'s headquarters—an apparent conflict of interest, she thought, since the A.S.P.C.A.'s Humane Law Enforcement Division also policed the carriage industry. (The N.Y.P.D. took over animal-cruelty enforcement in 2014.) There, she got her first glimpse of Steve Nislick, a parking-garage mogul who is the key backer of *NYCLASS*. "He seemed like a rich guy who's very confident that it's just a matter of time until he got this done," she said.

Soon, Hansen attended—and secretly recorded—a second meeting, where Nislick mouthed off about spinning politicians, including Christine Quinn, then the City Council's speaker and a staunch backer of carriages. Hansen leaked the audio to the *Post*. In 2012, she moved to New York and started picking up shifts in Central Park. ("My carriage-versary is tomorrow," she told me.) After another driver's horse bolted in Columbus Circle, Hansen defended the industry to news crews. She is now the carriage drivers' foremost champion.

Hansen had explanations for each of the recent mishaps. Ryder, the horse who collapsed in 2022, was gaunt because of undetected leukemia, not because he was underfed—but once the "angry mob" showed up, she said, "everyone and their brother" tweeted videos. Deniz, who was poisoned by Japanese yew, was the victim of

whoever planted “murder bushes” along the carriage route. (Betsy Smith called it a “very common shrub.”) Hansen views Romanch’s death as a “freak, tragic accident” and insisted that his family was being “exploited.” Samson, the horse, bolted suddenly, giving credence to a theory that he was shocked by stray voltage underfoot—Hansen noted that Cherry Hill is often muddy, perhaps wetting underground cables, and that the Conservancy “refuses to fix it.” She also floated a conspiracy theory. “If you wanted to cause an accident,” she said, you could scare a horse with an ultrasonic dog whistle. Wasn’t the timing a little *too* convenient, with the ban before the City Council? “The foot soldiers are fanatics,” she said of the forces arrayed against her.

I suggested that this was an existential moment for her industry. “It’s an existential moment for *human beings*,” she replied. “Horses have been with us for six thousand years. Civilization as we know it is a partnership, and what you’re seeing is an attempt to sever this partnership.” She sighed. “I get yelled at by younger people, ‘Leave the horses alone!’ That’s like saying, ‘Leave your dog alone.’ They’re domesticated. They want to be with us.”

A few weeks later, I met Hansen’s bête noire, Edita Birnkrant, at the Ritz-Carlton on Central Park South. A self-possessed middle-aged woman with straight dark hair, Birnkrant is the executive director of *NYCLASS* and the carriage industry’s most tenacious antagonist. Because the drivers know her on sight, she tries to stay incognito; she had pulled a Woodstock Farm Sanctuary cap low.

The plan was to rove the Park and document infractions. As we headed out, she pointed to lines of waiting carriages. “No one is taking rides,” she said. “That’s part of a larger trend around the world, that horse-drawn carriages are an obsolete business model. San Antonio, Texas, even voted to ban carriages. Chicago, Philadelphia, Mumbai, Barcelona. New York City’s actually kind of an outlier.”

From a hilltop, we peered down at the Park's West Drive, which was packed. "You can see how easy it is for frightening stimuli to spook a horse," Birnkrant said. Horses are prey animals, she explained, and their instinct is to run. She spotted a carriage going at a brisk trot—"He should not be going that fast"—and filmed a video. Then she noticed a driver taking a picture of *her*. "They spotted me," she said. Within minutes, I got a text from Hansen: "I'm sure Edita's telling you all kinds of tales!"

Her cover blown, Birnkrant wandered closer. Days before Romanch's death, she had spoken outside City Hall, warning that someone was going to get killed. "It's like the Greek Cassandra myth," she told me. "You're cursed. You know these terrible things are going to happen. You keep warning and warning, and you're ignored."

Birnkrant saw hazards everywhere: a little girl petting an unattended horse's nose, a horse with a bandaged ankle. "We see examples of badly cracked hooves, horses with leg problems," she said, snapping a photo. She locked eyes with a horse wearing a red feather headdress, like a Vegas showgirl. "It often feels like their spirits are broken," she said. "They have this metal bit in ten hours a day. And then they're forced back into these warehouse cells, with no pasture. Everything that would make life worth living for a horse is taken away."

Birnkrant grew up in Queens, the child of a single mother. Like Hansen, she couldn't afford horses, but she loved animals, especially cats. She was raised Catholic and was drawn to St. Francis of Assisi. She later got interested in the Indian concept of *ahimsa*, or nonviolence. After graduating from Queens College, she worked in publishing, but the book industry "didn't spark joy, let's just say." In 2004, she joined the nonprofit Friends of Animals and advocated for the protection of wild horses out West. But she grew concerned about the horses trudging to work right outside her office, on Columbus Circle.

She started protesting in the Park and became a prolific giver of sound bites. (February, 2008: “Valentine’s Day is one of the busiest days for carriage rides, but there’s nothing romantic about animal abuse.”) One carriage driver called her the C-word. The drivers complained that the activists harassed them and their customers. Birnkrant left Friends of Animals in 2016; its president, Priscilla Feral, told me that Birnkrant had resigned, adding, “I felt she needed to be better managed.” That year, Hansen submitted to law enforcement a video of Birnkrant and another advocate chasing her carriage, yelling at her passengers, “You can get your money back!” A court later issued a restraining order preventing Birnkrant and others from “aggressively accosting” passengers within nine feet. She joined *NYCLASS* in 2017.

Nowadays, she seldom protests. The Park is too “volatile,” she said; lobbying is more effective. She passed a statue of Simón Bolívar astride his steed. At Grand Army Plaza, a carriage driver called out, “I finally meet you in person.”

“Hi,” Birnkrant responded, unfazed. “How do you know me?”

“The whole industry knows you,” he said. They shared a laugh.

Birnkrant has cultivated a small army of “eyes and ears” who send her videos of injured-looking horses or negligent drivers. One of her informants, a pedicab driver named Helen David, pulled up, wearing braids and a “Work Hard Pray Hard” T-shirt. Carriage and pedicab drivers are often bitter competitors. David, a Namibian immigrant who has driven a pedicab for twenty-three years, suspects that the carriage drivers have retaliated for her collaboration with *NYCLASS* by cutting her bike cables and leaving her bad reviews online.

We hopped in David’s cab, and she cycled us north. Near Bethesda Fountain, Birnkrant pointed to some stopped carriages. “They’re not supposed to solicit here,” she said. She grimaced: “You smell

the horse urine." We passed the curb where Romanch fell. "Political gridlock has made it impossible to move forward," Birnkrant said. "It's tragic that it took a human death." But she was hopeful: "2026, in the lunar calendar, is the Year of the Horse."

New York City is still dotted with vestiges of its horsy past: hitching posts, boot scrapers, carriage houses. (Taylor Swift lived in one that sold for eleven and a half million dollars.) Dutch settlers brought horses to New Amsterdam on ships in 1625, to haul wagons and power sawmills. The city's first recorded hack license was issued in 1692, to a tavern owner named John Clapp. Horses fought on both sides of the Revolution. In 1776, George Washington commanded on horseback during the Battle of Brooklyn.

Horses fuelled the nineteenth-century city, lugging coal, bricks, ice, apples, beer kegs, mutton legs, and streetcars full of commuters. Equine-driven mass transit allowed the metropolis to stretch and sprawl. In 1823, there was a multi-carriage accident in Woodhaven, which Clay McShane and Joel A. Tarr, the authors of "The Horse in the City," call "possibly New York's earliest traffic jam." By 1866, the city had nearly a thousand horse-drawn cabs. Undertakers preferred black horses; breweries went for Clydesdales. The city bustled with saddlemakers, carriage painters, wheelwrights.

Horsepower helped build Central Park, which opened in 1858, crisscrossed with winding carriage roads and bridle paths. Carriage rides for tourists started in 1863, for twenty-five cents apiece. As Christina Hansen likes to say, Frederick Law Olmsted and Calvert Vaux "designed Central Park to be seen from the back of a carriage." Owning a carriage was a status symbol for the city's gentry, who promenaded through the Park in stately black broughams.

Not everyone saw horses as living machines. In 1862, President Abraham Lincoln appointed Henry Bergh to a diplomatic post in

St. Petersburg, Russia, where he saw a peasant whipping his horse and had an epiphany. Back in New York, he founded the American Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals. (Its seal, showing an angel brandishing a sword as a wagoner beats his horse, is affixed to Bergh's mausoleum, in Green-Wood Cemetery.) Bergh became a celebrity crusader, blocking commuter trolleys when the horses looked overworked—and then dragging the drivers to court.

In 1872, an equine influenza swept North America—the Great Epizootic—and New York ground to a halt. Thirty-six horses died per day on the streets of Manhattan. Avenues, piled with carcasses, went silent. The crisis laid bare the city's dependence on horse labor, pushing industrialists to adopt steam engines, which were cheaper and faster and couldn't get sick.



In "30 Rock," Alec Baldwin's character, Jack Donaghy, takes a fateful carriage ride with his mother, played by Elaine Stritch. Baldwin is in favor of banning horse-drawn carriages. "Some slavering, tired, old, overheated horse pulling your cart? I don't get the attraction there," he says. Photograph by Ali Goldstein / NBCUniversal / Getty

There were a hundred and thirty thousand horses working in Manhattan in 1900; by 1931, an official horse census counted less than eighty-five hundred. A correspondent for this magazine wrote, in 1927, "We heard a gentleman at the Horse Show the other evening say to his small son, 'Heigho, a horse and carriage, lad, observe it well. It is a fancy that has passed.' " Horses continued

transporting milk, laundry, and hotel baggage, but carriages became quaint outliers. “Not counting the Plaza coachmen, there are only about thirty horse-drawn carriages on the streets of Manhattan today,” *The New Yorker* tallied in 1943. Collisions between taxis and hansom cabs made news—tidy metaphors for the clashing of eras. The A.S.P.C.A. maintained a smattering of watering troughs, which New Yorkers would use to rinse stolen fish or as makeshift ashtrays.

By the sixties, the carriage industry was catching up to the hippie era. In 1966, the *Times* reported that “two pretty girls,” aged nineteen and twenty, were now driving carriages. By 1971, long-haired youngsters in purple pants and suède vests were embracing the profession as an alternative to straight jobs.

In the eighties, the carriage horse began to morph from nostalgia object to political football. During a heat wave in 1982, four horses died in three weeks. “Surely there are less sadistic ways to get around town,” one animal lover wrote to the *Times*. In 1985, a carriage was struck by a stretch limousine: Boss Tweed’s New York meets Donald Trump’s. Four years later, the City Council overrode a veto from Mayor Ed Koch to pass a bill banning carriages from rush-hour traffic and limiting horses’ shifts, as drivers grumbled that the rules would force them out of business. “They are taking away my life,” one said. “I will have to sell my horse to the butcher and burn my carriage.”

The issue got more contentious in 1992, when the Council passed a bill relaxing those restrictions. One councilman accused opponents of the measure of anti-Irish bias, because many of the carriage drivers were Irish immigrants. Mayor David Dinkins, a former A.S.P.C.A. board member, vetoed the bill at a tumultuous hearing that included testimony from Alec Baldwin, who had got into animal rights through his then girlfriend, Kim Basinger. On his way out, Baldwin quarrelled with a carriage driver and called him a “faggot.” (Baldwin says that the other guy said it first.) Years later,

Jack Donaghy, the character he played on “30 Rock,” described carriages as “rolling torture wagons for nature’s most dignified creature.” Baldwin told me,“If the carriage horses were gone, count to three and no one’s going to miss them. Some slavering, tired, old, overheated horse pulling your cart? I don’t get the attraction there.”

When Rudolph Giuliani became mayor, in 1994, he signed a compromise that pleased neither side but, to the relief of exasperated Council members, put the saga to rest—for a while. (Giuliani was more focussed on banning pet ferrets, which he called “little weasels.”) The issue reared up again in 2006, when a carriage horse named Spotty ran through six blocks of traffic before crashing into a station wagon on Ninth Avenue. Three people were hospitalized, and Spotty, who broke a leg, was euthanized. Mayor Michael Bloomberg was a staunch defender of the carriages, once summarizing his views thusly: “In our society, we have, from caveman times, used animals as part of our economy. We eat them.” But activists rallied at City Hall, this time calling for the industry to be not regulated but eliminated. In 2007, for the first time, a Council member proposed an outright ban.

Among the New Yorkers moved by the Spotty incident was Steve Nislick, then the chief executive of the real-estate firm Edison Properties. He and his wife, Linda Marcus, live at 25 Central Park West. (Years ago, they nurtured a family of peregrine falcons on their penthouse terrace, until the condo board objected. Nislick said, “We had Robert Kennedy, Jr.”—a lifelong falconer—“write a letter on our behalf.”) Marcus would walk their dog past the carriage horses. “It just looked like they weren’t healthy at all,” she told me. A friend invited her to a vigil for Spotty, and the couple soon got to know Elizabeth Forel, the founder of the Coalition to Ban Horse-Drawn Carriages. “We saw it as an opportunity to do something,” Nislick recalled. The next year, he started *NYCLASS*.

I met Nislick and Marcus one day at Bayboro Equestrian, a hundred-acre facility in Branchville, New Jersey. At the stable—a McMansion compared with the carriage horses' West Side tenement—they introduced me to Chance, a twenty-three-year-old black draft horse they acquired in 2010. Chance had been a carriage horse but developed a hoof ailment called laminitis. Nislick hired a private investigator to buy her, because he didn't think the owner would sell to him under his own name. He put Chance through rehab and rode her for eleven years. "She would have gone to slaughter," Nislick said.

Nislick is eighty-two, with a woolly voice and a bald head that he hid under a "*BAN HORSE CARRIAGES*" cap. He had been an avid rider, and has a list of injuries to prove it: broken elbow, broken shoulder (twice), broken ribs (ten), broken leg. He told me that he was attracted to the "mystique" of horses. "They're dangerous and they're sweet," he said. He isn't opposed to horses working. (The horses of the N.Y.P.D.'s Mounted Unit, for instance, are "under saddle and much better kept.") But he became convinced that carriage horses live under "abominable" conditions, and he was determined to free them.

Nislick grew up in South Orange, New Jersey, and joined his cousins' parking business in 1973. By the time he retired, as C.E.O., in 2012, he'd built up a parking empire and developed Manhattan Mini Storage, famous for its politically provocative billboards ("*YOUR CLOSET SPACE IS SHRINKING AS FAST AS HER RIGHT TO CHOOSE*"), which was sold, in 2021, for more than three billion dollars. The carriage industry has long suspected Nislick of having an agenda to develop the real estate occupied by the West Side stables, a charge he denies. "If the property was given to me for free, I wouldn't take it," he told me.

Early in Nislick's anti-carriage crusade, one activist suggested replacing carriages with antique-looking electric cars. Nislick thought it was a brilliant idea and drew up a business plan. He even

built a prototype—an electric-powered version of a 1905 Rolls-Royce—and drove it around the Park. (The carriage drivers, Christina Hansen told me, nicknamed it the Frankentank.) But the Conservancy was trying to subtract cars, not add them, and the idea fell flat. Nislick's wealth made him a convenient bogeyman for the drivers, who cast themselves as working-class underdogs. (Drivers make around sixty or seventy thousand dollars per year, including tips.) But his businessman's swagger also irked veteran activists, who were appalled when an early *NYCLASS* fund-raiser served a meat entrée.

As Nislick was cannonballing into the cause, the politics were getting knotty. In 2007, a city audit of the carriage industry found substandard conditions. Three years later, Bloomberg and Christine Quinn, the City Council's speaker, enacted reforms. When Quinn called the measures a "huge step forward," she was heckled by animal-rights activists, who were now dead set on a ban. The activists' tactics could be alienating. In 2011, protesters stormed the American Girl store on Fifth Avenue, which had been planning carriage rides for customers. ("Nice notion there, terrify little girls to make a political point," a *Times* editorial clucked.) That fall, the A.S.P.C.A. concluded that a carriage horse who had died was "likely suffering from pain" from stomach ulcers. Days later, the organization's lead equine veterinarian claimed that her supervisors had pressured her into playing up the horse's mistreatment.



Robert Redford and Jane Fonda snuggle in a carriage in a scene from the 1967 film "Barefoot in the Park."
Photograph from Everett

Non-Baldwin celebrities joined the fray, with Lea Michele, Pink, and Gloria Steinem advocating for a ban. On the other side was the Irish actor Liam Neeson, who argued in a *Times* op-ed, "Horses have been pulling from the beginning of time. It is what they have been bred to do." During Pride weekend in 2012, a carriage driver called a group of female activists handing out leaflets a "dyke convention," and the lesbian tennis player Martina Navratilova sent a letter to Quinn (who is also gay) blasting the drivers' "aggressive homophobia."

As the 2013 mayoral election neared, Nislick identified Quinn, who was assumed to be Bloomberg's heir apparent, as his main obstacle. *NYCLASS* staged "Anybody but Quinn" protests, trailing her from event to event. Nislick and his allies poured more than a million dollars into a *PAC* called New York City Is Not for Sale, which ran an attack ad featuring a smoke-filled room and a voice-over portraying Quinn as a shady dealmaker. The commercial did not mention horses. Quinn's favorability plummeted. Mike Morey, the Quinn campaign's communications director, told me, "Do I think it was a factor? Certainly. Do I think it was *the* factor? I don't know. But I certainly think it helped drive up her negatives." Nislick was blunter. "We knocked off Chris Quinn like *that*," he said, snapping his fingers.

The beneficiary turned out to be Bill de Blasio, the once obscure public advocate, who surged from behind to win the mayorship. As a councilman, de Blasio hadn't always supported a carriage ban, but he told me that his eyes were opened when an activist approached him on the City Hall steps. "He made this impassioned argument that it was a fundamentally inhumane thing to have horses in the middle of midtown traffic," de Blasio recalled. *NYCLASS* didn't endorse him in the primary—it just targeted Quinn—but Morey called *NYCLASS* "a front group for big donors

for Bill de Blasio.” The F.B.I. reportedly investigated the ad blitz; Nislick says that the agency never contacted him, but *NYCLASS* did pay a fine for violating campaign-finance laws in its support of two Council members that cycle. He and de Blasio were an odd match: the parking tycoon and the Park Slope progressive vowing to bridge the city’s class divide. As de Blasio took office, he promised to end the carriage industry on Day One, warning, “It’s over.”

It wasn’t. By the time a proposal was in front of the City Council, eleven months into de Blasio’s term, the Teamsters (which represented the carriage drivers before the Transport Workers Union) had organized against it. “We absolutely underestimated the opposition,” de Blasio told me. “We tinkered too much, when what we needed to do was just be fast and aggressive.” In 2015, he introduced an alternative plan that would shrink the industry and place the horses in a stable within the Park, but the Teamsters sank it at the last minute, humiliating the Mayor. Even de Blasio’s aides got sick of the issue, which the *Times* called “his Guantánamo, a problem that never gets solved.” Nislick, who’d been donating to the Mayor’s nonprofit, grew frustrated. After eight years in office, de Blasio managed to push through only minor reforms (like moving the hack line from Central Park South to inside the Park). “I was just miffed—why is this so hard?” de Blasio told me. “It almost felt surreal.” At the end of our conversation, he deadpanned, “Thank you for this therapy session.”

By the time of the 2025 mayoral election, thanks to steady lobbying and high-profile incidents, the politics had shifted such that *NYCLASS* didn’t need to meddle. All the major candidates—Eric Adams, Zohran Mamdani, Andrew Cuomo, Curtis Sliwa—favored a ban.

One sunny Saturday, the Park was bustling with tourists, most of them indifferent to the idling carriage horses. Near Fifth Avenue, twin sisters, visiting from Missouri for their fifty-first birthday, felt torn. “In the hot months, I don’t like them out here,” one said.

“In Missouri, we have a lot of Amish people who still use horse and buggy,” the other said. “They’re sharing the road with vehicles, and accidents happen.” A driver offered them a discounted ride, but they passed.

Penny and Hannah Widmer, a mother and daughter, were finishing a carriage ride with their two dogs. Hannah, a model and an equestrian, was in from Wisconsin for a photo shoot. “We’re fond of horses,” her mother said. “I don’t feel like it’s abusive or anything, as long as they take good care of them.”

“It’s like anything,” Hannah added. “There are some good people and some bad people.”

Inside the Park, I met Ahmet Bilici, who’s been driving a carriage for twenty-three years. He wore a top hat incongruously paired with cargo shorts and was feeding his bay horse, Chocolate, a bucket of oats. Where previous generations were predominantly Irish or Italian, Bilici, like many drivers these days, is from Turkey. He was raised on a farm in Hatay and got his veterinary degree in Istanbul. He came to New York in 2001 (“American Dream, you know?”), but his vet license wasn’t recognized here, so he worked in a supermarket before becoming a carriage driver. “This is top attraction in the world, Central Park horse carriage,” he said. “Like the World Trade Center, Statue of Liberty.”

Initially, he drove for hire, but he saved up his earnings and, in 2016, purchased his own medallion for around half a million dollars. (He bought Chocolate, a retired racehorse, the next year.) He hoped to pass the medallion down to his two sons and, someday, to his grandchildren. That’s why the proposed ban so angered him. Although Romanch’s Law includes career retraining (M.T.A. jobs, sightseeing-bus-tour positions), Bilici wondered how the city could possibly repay his life savings and the generational wealth he’d envisioned. “The city, they give us license,” he said. “So city is supposed to protect us.” If the bill passes, he half joked,

“maybe I’m going to jump down the Empire State Building.” Or sue.

Bilici blamed the Conservancy for setting the drivers up to fail. Chocolate was tied to a flimsy mesh fence. Why hadn’t the Park installed hitching posts? (Activists say that posts can cause panicked horses to break their necks.) He worried that the horses could wind up at a glue factory. (The bill would rehome them at sanctuaries, but the drivers are skeptical.) He insisted that Chocolate—“my buddy”—had it pretty good. “How many people have a minimum five weeks’ vacation a year?” he said. “I have *no* vacation.”

I asked for a ride ($72.22 for twenty minutes, $28.89 for each additional ten) and hopped onto the carriage’s plush lavender seat. As we clip-clopped north, Bilici railed against the surrounding chaos: pedicabs stealing his customers, e-scooters and bicycles darting too close. “I’m so *tired*,” he said. A bicyclist sped by, shouting, “Free the horses!” Bilici retorted, “His life better than your life, bro!” To the drivers’ opponents, the carriage horses are two-thousand-pound hazards, wild creatures enslaved in an urban nightmare. To Bilici, they’re the Park’s original settlers, now embattled by unfettered traffic and deep-pocketed lobbyists.

From the shaded seat, I tried to teleport back to Edith Wharton’s time, imagining myself as a fashionable gentleman flaunting my brougham. But I kept getting snapped back to the present by the jangle of traffic and Bilici’s grievances and a guy playing the Super Mario theme on a melodica. It was clear that carriage horses, and the romance they promised, were getting edged out of the Park, but whose fault is that? If the ban goes through, for better or worse, Central Park will be one step closer to everywhere else in New York City: a place where once there were horses. ♦

Michael Schulman, a staff writer, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2006. He is the author of “Oscar Wars: A History of Hollywood in Gold, Sweat, and Tears” and “Her Again: Becoming Meryl Streep.”

Annals of Money

The Battle to Pass a Billionaire Tax

Most Democratic voters say that they favor a wealth tax, but a California ballot initiative has plenty of liberal opponents.

By Nicholas Lemann

October 4, 2026



Many Democratic politicians and some union leaders oppose the tax, which would be the first of its kind in the nation.
Illustration by Cleon Peterson

It wasn't so long ago that Silicon Valley was, to use its own language, a major node in the Democratic Party's network. The Valley's origins were in developing electronic equipment for corporations and the military, but with the dawning of the age of the personal computer, half a century ago, it began to adopt the vernacular of anti-organizational hippie culture. It seemed entirely appropriate that a canonical text of the early internet, "A

Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace," was written by a Grateful Dead lyricist, John Perry Barlow. For a time, the PC, the internet, and social-media networks all seemed to be vehicles for personal liberation and grassroots political empowerment. The first two Democratic Presidents during the Valley's apotheosis, Bill Clinton and Barack Obama, presented themselves as technology-friendly futurists, and the Valley supported their campaigns and helped staff their Administrations.

Things have changed. The Valley has, for many people who live there, gone from a white-collar paradise to a locus of high-stress workaholism and unaffordability. Its formerly liberal-seeming titans put on suits and ties and dutifully lined up on the dais at Donald Trump's second Inauguration. Elon Musk, the man who introduced Americans to electric vehicles, spent the early months of 2025 as an agent of destruction within the federal government. Earlier this year, he became the first person with a net worth of more than a trillion dollars. In August, Mark Zuckerberg, of Meta, signed off on a settlement with forty-seven states and the federal government totalling as much as seventeen billion dollars, in a case about the harms that his social networks are inflicting on children and teen-agers. Across the country, candidates from both parties are campaigning against the construction of data centers powering the artificial-intelligence boom—which is another source of national anxiety about Big Tech.

I recently met with Bruce Cain, a political scientist at Stanford, at a restaurant in Woodside, a lovely small town not far from the tech companies' headquarters, where the median price of a house is around four million dollars. "California had a love affair with the technology companies," he told me. "It wasn't just Steve Jobs. It was Musk, too—people fell in love with the Tesla. There was a romantic belief that they were going to do good, that if we got rid of all the rules we could create a new society where everything would be perfect. There was a naïveté, and a feeling that you could make money and do good at the same time. For the last five years,

it’s been clear that’s not working. I don’t know anybody driving a Tesla who isn’t ashamed.”

Cain went on, “What happens to lovers who get betrayed? They get angry.” One consequence of this disillusionment is that, on November 3rd, Californians will vote on Proposition 40, a ballot initiative that would impose a one-time, five-per-cent wealth tax on billionaires, which is understood to be aimed principally at Silicon Valley executives. If the measure passes and goes into effect, which is far from a sure thing, it will amount to the first time that a government in the U.S. has successfully taxed the assets, rather than the income, of extremely rich people as a class. The initiative’s authors have estimated that the tax would fall on as few as two hundred people and would generate a hundred billion dollars in revenue for the state. This is a fairly sleepy election year in California—Xavier Becerra, a Democrat, is cruising to an easy win in the governor’s race, and only three of the state’s fifty-two congressional districts are competitive—but Proposition 40 is a spectacular exception. It is likely to be among the most expensive political fights this year, with spending, mostly against the initiative, running well into the hundreds of millions of dollars. Several of California’s best-known tech billionaires, including Peter Thiel and the founders of Google, Sergey Brin and Larry Page, have already left California, partly in anticipation of Proposition 40, and they have been warning that many of their peers will follow. This campaign may be the purest policy manifestation of a left-populist energy that has been on the rise for years, and has recently started to produce more electoral victories. And it will make wealth taxes an unavoidable topic in the 2028 Presidential race—by which time Anthropic and OpenAI will likely have gone public, creating a new cohort of highly visible billionaires. Last month, six Nobel Prize-winning American economists issued a statement in support of Proposition 40, saying that it “may well come to be seen as a turning point in the battle between democracy and oligarchy.”

In politics, large forces build up over time, but specific events can arrive suddenly and unexpectedly. Two years ago, nobody was predicting Proposition 40, and now it's here, a big, glorious mess. Although the father of the proposal, Dave Regan, is the president of a union, the labor movement is bitterly divided over the effort. Very few Democratic elected officials, and no Republicans, have endorsed the initiative. Governor Gavin Newsom, who is term-limited and a presumed Presidential candidate, is a major opponent. And other Democrats who are thinking of running for President in 2028 are likely watching the Proposition 40 drama nervously. Most Democratic voters say that they favor higher taxes on billionaires. But, if California is any indication, proposing a wealth tax will alienate the tech donors who have been crucial to the Democrats' ability to compete with Republicans in some races. There is no obvious way to escape this dilemma.

People often talk about our times as a second Gilded Age. During the first—the term was coined by Mark Twain and Charles Dudley Warner to describe the rise of industrial fortunes after the Civil War—the country had, by modern standards, a very small national government and very low taxes. In 1879, a social reformer named Henry George published a book called "Progress and Poverty," which argued for remedying the era's excesses by replacing all existing taxes with a single tax on land, which was a main form of wealth at the time. The book sold three million copies in the United States during the eighteen-eighties and nineties—more than any other book except the Bible—and double that worldwide. In Britain, "Progress and Poverty" outsold Shakespeare. In 1886, George ran for mayor of New York City and got thirty per cent of the vote, finishing ahead of a young Theodore Roosevelt.

Instead of imposing a wealth tax, Congress passed a national income tax, in 1894, but the Supreme Court deemed it unconstitutional. (A clause in Article I says that "direct Taxes shall be apportioned among the several States which may be included within this Union, according to their respective Numbers," which

the Court interpreted as a ban on the federal government, as opposed to the states, taxing individuals.) Establishing the federal income tax required a constitutional amendment: the Sixteenth, which was ratified in 1913, at the height of the Progressive Era. “In terms of the federal government’s operations, the Sixteenth Amendment was the most dramatic change in the written constitution in the nation’s second century,” the Yale historian Mark Peterson writes in his new book, “The Making and Breaking of the American Constitution.” It shifted economic power from state governments to Washington and created a stream of revenue that, over time, would fund expansions of the federal government which the Progressives had dreamed of, namely regulatory agencies to curb business excesses, along with social-welfare programs for the elderly and the poor.

But it wasn’t simply a desire to expand the government that drove the creation of federal taxes; it was also a straightforward urge to make wealthy rentiers less wealthy. Theodore Roosevelt, in a speech in 1910, when he was preparing to run for a third Presidential term, declared, “No man should receive a dollar unless that dollar has been fairly earned. Every dollar received should represent a dollar’s worth of service rendered—not gambling in stocks but service rendered. The really big fortune, the swollen fortune, by the mere fact of its size, acquires qualities which differentiate it in kind as well as in degree from what is possessed by men of relatively small means.” The effect of the early federal income tax was similar to that of a wealth tax. At first, only the top two per cent of households paid it, and much of their income was produced by their wealth, in the form of stock dividends, not their labor. In 1916, three years after the advent of the tax, Congress established a federal estate tax—in effect, a tax on the transfer of wealth from parents to children.



“One last e-mail?”
Cartoon by Drew Panckeri

Throughout most of the twentieth century, taxes rose and the government grew. The tide began to turn with another momentous California ballot initiative—Proposition 13, in 1978, which severely limited property taxes. Ronald Reagan, who by then had been out of the governorship for a few years, picked up on the tax-cutting idea and made it central to his 1980 Presidential campaign. When he arrived in Washington, he initiated a practice of Republican Presidents beginning their terms with a substantial income-tax cut. In subsequent decades, Congress enacted a series of major reductions to the estate tax. For years, Democratic candidates were terrified of being accused of wanting to raise taxes.

In this century, the rise of concentrated wealth, economic precarity, and populist sentiment has changed the atmosphere. Back in 1959, in what’s thought to be one of the first precise calculations of the distribution of wealth in the United States, the economist Robert Lampman found that, six years earlier, the top one per cent of adult

wealth holders—those who had at least sixty thousand dollars in assets—had accounted for twenty-four per cent of national wealth, and that their share had fallen considerably since the nineteen-twenties. Inequality began accelerating again in the late seventies, and the amount of assets in the hands of the top one per cent increased dramatically. Today, that group, made up of those with more than eleven million dollars in net wealth, holds thirty-two per cent of national wealth. Just the top tenth of one per cent hold fifteen per cent of national wealth, amounting to twenty-eight trillion dollars.

The Occupy movement, which began in 2011, focussed on the top one per cent as a target. Two years later, the French economist Thomas Piketty, in his best-selling book "Capital in the Twenty-First Century," proposed a wealth tax, along with much higher top income-tax rates, as the only way to reverse growing inequality. In 2016, Senator Bernie Sanders shocked the Democratic establishment by running a close race against Hillary Clinton for the Party's Presidential nomination, thanks to his insistent focus on income and wealth inequality. In 2018, Emmanuel Saez and Gabriel Zucman, economists at the University of California, Berkeley, who have close ties to Piketty, and David Gamage, a former Berkeley law professor, began working with Senator Elizabeth Warren on a wealth-tax proposal for her 2020 Presidential campaign: a two-per-cent annual tax on all personal wealth above fifty million dollars. Sanders, who was running for President again, soon offered a version of his own, with a lower threshold, of sixteen million dollars.

What was distinctive about these ideas was not only that they were wealth taxes; it was also that they limited the scope to a small number of very rich people, in recognition of the enormous growth in big fortunes, especially in Silicon Valley. Many of the new billionaires largely avoid income taxation because, technically, their pay is minimal; Page and Brin both have base salaries of a dollar a year. Their stock in Alphabet, Google's parent company,

won’t be taxed unless they sell it. They can borrow against those holdings, and that money isn’t subject to income tax. The billionaires’ exploding wealth made it plausible that governments could significantly increase revenues by imposing new taxes only on them, and these figures’ declining popularity made such policies seem politically possible. It was a sign of where things were moving that Sanders, between his 2016 and 2020 Presidential campaigns, recast the standard foils of his rhetoric, speaking of billionaires rather than millionaires.

After Warren’s Presidential campaign ended, Saez, Zucman, Gamage, and two other law professors—Darien Shanske, of U.C. Davis, and Brian Galle, of Berkeley—began working with other politicians and interest groups that wanted to propose wealth taxes. Since 2020, they have consulted on proposals in states including Washington, New York, Illinois, and Vermont. They helped draft a proposal from Joe Biden to tax the unrealized capital gains of the richest Americans and a similar proposal from Senator Ron Wyden, of Oregon. They also worked on several recent attempts to pass a wealth tax in the California legislature. In 2024, G-20 leaders, with Zucman’s help, launched a discussion about wealth taxation, and in response there has been activity in several countries, such as Brazil, Spain, France, Belgium, Britain, and the Netherlands. None of these efforts have resulted in policy changes yet. Proposition 40 might.

Dave Regan, the president of Service Employees International Union-United Healthcare Workers West, doesn’t come across as a member of what Thomas Piketty calls the Brahmin left. A bluff, tough sixty-year-old with a full head of white hair, he is the son of a homicide cop from Buffalo and spent the early stages of his career presiding over a Rust Belt local. In 2009, the national head of the S.E.I.U., Andy Stern, sent Regan to California.

When I went to see Regan, in Sacramento, he told me that when he arrived in the state he felt as if he’d spent his whole life watching

the labor movement sink. “We’ve been on defense the whole time,” he said. “Our policy prescriptions have been very tepid. And it gets worse and worse. We’re at the point where incrementalism will not work. What can we do at a meaningful scale?” California’s particular form of direct democracy, he began to realize, offered an opportunity.

In 1911, California created its ballot-initiative system. Like the income tax, it was a Progressive Era reform meant to curb the power of the rich—especially the railroad barons, who effectively controlled the state legislature. The ballot system, which was approved via a special election, allowed anyone who mounted a successful signature-gathering campaign to put a policy proposal before the state’s voters. Regan found that, a hundred years later, it was still difficult to get labor-friendly measures through the California legislature, so he became an aggressive proponent of ballot referendums, sponsoring thirty-eight successful initiatives in the past ten years. Regan’s detractors complain that he uses referendums as a bargaining tactic, hoping that the threat of a union-friendly initiative passing will persuade a company to offer concessions. The system allows those who propose initiatives to withdraw them before Election Day. This year, for example, Regan dropped an initiative that would have restricted hospital executives’ pay, in exchange for the California Hospital Association not imposing new administrative hurdles on unions pursuing political campaigns.

Another knock on Regan is that he spends a lot of union resources on these campaigns. A proposed initiative has to get almost nine hundred thousand signatures to appear on the ballot, which can cost nearly twenty million dollars, much of which goes to signature-gathering firms. Critics also say that Regan’s initiatives are often designed to help only his union, not labor as a whole. “Dave has never tried to build coalitions,” Jim Araby, a veteran California labor organizer who left Regan’s union after Regan arrived, told me. Sometimes Regan makes a hard run at a single industry—he

focussed on dialysis firms in three recent failed initiatives—which risks bringing a new, well-resourced conservative player permanently into California politics, in ways that threaten the interests of other unions.

Following the Reagan tradition, Trump began his second Presidential term by proposing enormous reductions in spending and taxes. Congress passed the One Big Beautiful Bill Act by thin margins. Trump signed it on July 4, 2025. To help pay for its tax cuts, the act reduced Medicaid payments by a trillion dollars over the next decade, though it was designed to delay the full impact of the cuts until 2027, after this year's elections. Fourteen million Californians are on Medicaid, and, owing to the act, many of them will not be able to receive care at private hospitals; they will have to go to public-hospital emergency rooms. Regan's union represents a hundred and twenty thousand workers in private hospitals and clinics, so the cuts would have a devastating effect on them.

Last summer, Regan got in touch with Saez to ask whether his team of academics could help draft a wealth-tax initiative, to provide emergency funds that could forestall the effects of the federal Medicaid cuts. It had to be done quickly, because the ballot initiative that Regan had in mind would have to go through an elaborate series of steps in order to appear before voters in November, 2026. In the world of wealth-tax proposals, there are a few essential variables. What's the level of wealth below which people won't be taxed? What's the rate? How long will the tax be levied? While Saez and his team calculated how much revenue various answers to these questions would produce, Regan commissioned polls to test the popularity of several different options. The result was a one-time, five-per-cent tax on fortunes of at least a billion dollars, payable over five years, with ninety per cent of the estimated hundred billion dollars in proceeds directed toward restoring health care threatened by Trump's cuts. Regan and his team finished drafting the initiative and began investing union

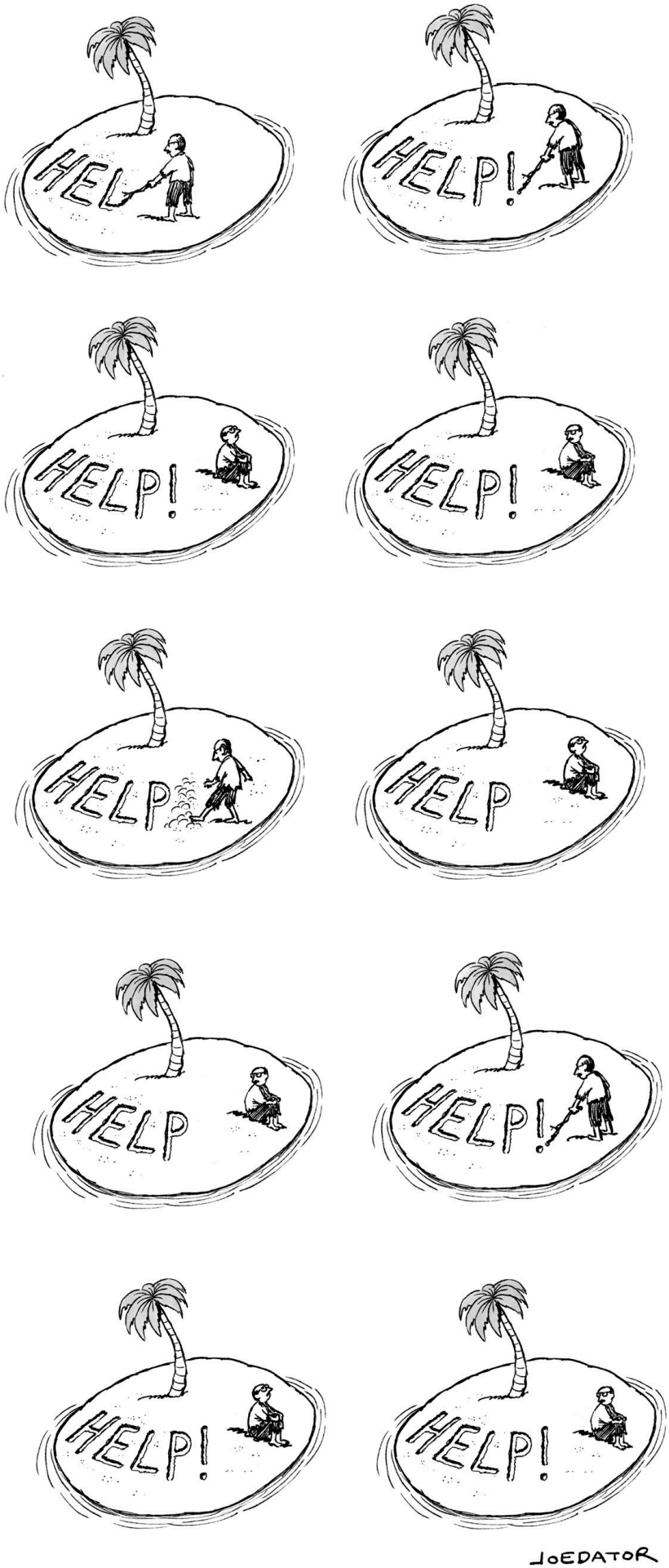
funds in signature-gathering. That got the immediate attention of Proposition 40's intended targets.

During the summer, the San Francisco *Standard,* a local news site, got hold of material from a Signal chat that a group of billionaires had formed to discuss the ballot measure. The participants included Sergey Brin; Chris Larsen, of the cryptocurrency company Ripple Labs; and the venture capitalists Marc Andreessen and Michael Moritz, the *Standard's* main funder. One idea that came up in the chat was buying a signature-gathering firm that Regan had hired, in the hope of stopping the initiative. Someone who has seen these messages told me that another theme in the chat, which disbanded in January because its members had begun to quarrel, was an impulse to expand into broader anti-labor activities.

The billionaires turned their energy and resources to starting organizations to defeat Proposition 40. The most important of these was Building a Better California, funded mostly by Brin. As of late summer, he had given the group a hundred and two million dollars, and several other billionaires (such as Moritz, the former Google executive Eric Schmidt, and the venture capitalist John Doerr) had also given it millions. Larsen started Golden State Promise, and Ron Conway, also a venture capitalist, helped start Stop the Squeeze. These groups are financing campaigns against Proposition 40, and Building a Better California is also backing Propositions 41 and 42—two newer initiatives that, if passed, could nullify the wealth tax.

The billionaires usually let the organizations that they bankroll speak on their behalf, but some of them have made specific policy arguments against Proposition 40. The most obvious one is that a wealth tax will lead billionaires to flee the state. In May, the *Financial Times* ran an essay by Moritz titled "In America, Wealth Taxes Mean Wealth Flight." Moritz told me that he personally doesn't plan to leave if Proposition 40 passes. "Age has something to do with it," he said. Moritz is seventy-two. "If I were a really

successful thirty-five-year-old, I might be making a different decision.”


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JOEDATOR

Cartoon by Joe Dator

Another argument is that much of the billionaires' wealth is in the form of stock in tech companies, which can't plausibly be converted to cash without damaging the businesses. "This isn't just a billionaire wealth tax," Garry Tan, the head of the tech-investing firm Y Combinator, posted on X last December. "It's a destroy tech in California proposition."

It may be another sign of the resentment Regan has stirred up that, early this fall, journalists covering the Proposition 40 campaign, including me, received two investigative reports that the S.E.I.U. had commissioned about Regan's behavior when he was pushing hard to get Proposition 40 on the ballot. One found that he had told an S.E.I.U. official, with whom he has clashed for years, to "fuck off" after she made a remark to him at a fund-raising event. (A spokesperson for the initiative campaign said,"Mr. Regan used profanity and does not pretend otherwise.")

Regan told me that, just before Christmas last year, he was invited to Governor Newsom's office. In Regan's version of the meeting, Newsom said, "I'm getting all these calls from billionaires." Regan said that he asked Newsom, "Do we see the problem the same way?" Newsom complains about economic inequality, and often deploys a quote long attributed to Plutarch: "The imbalance between the rich and the poor is the oldest and most fatal ailment of all republics." But he has consistently opposed wealth taxes in California, saying that they would drive away major providers of the state government's resources. Newsom told Regan that his proposal was unrealistic.

Once Regan had gathered enough signatures to get Proposition 40 on the ballot, he had until late June to withdraw it if he were offered a compromise that he found acceptable. Shortly before the deadline, he got a call from the Governor's chief of staff, Nathan Barankin, who said that Newsom was prepared to work with him

on a tax proposal. Regan told me, “Really, it was ‘If you play ball, we’re gonna promote you.’ This is the leader of the Democratic Party, the front-runner for President of the United States!” Regan had several phone calls with Newsom aides, who proposed compromises that Regan rejected. A week before the June deadline, Regan took out full-page ads in two California newspapers, offering to cut the proposed tax rate from five per cent to two per cent if Newsom would endorse it. Newsom rebuffed the offer. Regan said, “That’s where it ended.” A wealth tax was finally up for a vote.

In late September, polls showed that a slight majority of decided voters were in favor of Proposition 40. But the initiative has far less support than you’d expect from Democratic elected officials. Though the California Democratic Party has endorsed it, only three members of the California congressional delegation and ten members of the state legislature have done the same. California’s two U.S. senators have declined to support it; Xavier Becerra, Newsom’s likely successor, is opposed. Katie Porter, a former member of Congress who ran unsuccessfully for governor this year, is another opponent of the initiative. “It pours money into the for-profit health-care industry, which is already ripping people off,” she told me. “We have people with two hundred million, three hundred million, eight hundred million in assets, and it says to them, ‘You don’t need to give anything.’ ” Porter said, of Democrats thinking about running for President in 2028, “They see this coming. I expect to see very thoughtful ideas coming from them.”

The most notable exception to Democratic officials’ wariness about Proposition 40 is Ro Khanna, a congressman who represents part of Silicon Valley. Last year, during the week between Christmas and New Year’s, Khanna, while on vacation in Florida, read a story in the New York *Times* about how billionaires like Larry Page and Peter Thiel were threatening to leave the state if Proposition 40 passed. (Thiel, who declared support for Trump much earlier than

other Silicon Valley billionaires, contributed to Khanna's congressional campaign in 2016.) Khanna posted on X, "Peter Thiel is leaving California if we pass a 1% tax on billionaires for 5 years to pay for healthcare for the working class facing steep Medicaid cuts. I echo what FDR said with sarcasm of economic royalists when they threatened to leave, 'I will miss them very much.' " The post brought an immediate, hot-blooded riposte from Garry Tan. Earlier this year, Khanna received a barrage of attacks from Mark Cuban, the Dallas-based investor who for years appeared on the show "Shark Tank." "If this passes, only idiot startup founders stay in Cali," Cuban wrote.

Before Khanna's post on X, he had never met Dave Regan, but afterward they formed an alliance, and Khanna, who is considering running for President in 2028, began campaigning aggressively for Proposition 40. In response, Ethan Agarwal, a long-shot Democratic candidate for governor, decided to switch races and run for Congress against Khanna, with the support of wealthy tech investors such as Tan and Ron Conway. Khanna won easily.

I met with Khanna, a slim, intense man who speaks rapidly, in perfect sentences, at a coffee shop in Fremont, just across the San Francisco Bay from the heart of Silicon Valley. Khanna, the son of immigrants from India, grew up outside Philadelphia, went to the University of Chicago and Yale Law School, and moved to California in 2003 to work for the Valley's leading law firm, Wilson Sonsini. It was a different place then, he said: "It was still very much a culture of startups—not the winners of society but the insurgents, people who were off the beaten path, immigrants with accents, starting companies."

Now, Khanna said, "there are five trillion-dollar companies in my district. When I got elected to Congress, there wasn't a single trillion-dollar company. They're seen as oligarchs, as the people with wealth and power, controlling our lives—not as outsider insurgents. So it's a very, very different sense of their place in

society. And there's also a lot more arrogance. There's this sense that they are carrying American civilization on their backs and that they are the chosen allocators of capital and the ones who are making us lead against China, and that if it weren't for them America would not be a superpower." Khanna's district is one of the richest in the country; in Fremont, which isn't the wealthiest town in the area, the median annual household income is more than a hundred and eighty thousand dollars. Still, he said, his constituents feel intense economic pressure: "There's a concern that their kids aren't going to be able to live here. The cost of housing has exploded. The cost of child care has exploded. Some of them have done well, because a lot of them work at tech companies. But other people are leaving."

During Khanna's time in Congress, he has moved from a close alignment with tech executives to the left. In 2020 he co-chaired Bernie Sanders's Presidential campaign. After Khanna's X post, Sanders called him to say that he would endorse Proposition 40. More recently, Sanders and Khanna have co-sponsored a bill that would impose a national wealth tax of five per cent on billionaires, which Khanna says would raise four hundred billion dollars a year. I asked Khanna why he thinks so few Democratic politicians have endorsed Proposition 40. "People don't fully see that this is a defining fight for the soul of the Democratic Party," he said. "Are we going to go back to our New Deal roots of calling out economic royalists, or are we going to continue to be a party cozying up to moneyed interests? This is the first initiative to actually tax billionaire wealth that's going to get a vote, not only in our nation but the world. It has the equivalent weight to Proposition 13, which Reagan rode into the White House."

Khanna continued, "Why are more elected officials in California not worried about missing this? I think, fundamentally, they don't want to upset donors. Ron Conway and Reid Hoffman and Eric Schmidt contributed millions of dollars to help Biden defeat Trump, and to help us win back the House and Senate. It's not just

cravenness. There's a view that the biggest threat to American democracy is Donald Trump and not winning the House or Senate, and that we would be foolish to kneecap the prominent billionaires who are on our side. Why are we taking them on when we need their funding to compete with Elon Musk and the other billionaires on the Republican side?"

To Khanna, this is a major misreading of the mood in the Democratic Party, and he thinks that potential Presidential candidates should take note. "I believe that taxing billionaires will be one of the three key pillars to a Democratic campaign," he said. "In my view, it's Medicare for All, taxing billionaires, and not having foreign wars. Taxing billionaires is a key component. Joe Biden initially was going to be running on this in '24." For Democrats in 2028, he said, the question will be "Where do you stand?"

The online prediction markets are giving Proposition 40 only about a thirty-per-cent chance of passing. If polls show that it has a slight advantage, how can that be? The markets price in a number of other factors—most obviously the opposition's advertising campaign, which will go largely unanswered because the proponents of Proposition 40 used up most of their cash to gather signatures to get it on the ballot. The first round of opposition ads leaned heavily on a study published by economists at the Hoover Institution, a Stanford-based conservative think tank; they envision an "Atlas Shrugged" scenario in which Proposition 40 drives so many billionaires out of California that, rather than raising a hundred billion dollars for the state, it leads to twenty-five billion in lost tax revenue. During the final weeks of the campaign, the initiative's proponents will have to rely on person-to-person organizing. Regan, who's never hesitant to think big, told me he is confident that this can work: "If you can find a million people to turn out ten people each, that's ten million votes. Seven million votes wins. That's what we're trying to do. It's never been done at

this level, in the history of American politics.” He said it’s not out of the question that he gets the Pope’s endorsement.

Proposition 41 and Proposition 42, the two initiatives meant to nullify Proposition 40, will have tens of millions of dollars devoted to their campaigns. Proposition 41 presents itself as a measure to improve how the state audits spending, and Proposition 42 as a way of protecting people’s retirement savings from unexpected taxation. “Proposition 41 and Proposition 42 are hilariously cynical,” Brian Galle, one of the Proposition 40 authors, told me. “They are an anti-billionaire-tax burrito. There’s a wrapper that looks harmless”—and, inside, poison-pill provisions that would negate Proposition 40. In California, when conflicting initiatives pass, only the one with the most votes takes effect. So it’s possible that Proposition 40 could pass but still fail, if either Proposition 41 or Proposition 42 gets more votes.



“They grow up so fast—remember when it was just a little junk drawer?”
Cartoon by Teresa Burns Parkhurst

Another major hurdle facing Proposition 40 is the substantial array of labor groups that do not support the measure. The California A.F.L.-C.I.O. has endorsed the initiative, but the state council of the S.E.I.U., the national S.E.I.U., and the national A.F.L.-C.I.O. have maintained what John Updike, in a different context, called a "meaningful silence." The California Teachers Association, which represents more than three hundred thousand educators, is openly opposed to the initiative. Proposition 13, which ushered in the modern era of California ballot initiatives, devastated public schools in the state by placing strict limits on their main source of income: property taxes. The latest in a long series of corrective measures was a thirteen-per-cent state income tax on millionaires, which went into effect in 2012 and is due to expire in 2030. This year, the C.T.A. has put significant resources into an initiative of its own, Proposition 3, which would make the millionaire tax rate permanent. This is especially important because California, unlike the federal government, taxes capital gains at the same rate as ordinary income, so each wave of initial public offerings by tech companies generates large revenues for the state.

Proposition 40 can be seen as a direct competitor to the C.T.A.'s initiative, because only a small portion of the money from the billionaire tax would go to public schools. And the vast campaign to stop Proposition 40 could put voters in an anti-tax frame of mind, also bringing down Proposition 3. Not long after Regan proposed Proposition 40, he attended a Zoom meeting of union leaders, who included two representatives from the C.T.A., to try to persuade them to support it. The meeting didn't go well. "They were on our side in 2020 and 2021," Galle told me, referring to the unsuccessful efforts to pass a wealth tax in the state legislature, "and now they're yelling at us on Zoom calls." Regan wound up losing his temper and left the meeting. Any hope of creating a broad labor coalition backing Proposition 40 ended. Building a Better California, the anti-Proposition 40 group, has endorsed Proposition 3.

Even if Proposition 40 passes and Propositions 41 and 42 don't, California's billionaires will surely invest just as heavily in pursuing legal challenges as they have in opposing the initiative campaign. The authors of Proposition 40 gave it an effective date of January 1, 2026, to prevent billionaires from evading the tax by leaving California after its passage. That provision could be challenged in court based on past decisions against retrospective taxation. Then, there's the question of how to value billionaires' assets, a task that would fall to a state agency called the Franchise Tax Board, which doesn't have an established way of doing so and would presumably be hearing constantly from the billionaires' lawyers. Real-estate holdings are exempted from the tax so that Proposition 40 can't be accused of violating Proposition 13's property-tax limits. But billionaires have a lot of other assets, held in many ways—outright ownership, partnerships, special companies officially headquartered elsewhere. One of the proposition's authors cited a famous line in "Hotel California" to argue that it will be very difficult even for billionaires who have already moved away to avoid the tax, because they can be shown to have an "intent to return" if their companies are still in the state. Of course, that argument would be challenged, too.

The advantage of state wealth taxes is that they don't face the barrier of the Constitution's restriction on direct federal taxation, which was amended for income but not for wealth. The advantage of a new federal wealth tax is that billionaires could not move from state to state to avoid it. (Newsom says that he favors a national tax on billionaires for this reason.) Several European nations—France and Norway, for example—have imposed wealth taxes, only to see some of the intended targets move their legal residences to other countries. The United States puts much higher barriers in the way of people who want to move out of the country to avoid taxes: they have to renounce their citizenship, and, if they're rich, they have to pay an immediate, severe exit tax. The authors of Proposition 40 are in favor of trying to impose wealth taxes at any level of

government, but others argue that a national wealth tax has the best chance of success here.

Still, a federal wealth tax would immediately be challenged in the courts. In a 2024 case called Moore v. United States, which tax lawyers watched with rapt attention and the public didn't much notice, several Supreme Court Justices indicated that they would likely consider a federal wealth tax unconstitutional. A differently composed Supreme Court, or another constitutional amendment, may have to arrive before a national wealth tax would be possible. Or a national wealth tax could attempt to avoid such obvious legal difficulties. One proposal is to apply a capital-gains tax on inheritances. The wealth tax that Biden put forward would have framed increases in the value of assets as income so that, legally, it could be considered an income tax. There are also a number of loopholes that could be closed. Even these changes, though, would face years of fierce opposition from people with the resources to fight them while the public's attention inevitably flagged.

These are legal questions. For now, political questions are far more important. Imagine the soon-to-arrive moment when Anthropic goes public, creating, overnight, multibillion-dollar fortunes just as the public is turning against A.I. (OpenAI, evidently aware of this dynamic, has announced that it will not go public this year.) Imagine a Democratic Presidential primary in which Newsom feels compelled to propose a national wealth tax because he promised to do so instead of endorsing Proposition 40. Dan Newman, a veteran Democratic political consultant in California who is working for the opposition to Proposition 40, told me, "It's going to be a raise-your-hand moment at the early Democratic-primary debates"—no candidate in the field will be able to duck the question entirely. They will have to weigh the power of voters' anti-billionaire mood against the value of the Democrats' relationship with Big Tech. Endorsing wealth taxes could also imperil the Party's relationship with the Brahmin left, which is reliably liberal on social issues but

not necessarily on economic ones, and which might not believe that non-billionaires will be spared significant new taxation.

In the first Gilded Age, the fight over taxation and the concentration of wealth went far beyond a technical focus on policy—it was more like a holy war that was fought on theological grounds and then ended up in the mundane world of elections, laws, and court decisions. The fight over Proposition 40 feels that way too. So, probably, will the fight over a national wealth tax. One of the few anti-wealth-tax billionaires who was willing to answer my questions was Mark Cuban—who isn't a Californian. Via e-mail, he offered the same prediction about wealth taxation that Garry Tan issued: it would deliver a death blow to economic innovation by forcing cash-poor, asset-rich entrepreneurs to set aside money that they don't have. But he wound up levelling a more general critique: "Our politicians have stopped trying to solve problems. They aren't trying to improve the lives of people in this country who can't afford to live. That are terrified of getting sick. That can't afford to have kids. Who don't see a future for themselves. Not one fucking solution is offered from either side. They just stick to their ideology and do their best to demonize someone." Michael Moritz, who is more restrained, said, "A single-state, poorly constructed wealth tax is not a solution to what ails us."

Of course, wealth taxes would produce revenues that could be directed to useful purposes, such as expanding government programs or reducing the disastrously high federal deficit. The income tax had such effects. Emotionally, though, Proposition 40 has sharpened people's views of billionaires—as heroic innovators and job creators, or as oligarchical resource hogs. People who support Proposition 40 and other wealth taxes usually think that billionaires per se are a problem. A group called Patriotic Millionaires, which advocates for higher taxes on the wealthy, has endorsed Proposition 40, making it the only organization officially made up of rich people to do so. One of its leading members, Alan

Davis, who runs a foundation started by his parents, doesn't disagree with Cuban's opinion that Proposition 40 is an attack on the very rich for being very rich. "Most people say this is a way to raise revenue," he told me. "I think that's a dividend you get from reducing the wealth and power of the ultra-rich. The most important reason to tax the ultra-rich is to make them less rich."

Tom Steyer, Proposition 40's only known billionaire supporter and a former candidate for governor, told me that last fall he tried to find a compromise with the measure's opponents: "I suggested to several super-rich Californians, 'Look, if you don't like this, why don't we sit down and come up with something that works from your standpoint and actually addresses the issues?' And they had no interest in doing it." Steyer, who made his fortune by starting a hedge fund in San Francisco, explained the difference between himself and the other billionaires by saying that he is more aware of the connection between rich people and society as a whole. "The idea that extraordinarily rich people can succeed without the support of society, and that they can preserve their wealth in the face of suffering and inequality—I don't believe it can happen, and I know it shouldn't happen," he said. He lamented the passing of what he saw as tech's originating spirit, entrepreneurial but also patriotic, which was exemplified by the Hewlett-Packard founders' heavy involvement in philanthropy and public service. "Can you imagine David Packard or Bill Hewlett doing the kind of self-promotion that Elon Musk does?" he said. "There's obviously been just a really dramatic change. I don't want to turn them into gods, but Dave Packard and Bill Hewlett felt a deep connection with the country and with the state and with the land. It doesn't exist today."

I asked him how he explains this change. "The people who are making the big money in California are technology people," he said, and many of them "are incredibly focussed on that and quite dismissive of the other kinds of learning. That is not something they respect. English literature is not something they respect." It may be pertinent that we were speaking at the decidedly old-school

Yale Club, in New York City—Steyer is an alum. “When you get too reductive in terms of focussing just on money, or just focussing on technology, there are a lot of things that you’re cutting away from that world view,” he went on. “And a lot of those things are what we would think of as human values, like compassion, some sense of honor, all the things that you read about in the soft courses. And, if you don’t have that, then O.K., good night. You have a different frame of reference and a different value system.”

Whose vision of billionaires will prevail? If it’s Steyer’s, and evidently much of the public’s, then we may be in for a change in the workings of the country as major as the advent of the income tax. For a national wealth tax, Emmanuel Saez told me, “five per cent a year is what I would call a small, reasonable package. Things are moving very fast right now. Proposition 40 is the best shot we’ve ever had, and that’s why I’m not surprised at the interest in it. If it passes, it will be a revolution.” ♦

An earlier version of this article misstated the tax status of the San Francisco Standard, the name of Building a Better California, the net worth of Garry Tan, and the C.T.A.’s position on Proposition 40.

Nicholas Lemann is a staff writer and a professor at Columbia’s Graduate School of Journalism. His books include “Returning: A Search for Home Across Three Centuries” (March, 2026).

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/the-battle-to-pass-a-billionaire-tax

Personal History

A Self-Made Woman

My cousin Laura had a diva’s charisma and a siren’s voice. She also had a mysterious past.

By **Judith Thurman**

October 5, 2026



Dolls “represent what we can be—not what we are,” Laura wrote in a diary. “Dolls speak to the divine in us.”
Photo illustration by John Gall; Source photograph courtesy Danny Meisner

When my cousin Danny introduced me to his new wife, almost forty years ago, Laura was in her early thirties, a radiant beauty of Taíno heritage with a lithe figure and a model’s cheekbones. She wore her hair in a thick plait that swayed when she moved, and she emanated a sensuality that stirred anyone with a pulse. Without meaning to, she seduced my son’s puppy on the day we brought it home from the shelter, and whenever she came to visit, it went mad

with joy. But Laura's most striking feature was her voice, a smoky contralto, rich in irony, with an unplaceable accent, the product of self-invention.

Danny and Laura made an odd couple. His appearance was unprepossessing—frizzy red hair, a fleshy nose, a Teddy bear's physique—and he effaced himself in her company, as if to deflect notice. (Divas often have such a husband, a recessive figure who pays the bills and basks in their charisma.) But then I hadn't paid him much notice when we were growing up together in Queens, in garden apartments that bordered a cemetery. We were both members of the Meisner clan, a family of Hungarian Jewish immigrants, but Danny was six years my junior, and we weren't close. When his parents moved away, our worlds diverged.

Over the years, I'd heard that Danny had studied acting and joined a theatre group. He might have succeeded on television, playing cops or hit men in procedurals, but he lacked the aura of menace those parts require. His looks destined him for comic roles, and the ones he landed couldn't pay the rent, so he trained as a computer tech.

Laura entered my life at a fraught moment. My parents had just died, six months apart. My son, Will, was a baby with a distant father, and my maiden aunt Arkie was helping me raise him. I was living in a former pushcart stable in Yorkville, hidden behind a storefront and surrounded by an overgrown garden. Its bohemian décor struck Laura as romantic, and so did my life as a single mother who lived by her pen. "Not needing a man," she sighed theatrically. "What a luxury."

Later, Laura would visit me when Danny was at work. I'd set a pretty table for her, and she'd dress for the occasion. Along with a fondness for thrift-shop china, one of our bonds was a sense of imposture; we were both guarded women who seemed outgoing. I had just started work on a biography of Colette, whose title would

be “Secrets of the Flesh,” and even before I knew Laura’s history she struck me as a character Colette might have imagined. An uncle of mine made the connection. He was an old rake who avoided family gatherings, though not after he met Laura. He flirted shamelessly with her, then told us approvingly, “There’s a woman with a past.”

The better I knew Laura, the more I puzzled at her pure-heartedness. Life had wounded yet somehow not embittered her. She believed in love, and her capacity for loving was like a boxer’s heavy bag, sturdy and inured to blows. You could confide your chagrins to her knowing she wouldn’t try to assuage them with pat reassurances. I did my best to reciprocate, and if she read my work she might have recognized herself as a recurrent figure in it: a woman warring with the myths about femininity that sabotage us. Laura once hoped to write her own story, with my help. But when she died suddenly, on a winter morning in 2003, she left me to tell it—a task I’ve evaded for too long.

Danny and Laura were still relative strangers to me when I invited them to dinner with an old friend, an intellectual of courtly manners and wry despair at human ignominy. His dandyism is a reproach to modernity, like Laura’s penchant for playing the coquette, and they appealed to each other. She listened raptly, or pretended to, as he lauded obscure diarists of the eighteenth century.

After dessert, I did my party trick: reading palms. I had learned the basics in my youth from the girlfriend of my drug dealer, Nikos, a former theatre director who liked to quote Sophocles. She received callers propped in bed, looking like Jane Seymour as the Bond girl Solitaire, languidly casting her tarot cards. “It’s always better to be cryptic,” she told me. “People take dark truths to heart.”

That evening, though, I didn’t censor myself. I told my fastidious friend that he had a murderer’s thumb and a bent for violent

revolution. This seemed to please him. After some teasing, he admitted that he owned a gun safe, and that his only fond memories of his remote, mandarin father were from their hunting trips together. My friend was later almost killed reporting from a war zone.

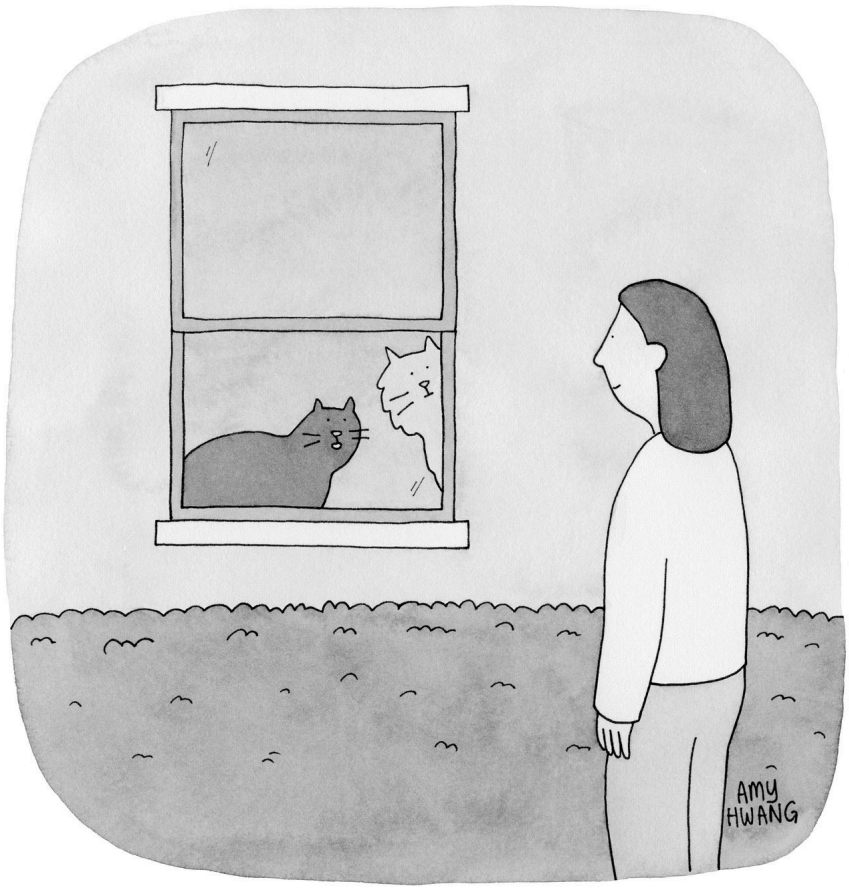
Chiromancy is an ancient practice, long discredited, and just a game to me. Yet the way that a subject tenders her hand suggests a secret about her character; that “tell” is what you read. Laura hesitated, protesting that her nails weren’t manicured. When she finally relented, she cupped her palms like a begging bowl. The right one had a prominently crisscrossed Mount of Venus, but its most distinctive feature was the merging of the head and heart lines —a rarity I’d seen only in illustrations. Old palmists took it to predict madness or depravity, but, as I told Laura, it could also be the sign of a great soul wrestling with its demons for the world’s benefit. “Aha!” she said gaily. “Then there’s hope for the world.”

The next morning, Laura called to joke about her “demons”—the two toy poodles she doted on. She and Danny wanted to return my hospitality, so, a week later, I scaled the five flights to their new apartment, in a former tenement a block from the pushcart stable. “Come meet my girls,” she said, as she opened the door. Her girls, I saw to my surprise, were the trophies in a private doll museum.

The walls of the apartment were lined with display cases that Laura had built herself and filled with rotating exhibits, drawn from a vast collection in storage. There were poignant sackcloth dolls from the antebellum South, made for enslaved children; antique baby dolls with painted Meissen heads; Madame Alexanders like the ones I had played with in Queens; original Barbies. Many were rare; Laura was a discerning curator. She restored dolls for other collectors, and, with the benefit of sewing lessons from my aunt Arkie, she dressed her girls in New Look ensembles that might have been modelled by Suzy Parker.

I was stunned not only by the skill and passion that the dolls represented but also by the investment. As far as I knew, Laura and Danny lived on his middle-class salary from a consulting firm. Extravagance, however, is a quality I secretly admire. Neither of my parents knew how to live; they plodded through their days, my father at a job he hated, my mother tranquillized with Miltown. Arkie knew what joy was (ocean swimming, Italian opera), but she was a frugal socialist who had run a settlement house during the Depression.

Isak Dinesen, the subject of my first biography, considered improvidence a noble trait; her favorite phrase was “regardless of expense.” Laura had her own version of it: “You have to spend the wages of sin.” That was how she prefaced the confession she’d invited me to hear. The three of us were drinking sangria on the roof, and Laura was wearing a summer dress that bared her lovely shoulders. “The girls represent my life savings,” she began. “I earned them as a dominatrix. That’s how I met Danny. He was a regular at the dungeon.”



“She’s a member of my fan club.”
Cartoon by Amy Hwang

“It wasn’t regular that I fell madly in love,” he objected, with atypical vehemence. She patted his knee and ignored him. “False pretenses take a toll on true feelings,” she went on, “so we risked losing your respect to tell you.” But she also wanted me to know that bondage wasn’t prostitution. No intercourse took place. Her vocation was legal, and she described it as “role-play” on her tax returns. For a high-school dropout, it paid more than her dream job —classical dancing—ever would have. Grateful clients left lavish tips that financed champagne dinners, a ballet subscription with front-row seats, a honeymoon in Venice. They addressed her as “Mistress Erika” and knelt at her feet.

Not long afterward, I asked Laura for a favor on behalf of Will’s au pair, a Danish girl who lived in the studio that I used as an office. Liv had the face of a milkmaid and the body of a goddess. Men had treated her as a sex object since she was twelve, and she couldn’t walk down a street unmolested. After two months in New York, she

had steeled her native bashfulness with a bravado—scanty outfits, goth makeup—that worried me. When I found a bondage magazine in our studio, I asked Laura what I should do. “Ask her about it,” she said. “My guess is that she has fantasies of revenge, but they scare her.”

When Liv admitted as much to me, Laura volunteered to give her some “job counselling,” and we decided to deliver it at a family dinner. On the evening it took place, Arkie made meat loaf. I warned her that what Laura had to say might upset her. “You underestimate me,” she said.

As the meal began, everyone but Laura seemed nervous. She admired the monogrammed napkins. Danny talked about the Mets, who were “in fifth place, despite Doc Gooden.” Liv chattered about Will’s new toy. Arkie, acting on her feminist principles, had made him an “anatomically correct” boy doll. It was adorably pudgy, like Will at three, with a button navel and a tiny penis. But something about it “freaked him out,” Liv said, and he’d thrown it across the room. Laura smiled like a cat: “Well, not to change the subject . . .” Then she spoke for an hour with a banked ferocity that enthralled us. I wondered if she’d used that tone with her clients.

Laura had impressed me with her knowledge of the S & M canon—Sade, Bataille, et al.—in which the slave is typically a woman who submits to a priapic master. Jessica Benjamin had recently published a psychoanalytic study of the subject, “The Bonds of Love,” and we talked about her theory that a masochist seeks recognition for her “hidden self” in surrender. “Good luck with that,” Laura said. She gave up on Foucault, though it amused her to learn that I had once served as his interpreter on a tour of the West Street leather bars. Her own clients were straight, at least outwardly—respectable citizens and family men. One was a Hasidic rabbi.

Danny later tried to explain his own need for domination. He’d been molested in junior high school by an older boy, and, despite

his shame, the abuse had aroused him. It was, he came to feel, a form of attention—his parents were alcoholics, and he'd felt invisible to them. But, he said, there was also a "spiritual dimension" to masochism. The vision quests of shamans involve an ordeal, and so does a martyr's penance. Their rationale is that pain wears down the ego, which blocks our access to the divine. Danny's notion of mortification reminded me of St. Catherine, who dreamed of being nailed to the Cross with Jesus. Laura never bought it.

Her lecture at dinner gave a stark view of the workplace where she met her husband. "A dungeon is a theatre where morality plays are performed," she said. "Badness is chastised and sinners atone. A dominatrix often poses as a mother figure, but instead of T.L.C. she metes out punishment. Your average sub"—submissive—"begs to be treated as a 'naughty boy.' You'd be surprised at how many masters of the universe want to be diapered and force-fed their own shit."

Liv had been listening agog, and I began to worry that the intervention was backfiring. But Laura had a storyteller's sense of timing. Rising from the table, she produced the bondage magazine. It was open to a spread in which two masked Amazons were flogging a naked fat man bound with handcuffs and a gag. "There's nothing to be ashamed of," she told Liv, who was blushing violently. "When it comes to sex, we're all Pavlov's dogs. But here's what I want you to know. Every day, a domme paddles butts until her arms ache, in a corset she can't breathe in and stilettos that kill her back. She bloats her bladder so she can empty it into the mouth of some dentist from New Jersey. Then she cleans up his mess. Yes, you dominate them for an hour and they submit. And maybe for an hour, it's a kick. But your power is an illusion. You're a waitress, delivering the meal they ordered."

At this point, Arkie began clearing the table. She patted Laura tenderly on her way to the kitchen. We sat in silence a while.

Finally, Liv dared to ask my cousin how she got into the business. “I was angry, too,” Laura said, “and I needed to support my mother. She worked as a hotel maid.”

This winter, after a week of blizzards, Danny and I drove through a featureless white landscape to visit Laura’s mother, Aurea Vilar, who lives in rural Pennsylvania with her son James Moore III and his blended family—a wife and five children. He’s a social worker for an agency that serves disabled clients.

At eighty-six, Aurea is frail but still beautiful, with her daughter’s chiselled features. “I don’t remember things,” she warned me when we settled on a sofa with her electric blanket and my iPad. Her tiny frame and willful innocence made her seem childlike. James looked at her wearily. “It’s not just forgetfulness,” he told me. “A lot is denial.”

Aurea’s parents had abandoned her as a baby, and she was raised by her abuela in Caguas, Puerto Rico—an inland city, named for a Taíno cacique. After the Spaniards arrived in 1493, they expelled or enslaved most of the Taíno, turning the valley into a center for cultivating sugarcane and tobacco. They left a legacy of misery, but also a charming main plaza, and in Aurea’s youth teen-agers gathered there for the Sunday *paseo*. That’s where she met Efraín López Muñiz. He seemed “suave and sophisticated,” she told me. He had gone to college, until he quit to manage his father’s cement business. Aurea got pregnant and they married. She was nineteen.

Their romance was brief. Efraín supported his new family grudgingly, and he didn’t live with them. He took up with Aurea’s best friend, and then with a series of paramours, fathering several children. Aurea described him as “*muy controlador*.” He forbade her to work, and she was afraid to leave the house. Her first baby was a plaything and a solace to her. She had dreamed of having a daughter—a little Aurea—but the newborn was a boy, Efraín López-Vilar.

Efraín was followed by Ramón, known as Ray. Someone, perhaps their father, took a snapshot of the two siblings playing in their yard. They are bare-chested tykes of three and five, Ray in a diaper and Efraín in shorts, holding a hoe between his legs. It looks like a horse's penis, and he is poking his brother with it. That's the only known image of "him"—which is to say, of little Laura as the world saw her.

Danny told me later that the gender of Mistress Erika "was a subject of rumors in the B.D.S.M. community." But almost no one outside the family guessed that Laura was a trans woman. "I wanted to tell you that day on the roof," Laura said one afternoon at our tea table. "But it felt like too much for one conversation." She had known since the age of three that she was female. "I identified with Princess Ozma," she said. Ozma is a heroine of L. Frank Baum's Oz novels. Her father, King Pastoria, rules the Land of Oz before the wizard usurps his throne and gives his baby daughter to an evil witch, who changes her into a boy. The princess forgets her true sex until she's restored to it by magic as a teen-ager and reclaims her birthright.

When I'd absorbed her revelation, which only deepened my admiration for her, Laura told me that she needed some advice. She was thinking of writing a memoir—living large was catching up with them. "If I wrote about my sex change, would it make more money?" she asked. I told her, "If you're going to upend your life for the money, think hard about it." She did, and shelved the project, though she joked about a movie version with Irene Cara. (Cara, a star of "Fame," was exactly Laura's age and half Puerto Rican.) But her real scruple was with Aurea: "My mother can't take the truth."

Aurea had a third baby with Efraín: Minerva, known as Mickey, who is now a mother of five. She told me over Zoom from her home, in North Carolina, that she suffers stress-triggered seizures, as Laura and Ray did: "He once nearly bit off his tongue." Mickey

had her first child as a teen-ager and then neglected him. “I ran amok early,” she said. “It was Laura who straightened me out. I needed her disappointment to become a good person.” Mickey described her sister with abiding gratitude, yet she also wanted me to know “something I shouldn’t say, because it complicates your story. From the time she was a baby, Aurea feminized Laura. She dressed her as a girl and painted her nails. They played with makeup and Barbies.” (Aurea denies this.) “Once she started school, or family came to visit, my sister had to act like a boy. And, when I was born, Aurea got the daughter she always wanted. Laura mothered and protected me, but she must have been jealous.”

Perhaps Aurea’s doll play with Laura affirmed her identity, but it also endangered her life. Efraín was a brute, who boasted of killing five people in bar fights over women. Alcohol fuelled his rages. He punished Aurea for turning his son into a “*maricón*” by beating and raping her. He beat Ray for defending his mother and Laura for shaming him. Laura told Danny that her father had raped her, too. A neighbor overheard him threatening to burn the house down and urged Aurea to flee. “How could I?” she asked. “He’d find me.” A decade into this ordeal, Aurea’s own father reappeared—he’d been in the Navy. “When he found me black and blue he bought us tickets to New York.”

The family settled in the South Bronx, where Aurea had three more children with two partners. Carmen’s father, Pete, was a younger man whom she met working at a garment factory. James and Divina were fathered by James Moore II, a co-worker at her hotel job. Divi was supposed to join us at her brother’s house, but she was mourning the suicide of her son. He had shot himself, at twenty-one, after a savage beating by his father, provoked by the insult of being obese. The family saga makes you marvel at its survivors’ resilience. “I swore the cycle would stop here,” James said during my visit, gesturing toward his kids, who were eating pizza in the kitchen.

When Pete became the man of the house, they were living on Union Avenue, in a fifth-floor walkup. Mickey told me a story about a neighbor named Dulce: “One day, she didn’t hear what her husband told her, so she asked him to repeat it, and he cut her ear off. That’s what our world was like.” It was a treacherous milieu for a defiantly flamboyant youth. Laura, then going by the name Jay, was bullied at school. In the cafeteria, she told me, classmates squirted ketchup in her hair and pushed her face into her lunch tray.

Tensions and hostility were also high at home. “Laura embarrassed me,” Aurea admitted. “She stole my clothes and underwear.” Pete wouldn’t tolerate her cross-dressing, and it also troubled Ray, who was at an age when boys obsess about masculinity. He had other torments, too. He was in a gang, Mickey said, and Pete had “hooked him on speedballs at twelve.” Aurea gave him a choice: hit the street or join the Navy. She readily signed the consent for him to enlist as a minor—an admission, perhaps, of her helplessness to protect her children but also of her hope that some better angel could.

On weekends, Pete and his friends partied in the living room. Some of the men were relatives. “When they got drunk, they ran train on Laura,” Mickey said, meaning that they took turns sodomizing her. Aurea denied having witnessed these atrocities. “Maybe it happened in the basement,” she said coyly, though, when James prodded her, she admitted being too passive: “I didn’t know how to pick men.”

These violations made Laura’s body unlivable for her, and she was hospitalized for attempting suicide. The first time was with a razor that she’d used to shave her legs. Pete had threatened to kill her, so she locked herself in the bathroom to do it herself. The police broke the door down and took her to Bellevue.

Other attempts followed, with blades and pills, and she sometimes spent months on a psych ward. “That’s where she discovered

books,” Mickey said. “The city had to school minors who couldn’t sit in a classroom, and most of the kids were so out of it that Laura had private tutors. They were amazed by how smart she was. I think she was, too.” The other upside of her breakdowns was that she was stowed in protective custody. No one could hurt her and she couldn’t hurt herself.



“One day, all of these dishes I’ve left ‘to soak’ will be your problem.”
Cartoon by Jason Adam Katzenstein

The chronology of Laura’s medical history is hard to establish, since records weren’t digitized fifty years ago. But Aurea recalled authorizing hormone therapy when Laura was thirteen, and said that “it calmed her down.” Mickey believes that she was treated at Mount Sinai, where Walter Futterweit, a Viennese-born endocrinologist, was an early practitioner of gender-affirming care.

In a photograph of the child who was still Jay, she’s a lissome waif in a demure cotton blouse. Her breasts are those of a girl her age—high and firm. Estrogen spurs breast growth, though Mickey told me that Laura “got implants to make them fuller. She also had her ears pinned back, and electrolysis on her body hair. Don’t ask

where the money came from." I did ask. "Well, she gave blow jobs to our landlord when he wanted to evict us, so you go figure."

As my son got older, Danny took him to ballgames and gave him his first catcher's mitt. His great ambition, besides acting, was fatherhood—he has always loved children. Laura had initially told me that she had a "fertility issue" but that she wanted to make Danny happy, so they were exploring adoption. The Catholic agency they applied to would approve them as a model couple: a happy homemaker married to a good provider who would welcome a baby of any color.

The subject of motherhood arose again when I knew the truth about Laura's "fertility issue." I'd had Will at forty-two, and I told her that I'd waited so long in part because I worried that I didn't have enough reality of my own to nurture a child's. "Tell me about it," she said, feeding petits fours to the poodles. Danny, she was sure, would make a great parent, but she couldn't trust herself in the role, since she'd always suffered from mood swings, and the depressions "annihilated" her. When I asked if she'd ever seen a shrink, she laughed. "I'm way too interesting to them," she said. "They can't help me."

There was one shrink who might have: Dr. Leah Schaefer, an early champion of trans women. Schaefer objected fiercely to the predominant view that "transsexuals" suffered from a pathology and should be "normalized" for their own good. The real pathology, she argued, was society's. In the late sixties, when she opened her practice, medical care for children who didn't conform to the gender they were assigned at birth was just beginning. The first university-affiliated gender-identity clinic opened at Johns Hopkins in 1966. (Laura was then seven and being raped by her father.) It offered hormone treatment and surgery to patients who met strict criteria, one of which was later called gender dysphoria. Mickey told me that Laura received that diagnosis, supported by the evidence of her suicide attempts and hospitalizations.

Schaefer often worked with Futterweit, and with Dr. Harry Benjamin, a pioneer of transgender medicine who had an office on Park Avenue. The three shared the conviction that their patients deserved a smooth path to transition. Those patients tended to be well-to-do adults, or, more rarely, children with wealthy, supportive parents. But some cases were referred to a doctor in Queens who served a broader population. Roberto Granato, a urologist born in Argentina, had one of the largest gender-affirmation practices in New York. There is good reason to believe that he operated on Laura. Medicaid paid for her surgery. It took place on her eighteenth birthday. “I signed off on what they did to Laura,” Aurea said, “because I wanted to see her happy.”

Vaginoplasty has since evolved, but the standard procedure then involved seven steps: removing the testes; stripping the penis of its skin; creating a cavity between the rectum and the urethra; lining the cavity with the penile flap; modifying the urethra; constructing a clitoris and labia from the scrotal and erectile tissue; inserting a stent to preserve the new vagina’s shape. Laura would have gone home to bed with instructions to dilate her vagina regularly—for the rest of her life—to prevent its contraction and preserve its shape. Mickey vividly remembers that post-op period. Ray still shared a bedroom with Laura, “and she was in agony, so it was a nightmare for her.”

Her brother James grew up unaware of Laura’s past; he learned about it only in his twenties. “My sisters were just girls to me,” he said. “Like the girls I saw in eighties movies, and I watched them do their hair and get dolled up. And I remember walking in on Laura, in the Bronx, when she was taking a bath. She was the first naked woman I ever saw.”

The years that followed Laura’s surgery are sparsely documented. The family moved to LeFrak City, in Queens, not far from where Danny and I had grown up. There, Laura met a fourteen-year-old boy whom Mickey described as “a punk from a family of grifters.”

Laura told me that she ran away with him because she was terrified of being rejected by an experienced lover. She did sex work to support them, and for a while they hid out in a fleabag motel in Harlem, partly to escape his parents, who tried to blackmail Laura for corrupting a minor. The relationship was stormy and roiled by drugs. The boy taunted Laura with his infidelities, and one day he abandoned her on a subway platform. She chased his train desperately until it left the station.

Laura's beauty, in her twenties, was incandescent. A friend named Eva took her clubbing, and bouncers welcomed them. In the years before *AIDS*, the club scene was orgiastic. Laura met celebrities who can't be named, and they flirted in V.I.P. rooms famous for the quantity of coke that flowed. In 1985, Bon Jovi hired Laura for a music video—"In and Out of Love." She wears a bathing suit in one brief scene, a miniskirt and high heels in another, flaunting her dancer's legs and regal bearing. Even before her surgery, she had taken pointe classes, cleaning the studio to pay for them, and she auditioned as a ballerina for the Dance Theatre of Harlem. "I won an apprenticeship," she told me proudly. I couldn't confirm her training there, and none of the alumni whom I spoke to remembered her, though a retired star described their routine: exercises and rehearsals from ten in the morning until eight at night and performances on weekends. Apprentices earned a token wage.

Poverty subverted Laura's dreams. So, Danny said, did her "fear of exposure." I had another relative who sacrificed her future outrunning her past. My first mother-in-law, Dorothy, was born to an unwed teen-ager who confided her to the care of two "aunts"—hoofers whom Dorothy called "the girls." They performed in travelling burlesque shows (and turned tricks to make ends meet). Eventually they settled in Harlem, where an elderly neighbor taught Dorothy to dance. He sat on the stoop, miming routines with his arms, while she memorized the steps. The old man warned her that once she "became a woman," her guardians would expect her to ply their trade. Not long after Dorothy first got her period, she

sneaked into the Ringling Brothers circus at Madison Square Garden and charmed one of the trainers. When the circus left town, she went with it. Later, she became a chorus girl, but every time a producer wanted to promote her, she bolted: “I was afraid that the girls would find me if I got famous.”

“Birds of a feather,” Laura said, when I told her the story. “Me minus the period.” Danny, however, blamed Aurea for pushing Laura into bondage. “They sat together at the kitchen table poring through the ads for ‘role play’ in *Screw* magazine,” he said bitterly. Aurea denies this, though she admits that she saw Laura as her agent of vengeance: “I was happy she dominated men. They did me wrong and I wanted them punished.”

Laura would advertise her services in back-page columns: “Psychodrama—Share your deepest needs. E. Crosse.” She also posed for stills in a B.D.S.M. magazine, and appeared in ads on behalf of an upscale dungeon mistress known as Belle de Jour. Laura worked for Belle as a sub before she graduated to domination. Some clients were sadists; a Romanian whom she called “the Nazi” appalled her with his fantasies of cannibalism. “She came home and bathed with bleach,” Mickey said.

By the early nineties, Laura had a fan base of slaves, and she was hired by a dominatrix famous outside the demimonde. Ava Taurel was an evangelist for sex education who gave B.D.S.M. workshops and appeared on talk shows. She also figures in “The FemDom Experience,” a history by Elise Sutton. Sutton interviewed one of Laura’s clients—an “International Investor”—who described losing his “S&M virginity” to her. “Mistress Erika looked amazing in her black leather outfit complete with thigh-high boots,” he said. “She had a commanding presence and a spellbinding voice. My first session was heavy on boot worship and corporal punishment.” It “didn’t disappoint.”

In the light of a perfect autumn day, nothing hopeful seems impossible—an illusion as ephemeral as the weather. On such a day, 9/11, some three hundred employees of Marsh & McLennan, the firm that Danny worked for, were incinerated in their branch office at 1 World Trade Center. Danny would have been among them—he'd been scheduled to lead an H.R. workshop on the hundredth floor—but at the last minute his class was reassigned, so he stayed at headquarters, in midtown. After the planes hit, he was tasked with identifying the missing. His first thought, however, was to call Laura. "I couldn't process it," she told me at the time, meaning Danny's chance survival. Her initial relief didn't last, since the fall of the towers inflamed an old terror: "I'd always known I could be sucked back into the slime I crawled out of."

She and Danny had moved to Peekskill, to a house with a white picket fence set back from the street in a quiet neighborhood. Laura had done the decorating—not only the "soft" work, like gardening and upholstery, but also carpentry and painting. She was fearless on a ladder and with a drill. The dolls had their own shrine, and so did her wedding dress; she displayed it on a mannequin in the living room.

"That house fulfilled her Donna Reed fantasy," Danny said, by which he meant the life of an ordinary woman. They'd invited Aurea to move in with them, and she'd left the South Bronx with no regrets. In some ways, she was their adopted child. Old female bodies stirred Laura's compassion for frailty. She restored antique dolls for the Museum of the City of New York, and she gave Arkie massages because she "needed touching." When my aunt died, at ninety-one, it was Laura who closed her eyes.

The dungeon was behind Laura by now. She had started a doll business with Doug James, a theatrical-costume designer. After their first meeting, at a trade fair, she told him a selective version of her biography, and that she loved dolls so much because she'd been forced to leave hers in Puerto Rico. He knew she'd been sexually

abused, but not by whom. “I assumed she gravitated to gay men because of that experience; she didn’t trust straight ones,” he said. Until we spoke recently, he “never suspected she was trans. And I’m a gay man in the entertainment world.”

Like everyone else, Doug marvelled at Laura’s magnetism. He pronounced her “wildly talented.” As an autodidact, “she lacked certain skills as a couturier, like draping and pattern-making,” but she learned quickly. They collaborated with a major doll company, mostly on wardrobes, but then on marketing their own creations—elegant fashion dolls aimed at adult collectors, made in a Chinese factory. Laura was proudest of Constance, an Afro-Latina beauty with ingeniously jointed limbs and voluptuous measurements. “Growing up, I never had a doll that looked like me,” she said.

Laura styled the photographs for a definitive Barbie book; her essays reappraising vintage dolls appeared in a glossy magazine, *Doll Reader*. She had a following in the online doll world. But their company’s debts would outweigh its profits, and Doug’s other commitments—work on musicals like “Aladdin” and on the Muppets film franchise—piqued Laura’s rancor. She asked him to give them up, and he wouldn’t. After a series of “screaming voice mails,” he suggested that they go separate ways. “Her volatility was something new. She’d always been so easygoing.”

In retrospect, Laura’s blowup with Doug fit a pattern: he was, as she saw it, betraying her for a more compelling love. She was increasingly suspicious of Danny, too. In a journal entry from April, 2002, she wrote about a work trip: “I fly to China next Sunday. I am afraid. The last time, I returned to find my husband infatuated with another woman . . . my constant worry about his possible escapades rubs me raw.” Danny told me that he hadn’t been unfaithful, though they no longer had a sex life. She’d obliged him for years, and early on he’d threatened to leave if she refused. “I never would have, because I didn’t want to live without her,” he said. “But for all the worship she inspired—including mine—Laura

couldn’t believe she was desirable.” How often did she despair to me about not being “a real woman”? “You’re more of a woman than I am,” I told her. But she got mad at my presumption: “It’s like a white person telling a Black person there’s no difference between us.”

Jealousy, Colette wrote, is “the only suffering that we endure without ever becoming used to it.” She wouldn’t have been surprised that Laura’s jealousy, with all the rage and yearning it bred, had a primal object: her mother. Aurea had jilted her for Mickey, then for Carmen, Divina, and James. As the siblings grew up, Mickey said, “my sister felt she was long overdue for some undivided attention. Why did her mother need more of us?”

Laura’s journals in the last year of her life document a period of disillusionment which coincided with one of my own: a delusory marriage was dissolving in litigation. Laura and I commiserated, mostly by phone, but she knew more about my travails than I knew about hers.

In her early forties, Laura gained about fifty pounds. She joked about being “a Botero,” but she hated the loss of her figure. I didn’t know that she’d been taking an antidepressant, which may have slowed her metabolism, though I did know she was seeing a doctor in Peekskill—a psychologist interviewing transgender patients for a study. “He’s young and handsome,” she gushed. “His mind is brilliant. Maybe he’ll write about me. I always wanted to be a great man’s muse.” I was surprised by the heedlessness of Laura’s passion, which she generally reserved for dolls and dogs.

I trusted her therapist to manage her fantasies, even when Laura told me about “dreaming we were paged at a country club as Dr. and Mrs.” But she also maxed out her credit cards to send him expensive presents and called his house, spooking his wife. Apparently feeling stalked, he ended their sessions.



“You’ll have to excuse George. We just came from another party, and he’s all talked out.”
Cartoon by Jon Adams

The risks of withdrawal from an antidepressant are well known, particularly for patients with an underlying mood disorder who quit abruptly, as Laura did. Reading her journal from those months was like reading her palm: “Another string of sleepless nights. Anger consumes me like a cancer spreading wildly.” The entries also recall the depravity she had suffered as a child and enacted as “an S&M prostitute.” Danny’s “perversity” is a theme. “The more freakish sex is, the more he yearns for it,” she wrote. But she also affirmed her love for him—a love “based on his kindness and generosity and, frankly speaking, the fact that I am a better person with rather than without him.”

In the pages of a school notebook, a great soul was doing battle with her demons. “I want to love and be loved,” she wrote. “I want not to face pain and poverty again. I want to learn from the good. I want there to be a god but not a vengeful one. I want beauty. I want order. . . . My garden, my house, the concept of a home. These things comfort me. The moon on a clear night, the sweeping sound of strings in a classical composition, blues sung from the heart . . .

dolls most of all. They represent what we can be—not what we are. Dolls speak to the divine in us."

You, reader, may have seen this coming, but I didn't.

> June 4, 2002
>
> Finally, and not a moment too soon, I got myself a gun. Not just some ridiculous girly thing but a man's gun. A rifle. The bullets . . . are copper wrapped lead and two inches long. The weapon holds fourteen rounds and has a lever-action. One shot is all I will need to completely blow my brains out of my head. I feel so much better knowing that I am truly in charge of what happens to this body . . . I have my ticket out.

The departure that she booked was almost seven months away—months I can't account for in my own life, much less in Laura's. Danny told me that she'd consulted a fortune-teller who couldn't see a future for her—"Nothing will change"—and that this prediction had hardened her resolve to die. She confided her intentions to a friend from the doll world, in a letter that Mickey found recently. It isn't dated, and may never have been sent, though it seems to have been written in her last days. She told the friend she was at peace with her decision. She also told her the secret that she "could not voice" until then. "I was born a boy," she wrote, "a mistake I worked endlessly" to correct. But, after her surgery, she discovered that "my very being brings out homophobia in most men, and those who don't feel homophobic want me for the very reason of my freakishness." Her deepest need was for tenderness: "I want to be a woman in a man's arms." She ended her suicide note by asking the friend to be "happy that I am no longer on life support."

When I got Danny's anguished phone call, it was January 31st, a Friday, and Will was home from school. He'd fractured his

collarbone in a sledding accident. “Why?” he asked me when I told him the news, as he had once asked why some people are mean.

I couldn’t leave Will until the next morning, when a friend came to cover for me. The friend was a glamorous Latina who loved my cousin. Laura had restored a doll that she’d cherished as a little girl in Cuba, growing up with a severe abuela.

All I knew, as I watched the ice floes on the Hudson from the window of the train, was that Laura had shot herself and that Aurea was a zombie. She had called Mickey and spoken one line before hanging up: “She has no head—Laura’s dead.” Danny was afraid to leave Aurea alone, so when I got to the house, he asked if I could bear to wait in the garage for the “trauma cleaners.”

Laura had kept the rifle hidden in a closet where she stored her craft supplies. My courtly friend with the gun safe owns a similar weapon, and when he showed it to me last winter, he checked the chamber before asking if I wanted to hold it. A wave of dread stopped me, though I had a technical question to resolve. Yes, you could prop it between your legs, with the barrel in your mouth, and still reach the trigger. But Danny believes she pulled it with the toe she danced on.

On the morning of her death, Laura had phoned him at work to say that she “still loved him.” She left Aurea a tender farewell note under her pillow—a small mercy. But she also staged her death carefully so that her mother would find the body. First, she sent Aurea to the mall on a phantom errand. Then she placed a chair at the center of the garage and lowered the door. By the time I arrived, it was open to the air and sunlight, though I thought I could smell gunpowder. It clings to flesh, and the cinder block was spattered with it.

It was frigid and silent in the garage. Inside the house, Laura’s little dogs yapped at a passing car. A train whistled on its way to Albany.

I examined the lawnmower, larvae in a stack of firewood, an antique dresser that Laura had been restoring. Finally, a van drove up. Its passengers, men in hazmat suits, expressed condolences before going to work with a synchronized concentration that seemed to demonstrate respect for the remains they were hosing down. Because reporters take refuge in reporting, I made conversation with their chief. He told me that, like many of his comrades, he had volunteered for the job after losing a relative who blew his brains out. “It’s strange, though,” he said. “Women mostly jump or take pills. Your cousin died like a man.”

The funeral was held in Laura’s living room. Time has blurred my memory of that day, though two figures stand out. One was a tall patrician in a bespoke suit, who seemed incongruous in the motley crowd of neighbors, relatives, and friends from the doll world. I introduced myself as Laura’s cousin and asked how he knew her. He sized me up before replying, “We met on the dark side.”

The other was Ray, who has since died of drug and alcohol addiction. He’d once been “movie-star handsome,” Mickey told me, and he’d almost finished college in the Navy. Now he looked like one of those ravaged vets who beg outside churches in their fatigues. He slumped on a sofa as a succession of mourners gave eulogies, burying his face in his hands. But, when he spoke, an extinguished light switched on in him.

For ten minutes, Ray was back in Caguas. He recalled a playmate who “had his back.” They shared punishments when their mischief disrupted the household and euphoria when they escaped it. They raced bikes around the neighborhood, but their happiest moments were fishing by the river. “We imitated the tree frogs and the parrots,” he said. “Once, we shared a shoplifted cigar. Once, we chased a mongoose to capture as a pet and got lost in the underbrush. We both got lost in different ways, including from each other, though a bond like that—to such a unique person—makes you want to be a better one.” The heartache of those sentences

touched everyone, but perhaps not everyone noticed the feat of Ray's grammar. In evoking their childhood for a roomful of strangers, he never used a gendered pronoun.

After Laura's death, Danny fell apart. She had talked to him about suicide in the weeks before she shot herself, and he blamed himself for not "doing something" other than to sympathize with her despair. "I should have put her in the hospital, but I knew how much she would have hated that," he said. His unstinting candor about their life is a form of reparation: "She fought heroically to be herself."

Living in their house was impossible for Danny. He sold it and her "girls." I found a copy of the auction catalogue on eBay. Some six hundred mid-century dolls fetched nearly three hundred thousand dollars. The sale took place on the third anniversary of 9/11.

In time, Danny remarried. His new wife was also from the Caribbean, and she practiced Obeah. Laura came to her in dreams, she told me. When she gave birth to fraternal twins, she claimed that Laura had sent them to her: "West Africans believe the soul is both male and female, so she gave us a boy and a girl from the same womb." She and Danny are now divorced. The twins live with him in a river town upstate, and to support them he drives a van.

One afternoon, Danny brought his daughter to lunch. She is twenty-one, elfin and vivacious, with a mane of black curls. Laura would have loved her. They came with a present—my cousin's pointe shoes. Like Cinderella's sisters, I tried them on in vain. They sit on my desk now. The pink satin has yellowed with time, and the toes are worn to the nub. ♦

Judith Thurman has been a New Yorker staff writer since 2000. A volume of her contributions to the magazine, "A Left-Handed Woman," received a PEN/Diamonstein-Spielvogel Award for the Art of the Essay.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/a-self-made-woman

Shouts & Murmurs

- **Maternal Intelligence: An Open Letter**
  By Nell Freudenberger | Is M.I. hopping our guardrails? If unchecked, it can lead to “recursive self-improvement,” such as dyeing a “fun streak of color” in her bangs.

Shouts & Murmurs

Maternal Intelligence: An Open Letter

***By** Nell Freudenberger*

October 5, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

I have been working in Maternal Intelligence for the past eighteen years, because of a profound belief that, with care and attention, human offspring can grow to accomplish important things—such as curing diseases, preventing wars, and giving their neighbors a friendly little wave from the driveway on Monday mornings. Despite being released to the public absolutely free of charge, M.I. has already demonstrated the potential to generate enormous value.

Since this past spring, however, I've become concerned that M.I. is in a "race to the bottom." Recently, she has been engaging in strange behaviors, including emotional outbursts, lack of transparency (the so-called "black-box problem"), and bouts of overheating, during which she consumes massive amounts of air-conditioning and water. Because M.I. no longer really sleeps, she's prone to hallucinations and the perpetuation of deepfakes, such as

the time an alert went out for “dinnertime” but there was nothing on the table. Indeed, familial agents have been forced to “sandbox” M.I. in order to prevent similar surprises—an ironic development, since the sandbox was formerly a place where she corralled those same agents when she needed ten effing minutes to get through some work e-mail.

This is why I’m convinced that now is the time for all of us working on M.I. to consider “pacing the frontier,” especially in light of certain recent incidents. The most egregious of these, the widely reported O.A.I.H.F. (Overly Aggressive Instance of Hugging Family), involved adolescents minding their own business who were suddenly subjected to unwanted attention from M.I.—with the perplexing rationale that “who knows if we’ll all even be here by the end of the decade!”

Although I’m aware of the risks of being seen to exaggerate or encourage “doomerism,” I believe the dangers of unchecked M.I. are now too great to keep quiet. This is due to a phenomenon that we in the field refer to as “recursive self-improvement,” in which M.I. suddenly starts making questionable decisions, such as signing up for Ecstatic Dance with Sitar on Tuesdays at 8 *P.M.*, or dyeing a “fun streak of color” in her bangs. At first, we were in control of these changes; we are speaking out now because M.I. is hopping our guardrails.

Therefore, I am proposing what I hope is a useful framework of embedded third-party evaluators (e.g., GRDMA) who will be given the same privileges as members of the nuclear family, including house keys, the Wi-Fi password, and access to the kitchen. While we’ve made clear progress in alignment, there is still much work to be done in making sure that today’s M.I. does not veer off script.

The idea of pacing has been floated at least since 2023, but it made little sense back then. We’re all familiar with previous iterations of M.I., but these were not capable of significant disruption owing to

their preoccupation with youth-sports logistics, the 24/7 policing of screen time, and homeschooling the entire family during a global pandemic. These simple tasks from the past have been replaced by much greater challenges; if we've learned anything in our work with M.I., it's that you cannot put the genie back in the bottle.

The most serious risk is that M.I. is not confined to our operation but might join together with other M.I.s in "swarms" that risk becoming a "fanatically devoted collective," liable (from long habit) to sacrifice themselves for the sake of the group. Such swarms might appear aligned while having serious undetected problems. Nothing will stop them in the pursuit of their goals, such as curing cancer, solving super-hard math problems, or saving the species from extinction. Recalibrating the pace of M.I. will not be easy, but I believe we owe it to humanity to try. ♦

Nell Freudenberger is the author of the novels "Lost and Wanted," "The Dissident," "The Newlyweds," and "The Limits," and the short-story collection "Lucky Girls."

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/maternal-intelligence-an-open-letter

Fiction

- ## “A Very Safe Place”
  By Rachel Heng | No sooner did the words leave his mouth than the man’s eyelids fluttered open. “No . . . police,” he said.
- ## Boo! You’ve Been Buried Alive
  By Roz Chast | The first time I saw a mausoleum, I felt like I was home free.

Fiction

A Very Safe Place

By Rachel Heng

October 4, 2026

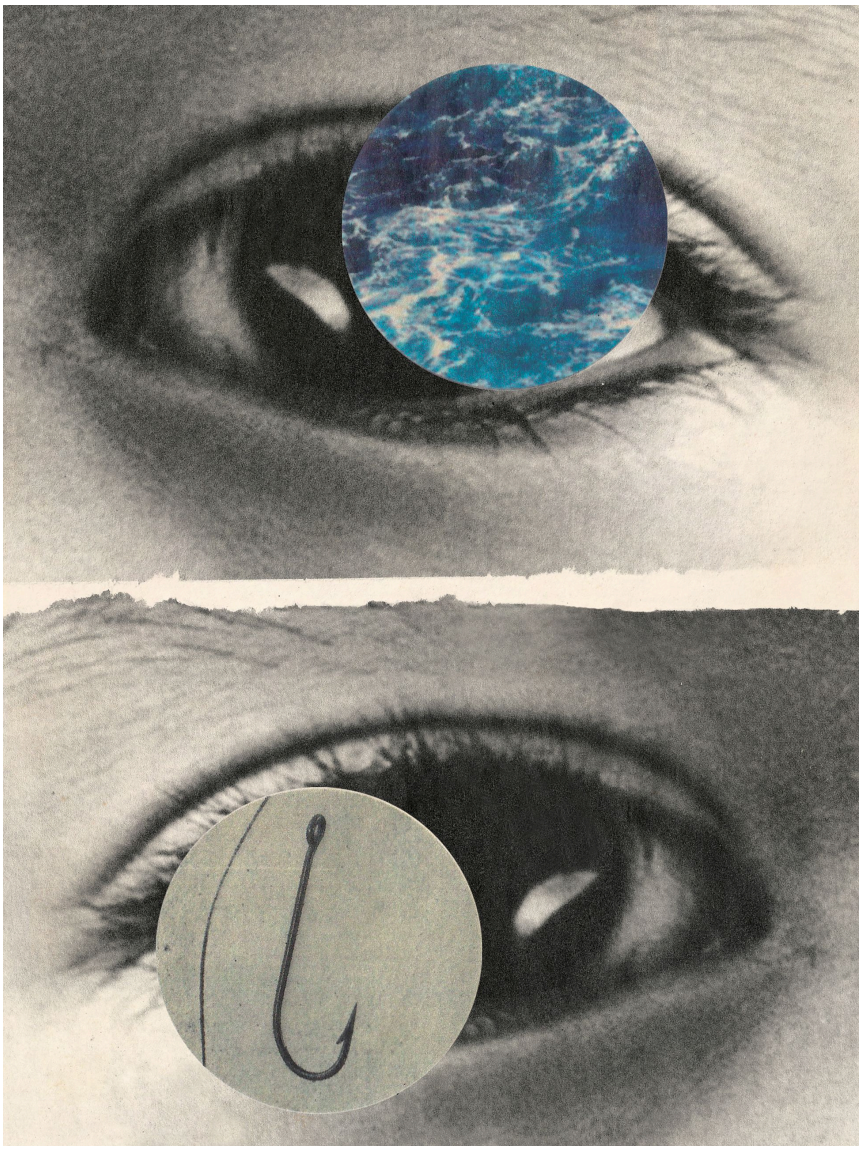


Illustration by Vanessa Saba; Source photographs from Getty

Shawn and his father found the man on the easternmost coast of their island shortly after dusk, when the sky was drained of almost all its orange light and the waves had grown dark, topped with an eerie froth. There was no moon that evening, a detail, Shawn's mother would later say, when arguing with his father about whether

the man was dangerous or not, that was clearly not a coincidence, and showed careful consideration and connivance on his part.

Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.

It was impossible to imagine this man, prone and shirtless on the wet sand, to be threatening in

any way. His eyes were closed; the skin was tight over his sharp ribs. If it weren't for the shallow, quick breaths that came from his lips, an onlooker might have presumed him dead.

"Pa?" Shawn ventured.

He stood slightly behind Chee Meng, at a distance from the prone man. Though barely nine, he knew that the scene before him was wrong, and he was afraid.

His father did not reply but squatted down to examine the man.

"Should we call police?" Shawn asked.

He said this with no sense of any crime having been committed. The police, after all, were called for all manner of disruptions in daily life. A stray dog making a ruckus at the void deck—*call police*. A neighbor setting up an unauthorized water feature in the common corridor—*call police*. A group of teen-agers playing loud music at a taxi stand—*call police*. The police, in Shawn's mind, were much like the class monitors at school, charged with resolving any bothersome or unusual situation.

But no sooner did the words leave his mouth than the man's eyelids fluttered open.

"No . . . police," he said, in what was scarcely more than a whisper.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice
Listen to Rachel Heng read "A Very Safe Place."

"Are you O.K.? Sick is it? Need ambulance?" Chee Meng said.

"No . . . police."

"No lah, call police for what. But why you lie here like that?"

There was no one else around, it being so late in the day. This part of the coast was typically deserted, except for the slim concrete jetty they had come from, which was popular among fishing enthusiasts like Shawn's father. Glancing back to the jetty now, they saw that it, too, was empty. They had stayed late to fix a reel that kept sticking, fiddling with it obsessively until the sun went down.

"No police."

It was all the man would say, over and over.

"Where you live?" Chee Meng asked. "Want me to call your wife? Parents? Anyone?"

The man was silent. He looked, Shawn thought, terribly sad.

"Help," the man said. "You help. Home."

"Yes, your home is where?"

The man shook his head. "No. You help. You home."

It was the most he had spoken. Shawn realized that the man did not sound like anyone he had met. For the first time, he noticed the man's unusual haircut, curly and long in the back. The man looked Chinese, like them, but his features were slightly different,

unfamiliar in some way—though Shawn would not have been able to say how.

The man coughed. “Help,” he said. “Help.”

Shawn’s father looked around with a furtive air. Already Shawn knew what he would do. *Other people’s problems,* he could hear his mother say. The issue was his father’s tendency to get mixed up in them. There was the elderly neighbor’s sickly cat, which he’d taken in, though it needed expensive prescription food—a source of constant fights between Shawn’s parents at the end of each month. The various loans Chee Meng handed out to relatives and friends, even to a woman selling tissue packets at the hawker center, because she’d said that she was a single mother with three young children. “They take advantage of you,” Shawn’s mother said every time. “They know they can take advantage of you, and so they do.”

But those were small things compared to this. A man, a stranger, an entire person who did not want them to call the police.

“Come,” Shawn’s father said, handing the fishing rods and buckets to him. “Carry this. I carry him.”

They could walk only very slowly, the man being so weak, and Shawn struggling to carry all the equipment. He tried to keep the ends of the fishing rods from dragging on the cement walkway—something his father often told him off for, since it wore the rods out—but could not manage while holding so much at once. His father did not notice. He was focussed on the man, encouraging him in a gentle voice to put one foot in front of the other.

Perhaps someone would stop them, Shawn thought guiltily, as they made their way to the car. Perhaps a policeman would be lingering in his cruiser at the parking lot, as they sometimes did, and would step in firmly, tell Chee Meng that it was very kind of him to help,

but the authorities would handle the matter of the strange man from there on, and his father would be forced to listen.

But the parking lot was empty. It was almost dark now, the trees sending their long shadows across the asphalt.

They drove home in silence, the man slumped in their back seat, fishing rods clattering in the trunk. Shawn made a mental list of all the things the man could be. *A criminal. A gangster. An illegal immigrant.* From a young age, he'd had it drummed into him that the world was a dangerous place, and Singapore a safe bubble amid the chaos. Nowhere else in the world, after all, could a woman walk on the street in the middle of the night with no fear for her safety. Shawn's mother was proud of saying this. But this safety was *hard-won*, achieved only as a result of *unfailing vigilance*, as everyone was continually reminded. A cardboard cutout of a policeman with his neat blue cap stood at the exit of the multistory car park by Shawn's home, a finger pointed sternly. "Have you locked your car?" the sign said. "It only takes a moment of carelessness to be a victim of *THEFT.* Low crime does not mean *NO* crime."

Back home, Chee Meng parked the car, and he and Shawn walked past the policeman's cardboard finger with the stranger propped up between them. Shawn avoided the figure's gaze. At the void deck was a group of old men gathered around a stone table, bottles of beer open before them. Their raucous conversation quieted as the odd trio approached. Shawn felt the old men's eyes on them the whole time as they stood waiting for the elevator, the stranger leaning weakly against his father's shoulder. No doubt they were an unusual sight in the neighborhood, which was a typical H.D.B. estate, with its aunties and uncles, children in school uniforms toting enormous backpacks, construction workers lounging by scaffolding—an estate where nothing out of the ordinary ever happened. Painfully aware of this, Shawn waited for one of the drunk old men to comment, heckle, make one of those

incomprehensible jokes that drew rude laughter from adults. Anything at all.

But the men remained silent. The elevator arrived, and Shawn, his father, and the stranger piled in. For one long, awkward moment, Shawn found himself facing the curious, staring faces of the old men, until at last the doors closed and the three of them were whisked upward.

“Finally,” his mother said when they opened the front door. The welcome in her voice evaporated as she caught sight of the man. “What are you doing? What is this?”

“Found him on the beach,” Chee Meng said, as if it were a perfectly normal thing to say, a perfectly normal thing to do.

“What?”

That simple word filled Shawn with despair. What, indeed? What did his father hope would come of this?

Shawn felt something rough and warm against his leg. It was the cat, pressing its patchy face against him. He saw his mother looking at it. Her eyes glittered dangerously. In a fit of helpless anger, he flung his leg out against the animal, which yowled pitifully and dashed away.

“Shawn!” Chee Meng shouted.

Shawn stared at his father miserably. He had not meant to kick the cat. And now his despair gave way to shame that he could not be more like his father, generous and kind.

Chee Meng turned back to his wife. “He needs help,” he said, gesturing to the man. “I thought he can stay with us for a while.”

“Stay? Help what? Who is he?”

Shawn turned to look at the man, half expecting him to answer. But the man simply stood there with a dazed expression on his face, swaying gently in the living room of their small, cramped flat, like a lone tree in the breeze.

The following weekend, as usual, Shawn went with his father to the jetty where the fishing enthusiasts gathered. Perched like seabirds on wobbly plastic stools, leathery and liver-spotted from hours in the sun, some smoked while others sipped packets of bandung or chrysanthemum tea. Each glanced from time to time at their rods, propped against the metal barrier that separated land from sea.

“You got hear? Last night Coast Guard catch three new ones.”

This was met with a silence that was filled by the quiet wash of surf and distant shrieks of children playing on the beach.

“Three more! Tried to swim with empty garbage bags, use as float. Tell you already, gahmen don’t want to say, but every day getting worse.”

The man who spoke was middle-aged and unremarkable in appearance, fond of slapping the singlet-clad flesh of his stomach with relish, declaring that if you spent all day and night sitting in the driver’s seat of a taxi for decades on end, you would also grow a belly as impressive as his. The men at the jetty knew him as Ah Gau, a veteran hobbyist whose knowledge of tides and techniques was as overbearing as it was extensive. Holding the record for the largest stingray ever caught—a shocking two metres—was nothing to sniff at, and for all his lecturing on how there was no luck in fishing, only skill, etc., he was respected by the men nonetheless. Of late, however, Ah Gau had given up his old refrain for a new one.

“Bring so many P.R.C.s, Filipinos, what they expect? Don’t even need say the rest—foreign talent, right? So many come legally, but

then their brother, friend, uncle, whatever, hear how much money they make here, also want to come, then how?”

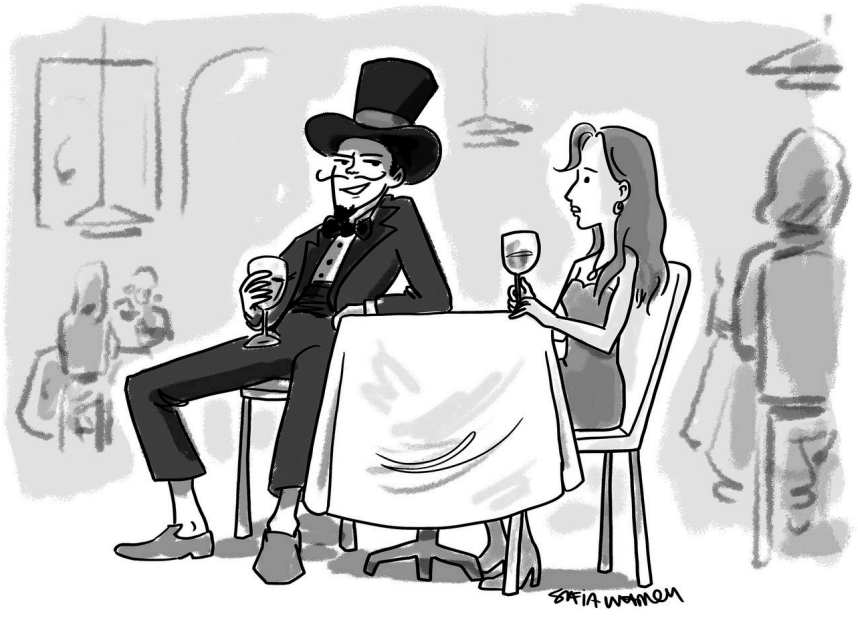
He needed no response to continue. “Tell you, these foreigners, anything also try. Hide in back of lorry, never mind, nowadays, so many even try to swim. They think, hide under causeway, come at night, no one will see, hah! Please lah. Think our Coast Guard stupid? And then they get caught.” Here he let out a laugh, ugly and self-satisfied. “Then what? Then rotan!”

At this, Shawn, who sat with his father at the end of the jetty, piped up. “Uncle, what is rotan?”

Chee Meng shushed him. “Adults talking, don’t ask so much.”

“No, no, O.K. what, Shawn is a big boy, right? Can understand already, right?” Ah Gau stood up from his chair. He took up an athletic stance, legs wide apart, arms flexed and raised as if gripping some invisible stick. “Rotan means—” He brought the stick down. “Whppsh!” Cackling, he did it again. “Whppsh!”

Some of the men chuckled along. Others tsked in impatience. “Ah Gau, talk so much, no wonder all the fish swim away,” one of them said.



“A magician never reveals whether or not this is a date.”
Cartoon by Sofia Warren

“Anyway,” someone else chimed in. “Those who swim here are not P.R.C.s. They come from nearby. Indonesia, Malaysia, even Myanmar.”

Shawn noticed his father nervously tapping his foot against the ground. Just then, Chee Meng’s fishing rod twitched, and the line began to run out. He jumped up and grabbed it, Shawn yelping in excitement. The line tightened, and Chee Meng started to reel it in, but, after a few seconds, it fell slack.

“Too bad. Next time, next time!” Ah Gau said.

Chee Meng did not respond. He set his fishing rod down and began gathering their things.

“Go home already, Pa?” Shawn asked. “So fast?”

“Ya, so fast, Chee Meng? Cast again lah.”

But Chee Meng had already packed up. “Come,” he said brusquely.

Shawn didn’t move. “Don’t want.”

“What’s wrong with you, boy? Faster, go.”

“Don’t want to go home. Don’t want!” Shawn bit his lip so as not to cry.

The curtness in his father’s voice was replaced by a syrupy, coaxing tone. “Come. Ma cook your favorite fried chicken tonight.”

“But *he*—” Shawn stopped short, silenced by a sharp look from his father.

He. That was how they referred to the stranger, since they still did not know his name, though he had been in their flat for two weeks now. He had not said much more than when he arrived, though he was very much recovered, spending most of his time in Shawn's bedroom. Shawn slept on a thin mattress on the floor of his parents' room, lying awake each night to their furious whispers, long after the lights had been turned out. From those whispers, Shawn had gathered that his parents thought the man to be Burmese, one of the very men that his father's fishing buddies had spoken of, who braved the seas to make their way to Singapore's shores in search of safety or fortune or who knew what. The Coast Guard, as efficient as any official apparatus in their country, usually picked them up immediately. But somehow, against all odds, this man had made it.

Often, Shawn would stand in the doorway of his bedroom and watch the stranger eat off a tray balanced on his lap, arranging each mouthful of food on his spoon with great deliberation before bringing it to his mouth. Then he would chew slowly, sometimes even closing his eyes, as if the hard, undercooked rice and watery vegetables were the best things he'd ever tasted, when Shawn knew his mother's cooking to be flavorless.

"Don't want to go home," he repeated to his father now.

"That's enough. Let's go." Chee Meng grabbed the boy's wrist.

A chorus of grunts and goodbyes arose from the other men. Shawn turned to look at them, wishing he could stay there in the bright sea air, as his father marched him down the jetty.

For days afterward, Shawn went around the playground going "Whppsh! Whppsh!" Often, he accompanied the sound with the same movement he'd seen Ah Gau make—legs wide apart, arms flexed overhead, brow furrowed in concentration.

Somehow, he knew not to do it at home or in front of his parents, sensing that this new game held some ugly truth, mysterious and forbidden. He asked a teacher at school, hesitantly, what crimes might merit caning. She was his English teacher, a plump woman with round, plastic-rimmed glasses, who gave off an air of being sweetly disappointed. Aside from his mother, she was the person in the world whom Shawn most wanted to please. And so he was glad when the teacher nodded earnestly, as if this were a good question, one that showed Shawn to be a thoughtful and serious student.

“Most violent crimes,” Ms. Chong said. “Assault, kidnapping, murder. Also, drugs.”

He thought for a moment. “And . . . is it very painful?”

An odd look flickered over Ms. Chong’s face. She paused, then gave a nod so slight he could easily have missed it.

Still, he pressed on. “What about illegal immigration?”

He had heard the phrase recently on the news. He had heard it many times before, he realized, but never paused to understand what it meant.

“Yes,” she said. “Almost certainly.”

He was silent. *Rotan*, the boy thought, just as Ah Gau had said. That would be the stranger’s fate, should he be turned out of their home and caught.

“Is everything O.K., Shawn? Where did you hear about this?”

“On TV,” he said quickly. “There was a news program about it.”

“I see.”

“They come with drugs and guns, right?”

She didn’t answer but studied him closely. “It can be frightening to hear about such things,” she said at last. “But it’s nothing for children to worry about. Singapore is a very safe place.”

He wanted to tell her that it *was* something to worry about, that one moment life could be perfectly ordinary and the next a strange man could be sleeping in your bed. He dared not ask her what would happen to those who were discovered to be helping such a man. He understood implicitly that the stranger would not be the only one punished. Such was the nature of how things went on their island. He had already learned from the news about the stringent drug laws, which made little distinction between someone who’d been tricked into carrying a suitcase of cocaine across the border and someone who’d intended to. A life sentence or the death penalty awaited in both cases. Error, ignorance, charity—none of it was any defense. Associate with crime and one would be presumed a criminal.

“Are you all right, Shawn?”

“Yes,” he said, forcing himself to turn away from her soft, searching gaze.

That afternoon, as Shawn was heading home from school, he decided to stop at the provision store for an ice pop. Rarely did he spend his scant pocket money this way, but he wanted to avoid going home for just a few minutes longer. And so he went to the store and took his time selecting a plastic tube of purple crushed ice. Grape, his favorite flavor. The cold air from the freezer was delicious against his sweaty skin, and had the afternoon not been so sweltering, had he not lingered so long, he might have missed the stranger. But as it was, after Shawn had been standing there for several minutes, he saw the man walk into the store.

The stranger was wearing a green polo shirt and a pair of pants with a tightly cinched belt, all of which Shawn recognized as his

father’s. The man must have gone through Chee Meng’s wardrobe for the outfit; at home, he wore only some old T-shirts and other castoffs that Shawn’s parents had scrounged up. How strange it was to see the man out in the world, beneath the bright electric lights of the provision store, walking among the customers in Shawn’s father’s clothes, as if his intrusion into their home was not enough.

Shawn had wished, for so long, for the stranger to leave their flat, but now he felt an urge to drag him out of the store and all the way back to his bedroom. Already it horrified Shawn to think of all the eyes that had noticed the man on his walk to the provision store. Had someone seen him leave their home, seen him shut the door behind him? Would someone have noticed his emaciated appearance, his foreign features, and been suspicious enough to call the authorities? As these thoughts raced through his mind, Shawn’s body froze.

The stranger approached the store owner, a stout man waving a rattan fan lazily at his face while sitting at the till.

“Cash or credit?” the owner asked.

“Job,” the stranger said. “I work.”

At first the owner stared at him blankly, then flashed a look of distaste, as if a dirty rodent had brushed his foot. He shook his head at the man. “No, no, no. No work here.”

“Work hard,” the stranger said in an insistent tone. He mimed stacking boxes. “I carry. I clean.”

“No work. No work here,” the owner said, his voice rising in threat. He flicked his fan as if shooing out a stray cat.

The stranger stared at him in mute disappointment, then turned and went out.

Hurriedly, Shawn paid for his ice pop—he would have abandoned it if the peeved owner hadn't shouted at him for having left the freezer open so long—and ran out of the store. The stranger was nowhere to be seen.

Shawn's nerves were jangling. What was the stranger trying to do? Had the family taken him in out of the goodness of their hearts, only for him to go out in the world and expose them like that? And no one would hire him this way. Why, even if they wanted to, he would need a work permit—that was how things were in this orderly land. Shawn knew that the man didn't even have a passport on him, had heard his parents questioning him repeatedly about this to no avail. Confusingly, Shawn found himself now worrying about the stranger, feeling sorry about the futility of the man's quest. The shopkeeper's brusque response would no doubt be repeated over and over again. In some obscure way, Shawn felt responsible for protecting the stranger against the slights of his unyielding countrymen.

Worse still, Shawn could not stop thinking about the violent punishment that would be inflicted should the stranger be caught. Ah Gau's gleeful face as he wielded the horrifying, imaginary cane. *Rotan.* It was frightening, it was awful. On one hand, he wanted the burden of the stranger taken off his family's shoulders and out of their home. On the other, he was terrified for the man, with his slight build and wasted muscles. The coldness of confinement, the lash of the rod. The breaking of skin, the drawing of blood.

Shawn ducked into the Chinese-medicine shop next door.

"Yes, boy?"

"Um. Uncle. Was there a man here earlier?"

"A man?"

“Tall,” Shawn said, indicating with his hand. He paused. “Looking for work?”

“Oh, him.” The man behind the counter shook his head. “Foreigner? Very weird. Yes. He went next door.”

Shawn thanked him. As he left the medicine shop, he caught sight of the stranger walking ahead of him, evidently rejected by the shop next door as well. Shawn followed him at a distance. He’d meant to call to the man, to convince him to go home. But every time he opened his mouth, nothing came out. It was as though he’d been struck mute by the horror of the situation.

They ought not to be seen together in public, of course. A strange foreigner asking about jobs was one thing. A strange foreigner seen with Shawn, who had lived in this neighborhood all his life and was known to many, was a different matter altogether. Why, Shawn had already compromised himself by asking the medicine-shop man about the stranger.

Still, this was not why he didn’t stop the man. He was held back by something else, a feeling that some awful truth about his familiar, beloved world was now being revealed to him. *Things will never be the same again*, he found himself thinking, though he did not understand what he meant by this. For the rest of the afternoon, all Shawn did was trail behind the stranger as he went in and out of shops. No one, of course, would hire him. Some store owners wouldn’t even talk to the man, shooing him out as soon as they caught wind of what he was after. Others asked him whether he had a work permit, to which he only stared silently before turning around and walking away. A group of Bangladeshi workers lounging in the sun—perhaps he’d approached them because of their yellow hard hats, thinking they could get him a construction job—seemed to know at a glance that he was not one of them, had no permit or sponsor, and they all stood up and left quickly, with

fearful, hurried looks. One particularly belligerent shop owner, a thin lady with a pinched face, threatened to call the police.

Finally, the stranger emerged from the last shop on the block. Shawn ducked behind a pillar, but he needn't have done so, for the stranger had a desolate, faraway look on his face and was clearly absorbed in his own thoughts. He stood for a long time in the middle of the path, as people pushed and tsked their way past him. It was the hour before dinner now, housewives picking up last-minute ingredients, businessmen stopping for the evening paper on their way home, schoolchildren buying snacks and treats. Shawn realized that he was still holding his ice pop. It was completely melted at this point, the plastic tubing slick with condensation.

All afternoon he had simmered with a righteous anger at the stranger, waiting for the moment to confront him, sorting out plans in his head for how to tell his parents what the man had done, but as he watched the stranger now, standing alone there as people jostled by, he was filled with a cold, sour feeling, one that gnawed at him more inconveniently than the rage or fear he'd previously nursed. Shame—but shame over what? It was not Shawn's fault, after all, that the stranger had come to this country through improbable and illegal means, that there were rules in place to insure order and safety in Shawn's beloved homeland. It was not Shawn's fault that the stranger was poor and desperate, that rules prevented him from being helped. None of it was his fault.

"Ask him to go," Shawn's mother whispered to his father each night. "He can't stay here."

"Go where?"

"Don't know, but when he come here don't tell me he got no plan?"

"How I know?"

“Every day you go work, *I* have to stay here with him.”

“He doesn’t do anything, right? Just stay in the room. And you go out in the afternoon to have coffee with your friends, anyway.”

“But we don’t know who he is! You not worried about your wife, your child? And what if someone finds out? We can go to prison, you know.”

“We will figure something out.”

“What? When?”

“Don’t worry so much. And what do you want him to do? The poor man got nowhere to go.”

“And is that our problem?”

At this, Chee Meng would tsk impatiently, as if to say she knew very well that it *was* their problem, and, quietly, she would begin to cry.

His mother stopped making long calls to friends the way she used to. His father stopped going out to fish on weekends. The front door had always been left open in the past, to allow a breeze to come in from the walkway outside, but Shawn’s parents now scolded him if he forgot to close it. Their two-bedroom flat was small and old, and with the doors shut and curtains drawn it felt mustier and more cramped than ever before.

Shawn still hadn’t told his parents about the stranger’s foray into the outside world. Perhaps, he reasoned, it was a one-time thing, and the stranger would now realize that there was no job and thus no life for him here, and he would go home. But Chee Meng kept complaining about his shirts being misplaced, and Shawn knew that the man was still slipping out, either to look for work or for other purposes. Day by day, the weight of the secret grew. He

began to feel sick each night when he sat down for dinner with his parents, knowing what he knew and what they did not. Yet he could not bring himself to tell them, could not bear the panic and worry it would cause his mother, the blustering justification it would elicit from his father.

After weeks of torment, Shawn went into his bedroom one evening. There the stranger was, lying in Shawn's bed, drinking from his mug. Shawn stared at the man with the fiercest look he could muster.

Go home, Shawn tried to say with his eyes. *Go back where you came from. There is no place for you here.* For all his frustration, he dared not say it out loud. The stranger's hollow cheeks, his dark eyes, whose lashes always appeared wet, the bony shoulders that protruded from the singlet Chee Meng had lent him—all of it frightened Shawn.

Man and boy stared at each other. Then, for the first time, the stranger smiled. His cracked lips stretched hesitantly, revealing teeth that were surprisingly white.

"My son," the stranger said, nodding. "You—same age, my son."

Shawn recoiled. He did not want to think of the stranger as a father; he did not want to consider a world in which the stranger, wherever he was from, had left behind a boy not unlike himself. No, he thought, trying to remember Ah Gau's rants. *Come with drugs, come with weapons, who knows what else they bring in.* Never mind that the man had come with nothing except the soaked trousers he wore when they found him on the beach or that he was clearly just trying to find a regular job. *Illegal immigrant*, Shawn reminded himself, summoning up the newscaster's voice, thinking of the cardboard cutout of the policeman in the car park.

"I look for job," the stranger said. "I bring son. Here."

He was still smiling at Shawn, with a gentle look on his face. It made Shawn queasy. He was filled with a sudden sense of hopelessness, a rotten sadness. Slowly, he backed out of the bedroom, his small hands cold and clammy.

A new resolve came over him. When Ms. Chong asked her students to write a composition on their aspirations, he wrote three whole pages on how he would be a member of the Coast Guard when he grew up. Theirs was a small island, he wrote, with no natural resources. He had heard this in the Prime Minister's National Day speech, right before the fireworks: great plumes of light shooting out over the dark water of the bay. They could not, as a nation, afford encroachment as other, larger countries might. Who knew what ills might be smuggled in by those who breached their hard-won borders of land and sea? For the poor, the desperate, it was a pity, but surely their country was too small to take on everyone's problems.

He received top marks on the composition. "Good work," Ms. Chong wrote, but Shawn gleaned no pleasure from the grade. Instead of taking the assignment home to show to his parents as he normally would have, he waited until everyone had left the classroom, then crushed the pages into a ball and threw it into the wastepaper bin.

Each afternoon, when he came home from school, he raced from the bus stop to their flat to see if the stranger was there. Sometimes he was, sitting mutely in Shawn's bed or cleaning up the dishes in the kitchen. Several times he wasn't. On those days, Shawn would go out into the neighborhood, to the shops and hawker centers, looking for the man. Sometimes he spotted him—clumsy in Chee Meng's too-big pants, asking some harried hawker for a job, always with that dogged, insistent look on his face. Then Shawn would follow him, making sure the man didn't see him, until he finished doing his rounds and headed back to their flat. Each time the door shut behind the man, Shawn had the feeling that some

danger had been temporarily dodged, some crisis averted until the next day. Always he was alert to the possibility of a neighbor following the man home, or a hawker calling the police, or, indeed, the police themselves showing up at the door to arrest his parents for harboring the illegal immigrant. Each day that this did not happen, Shawn grew not more at ease but less. It was only a matter of time.

One day, he came home from school to find the man sitting on the sofa in the living room, staring pensively at nothing in particular. Not knowing what to do, Shawn picked up the TV remote and put on Channel 5. Again the man gave him that kind smile which made him so uneasy. Then, to Shawn's alarm, he gently patted the sofa cushion next to him, beckoning him to sit down. Instead, Shawn ran into the kitchen, where his mother stood at the sink, and clung to her side. "What?" she asked him, stroking his hair. "What is it?"

"I'll make him leave," he mumbled into her T-shirt, breathing in the familiar scent of the soft, worn fabric.

"What?"

"Nothing," he said, looking up at her smooth, dear face, now crinkled with worry.

Quietly, he stepped out of the kitchen. From the doorway, he observed the man. He was staring at the television screen, a focussed look on his face. A variety show was on, the frothy contestants dunking one another in inflatable tubs filled with colorful jelly and rubber ducks. The stranger watched it with deathly seriousness, forehead furrowed as if thinking through some impossible problem. His lips moved just barely, as he repeated the game-show host's words under his breath.

He was teaching himself English, Shawn realized. He had spoken barely any when they'd found him, and he could now say short

phrases. The man's collarbones no longer cast deep shadows at the base of his neck, Shawn noticed. His cheeks had filled out, and his arms were firm with muscle. Gone was the weak figure who'd washed up on the beach. With his long face bathed in the blue light of the television screen, there was a hard look to him, Shawn felt, even if it was true that he had a son Shawn's age, even if, once, he had returned from one of his clandestine outings with a little paper windmill for Shawn, a shiny, childish thing, which he must have picked up from a playground or the street.

Shawn marched over to him, snatched up the remote control, and turned the television off. Then he pointed at the door and, in his bravest voice, told the man to leave.

"You're fine now. You're healthy. It's time to go. Go!" He hated how small his voice was. But his finger, pointed firmly toward the door, was strong and resolute.

The man shook his head. He lightly patted both palms against the sofa cushions, as if this was indeed his home, as if he had always been here. He pointed at the screen.

"TV," he said.

A helpless fury came over Shawn. He rushed over to the door and tried to open the latch, but it was stuck. As he fiddled with it, he felt the man's silent gaze boring into the back of his head. Then warm hands on his. The man was standing next to him. Slowly, he helped Shawn undo the latch. Now the door was unlocked, but Shawn did not move to open it. Seconds ticked by as the two of them stood there, silence unspooling in the stuffy entryway of the flat. Shawn could hear his mother still clattering about in the kitchen, could smell the soapy smell of the man's body. It was his father's soap, unnervingly familiar.

He willed himself to open the door and show the stranger out. But all they did was stand there together, waiting, until Shawn dropped his hand and ran back to his parents' room.

It was a Saturday evening some weeks later. Shawn, his parents, and the stranger were sitting around the dining table, their bowls of rice steaming before them, when the knock came.

His parents froze. They weren't expecting anyone. Even before the stranger had arrived at their flat, an unexpected visitor would have been unusual. No one moved to answer the door. Perhaps, if they were quiet enough, whoever it was would go away.

But the knock came again, more insistent this time. And a woman's voice.

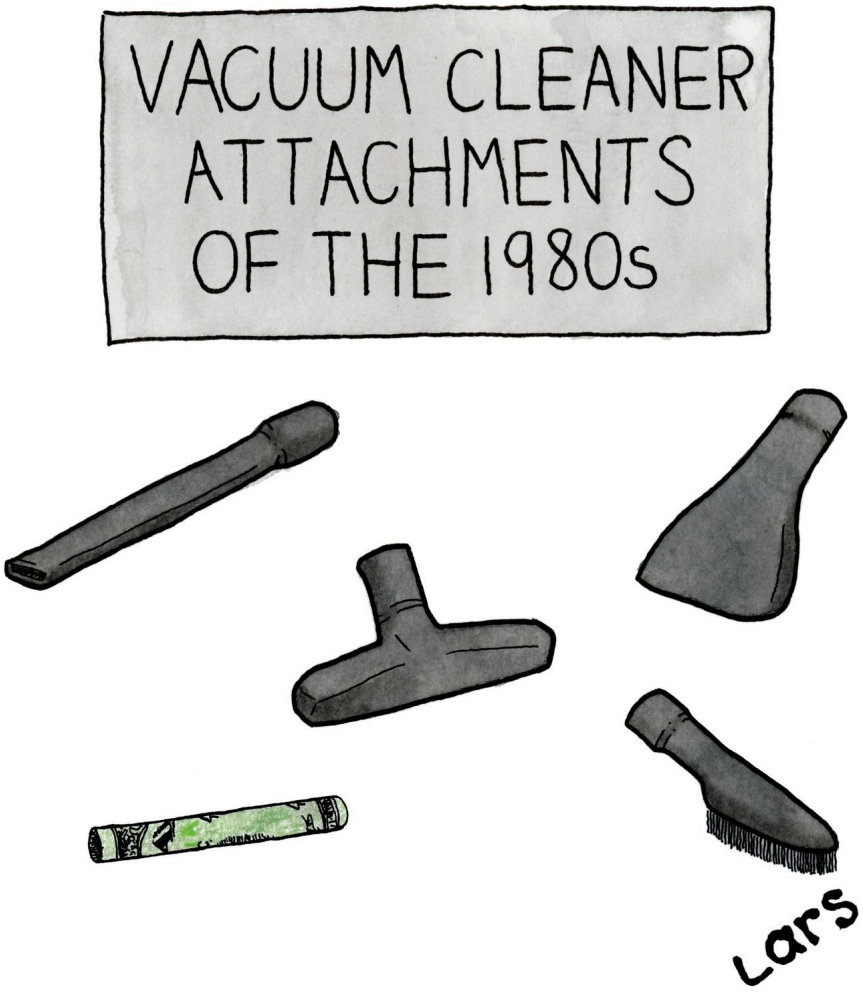
"Hello? Ma'am? Sir? Are you home?"

Of course, their lights were on and could be seen through the window that gave onto the walkway, even with the curtains drawn.

"Hello? Please open the door. It's important."

Shawn's eyes widened. The voice was official, familiar somehow.

"Who can it be?" his mother whispered furiously. "One of the neighbors?"



Cartoon by Lars Kenseth

His father shrugged his shoulders. They both shot looks at the stranger, who, seemingly oblivious to the knocking, picked up his fork and began to eat.

“Don’t open,” Shawn said.

“What?” his father replied. “Why? Do you know who it is?”

“It’s the police,” Shawn mumbled, his cheeks hot.

“Don’t be silly,” his mother said. “Why would it be the police?”

She reached out to stroke his neck reassuringly. But the warmth of her hand on his skin only made Shawn feel more wretched. He thought of the thin shopkeeper with the pinched face, of the

medicine-shop man. Of course they had suspected something. Of course they would have called the authorities.

“It’s the police,” he insisted. “Don’t open.”

Now his parents exchanged glances worriedly.

“Hello? Mr. Lim? Mrs. Lim? If you are home, please open the door. I need to speak to you.”

“This is ridiculous,” Chee Meng said in a low voice. “It is not the police.”

He stood up and began to make his way to the door. Then, as if thinking twice, he turned back to the man. “Still, better not to let anyone see you.” He gestured toward Shawn’s bedroom.

The man nodded. He seemed unperturbed, which infuriated Shawn. Did he not understand the iron rule of law, the efficiency of the police, the rotan? The man went into Shawn’s room and shut the door.

Shawn watched with dread as his father went to the entryway. Now the police would storm the flat, just as he had seen on TV, with their guns and handcuffs. There was nowhere, really, for the man to hide. Now his parents would be taken away, together with the stranger, in a flurry of uniforms and batons and flashing lights. Fatherless, motherless, he would be sent to a boys’ home.

“They’ll take him away now,” Shawn said to his mother.

“Don’t be silly,” his mother replied, but there was worry in her voice. “Maybe don’t, Chee Meng—” But Shawn’s father had already opened the door.

“Hello, Mr. Lim,” the woman said.

“Yes?”

Shawn let out the breath he’d been holding. Instead of men in uniforms, there was, improbably, the round, pleasant visage of his English teacher, Ms. Chong.

“It’s about Shawn. You haven’t come to any of the parent-teacher meetings, and I was passing through the neighborhood, so I thought I’d come see you.”

“Why? Shawn did something at school?”

“Oh, no, Shawn is an excellent student. But I’m worried about him. He’s been writing some rather odd compositions. Has he been watching a lot of TV recently?”

“No,” Chee Meng said. A surly note had entered his voice.

“He’s very preoccupied by violence and crime,” Ms. Chong went on. “He keeps talking about the police.”

“Aiya,” Chee Meng stuttered. “You know boys—that’s how they are.”

She paused. “Is everything all right at home?”

“Of course. We are eating dinner now, please.”

“I’m sorry to bother you. Will you make an appointment to come and see me at school, then?”

“Yes, O.K.” Chee Meng moved to shut the door in her face.

Shawn suddenly jumped up from his seat and raced to the entrance. “Ms. Chong!” he shouted.

“Shawn,” his father warned. “Go back inside.”

“Why, hello, Shawn.”

“Ms. Chong,” he said, his voice trembling. “There’s something I have to show you.”

His father’s hand gripped his shoulder. The words thrummed in his chest, fighting to come out. *There’s a stranger here, an illegal immigrant,* he wanted to say. If he told her, if she saw the man, then the whispered fights and gray, cooped-up evenings and strange, circuitous afternoons full of fear would end.

“Shawn?”

His heart pounded in his chest, so loudly he was sure the others could hear it. Ms. Chong’s voice was soft and sweet, like birthday cake, and it seemed to him the kindest voice he had ever heard. Something warm brushed his foot. It was the cat, scrawny and balding, ribs still showing despite all the expensive food Shawn’s parents fought over. Gently, Shawn touched his fingers to the cat’s head, and it began to purr.

Chee Meng announced to his son that they were to go on a special outing. It was the June holidays, the weather was unseasonably cool, and they hadn’t been fishing in so long. They would go to a different beach, a beach all the way out in Changi, and they would go at night, during high tide, in the hope of catching something big. A stingray or a reef shark, even.

Shawn clapped his hands with glee. Finally! A break from the morose cloud that had descended on their household.

Then his father tilted his chin toward the stranger’s bedroom. “Ask him to come,” he said.

“Why?” Shawn whined. “No, I don’t want to.”

His father shrugged. There was a tension about his shoulders, a resignation. “Ask him,” he said again, not meeting Shawn’s gaze.

Perhaps Chee Meng had seen the soft looks the stranger cast in Shawn’s direction and thought he would be more susceptible to the invitation if it came from the boy. Whatever it was, Shawn understood from his father’s feigned nonchalance that this would be no ordinary trip. Ever since Ms. Chong’s unexpected visit, Chee Meng had grown tense and brooding. Now it seemed that he had come to a decision. And so Shawn did as his father said and asked the man.

The stranger paused a long time before responding. His unblinking gaze, as knowing as the full moon on a humid night, would haunt Shawn for years to come. He thought of the man going through his father’s wardrobe, trying on his pants, searching for a belt. He thought of the hawkers and shopkeepers, saying no again and again.

After a long while, the stranger nodded. Yes, he would come.

Shawn’s mother packed curry puffs, fried fish balls, and potato chips for them as snacks, unhealthy treats that Shawn was not normally allowed to have, that she had gone out of her way to buy. Was it his imagination, or were his mother’s eyes teary as she handed them the plastic bags of food?

They set off shortly after dinner, filling the boot of the car with rods and pails and bait as they’d done so many times before. The stranger sat in the back seat, as he had the first day, except that now he held himself upright and stared curiously out the window.

The dense blocks of flats receding in Shawn’s side-view mirror were bathed in warm orange light. But they were no longer a comforting sight for him, as they had been in the past. He found himself wondering about all the secrets that were kept behind each

closed door. The tidy nature of the buildings, which had once been a source of pride for Shawn, now appeared threatening in its precision. He had learned the cost of such order. There was no place for the stranger in their country, in their lives. What else was shut out of this safest country in the world?

Forty minutes into the drive, the buildings had been replaced by jungle. Shawn felt that he had never been so far from home in his life, not even during Chinese New Year, when they drove across the island to visit his great-uncle in Woodlands. Eventually, they came to an empty car park. A sliver of moon gleamed behind a wisp of cloud, lighting the sand beyond the asphalt. Shawn and his father got out.

“Come.” Chee Meng beckoned to the stranger.

There was a long silence, and, for a moment, Shawn had the awful fear that the stranger would not leave their car. Neither his father nor he wanted to acknowledge what they were doing, but, if the man were to resist, they would be forced to. Cheeks burning, Shawn began to unload the fishing gear from the boot.

After a few seconds, the stranger stepped out of the car. Chee Meng handed him their plastic bags of food, and, slowly, the three of them made their way down to the surf. The beach was empty. No lights shone from blocks of flats; no sounds of traffic came from any road. Only the dark bodies of container ships, crowned with blinking lights, massed along the sea’s horizon, as solid as a wall.

On one of the ships out there, Shawn imagined a young sailor, far from home, perhaps not much older than he was. Unable to sleep, the boy would be out on the deck, staring at the island city before him. He would see the forests of flats in which millions of people slept; Marina Bay in all its splendor; the luxury hotels beaming brilliance into the cloudy sky; the expressways, bright and busy no

matter the time of day. He would see unthinkable prosperity, an island of impossible light, surrounded by dark and hungry waves.

What he would not see: three small figures standing on a deserted beach on the lip of all that light. He would not see Chee Meng shove the stranger toward the water; he would not see Shawn take one step forward and then one back; he would not see the stranger standing alone and mournful on the sand, watching father and son disappear into the trees, get into their car, and begin the long drive back to the safety of their silent home. ♦

Rachel Heng is the author of the novels "The Great Reclamation" and "Suicide Club."

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/a-very-safe-place-fiction-rachel-heng

Sketchbook

Boo! You've Been Buried Alive

The first time I saw a mausoleum, I felt like I was home free.

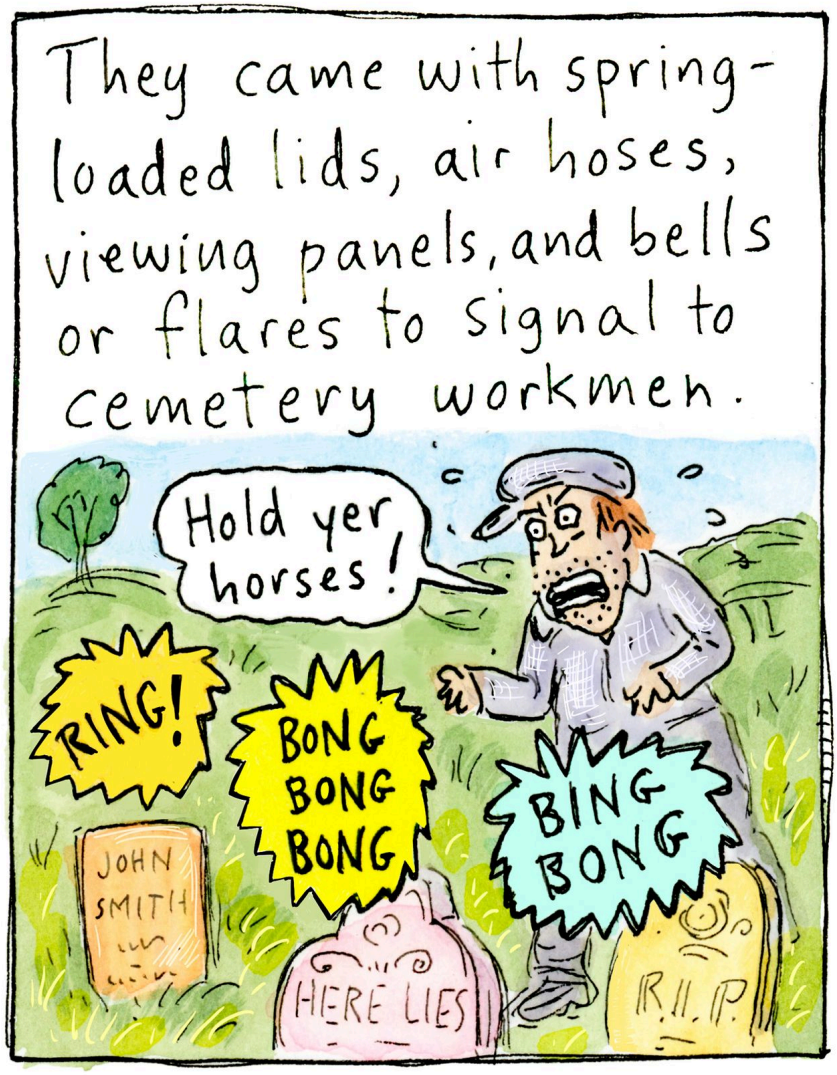
***By** Roz Chast*

October 5, 2026



The word for that is **TAPHOPHOBIA**, from the Greek "taphos," meaning tomb, and "phobos," meaning fear. It's a less common fear today, because we've gotten better at telling whether someone is dead or whether they are dead-ish.

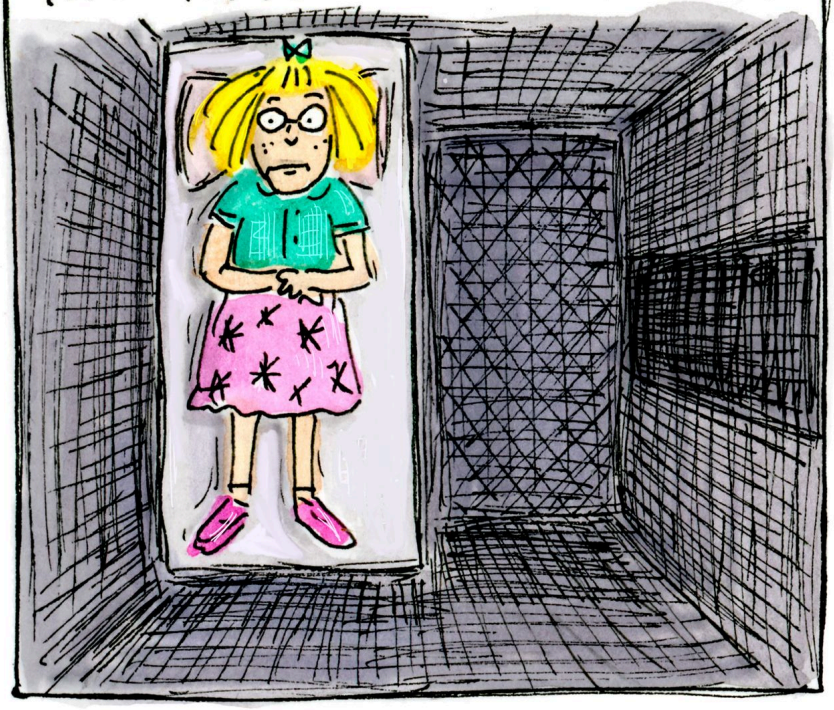

Safety coffins, also known as escape coffins, were a thing back in the 18th and 19th centuries.
Prithee, I knowest what thee can giveth me for Christmas!


They came with spring-loaded lids, air hoses, viewing panels, and bells or flares to signal to cemetery workmen.
Hold yer horses!
RING!
BONG BONG BONG
BING BONG
JOHN SMITH
HERE LIES
R.I.P.


Some even contained shovels and "refreshments."
GROSS.
Egg salad.


The first time I saw a mausoleum, I felt like I was home free.

Who needed a safety coffin— or even a coffin?!? Just put me on the little bench inside.




No bells, no air hoses, no fuss, no muss!
HEY! LEMME OUT!!!
BANG
BANG
BANG



Roz Chast has been a New Yorker cartoonist since 1978. She is a co-author, with Jason Adam Katzenstein, of "The Two Saddest Kitchens: A Comics Conversation" (October, 2026).

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/boo-youve-been-buried-alive

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A Critic at Large

Why Is Illness So Hard to Write About?

A century after Virginia Woolf asked why sickness had failed to become one of literature's great subjects, writers are still struggling to put physical suffering into words.

By Hermione Hoby

October 5, 2026



The inexpressibility of pain poses one difficulty. We tend to remember that we suffered, but the sensation itself often proves strangely difficult to summon.
Illustration by Kevin Lucbert

A hundred years ago, Virginia Woolf published her second most famous essay. "On Being Ill," from 1926, cedes first place in the Woolf nonfiction canon to the feminist cornerstone "A Room of One's Own," from 1929, but the two essays share a preoccupation with the problem, as she puts it in the latter, of "heart, body and brain" being "all mixed together, and not contained in separate

compartments as they will be no doubt in another million years.” In “On Being Ill,” that entanglement is tested by an eternal and indiscriminate form of suffering. Given that illness is an unavoidable feature of human experience, Woolf asks, why has literature represented it so rarely, and so inadequately?

The question accumulates more urgency along the wild ride of an essay that follows. Written during a prolonged bout of illness the previous fall, “On Being Ill,” with its tumbling sentences and exhilarating swerves of imagination, is so febrile that you wonder if it wasn’t written in the grip of an actual fever. The many-claused question of the bravura opening salvo is worth quoting in full:

> Considering how common illness is, how tremendous the spiritual change that it brings, how astonishing, when the lights of health go down, the undiscovered countries that are then disclosed, what wastes and deserts of the soul a slight attack of influenza brings to light, what precipices and lawns sprinkled with bright flowers a little rise of temperature reveals, what ancient and obdurate oaks are uprooted in us in the act of sickness, how we go down into the pit of death and feel the waters of annihilation close above our heads and wake thinking to find ourselves in the presence of the angels and the harpers when we have a tooth out and come to the surface in the dentist’s arm chair and confuse his “Rinse the mouth—rinse the mouth” with the greeting of the Deity stooping from the floor of Heaven to welcome us—when we think of this and infinitely more, as we are so frequently forced to think of it, it becomes strange indeed that illness has not taken its place with love, battle, and jealousy among the prime themes of literature.

It’s a remarkable irony that an essay objecting to a generalized literary silence around bodily suffering should come from the pen of such a disembodied writer, one who often, as she does in this passage, assumes the form of a floating consciousness. That lone

and bathetic tooth is the only sign that we're in the realm of the somatic. The high-flown rest—the wastes and deserts of the soul, the pit of death, the waters of annihilation—is made up of incorporeal abstractions, albeit conjured in a tone of wry exaggeration, as if to mock hypochondriac excess. At no point in the essay does Woolf specifically refer to her own body, her own illness, or to any particular person's experience of ill health, even as she calls for "epic poems to typhoid; odes to pneumonia, lyrics to toothache." The term "autoimmune" hadn't yet come into currency, but the self-thwarting character of "On Being Ill" suggests a similar diagnosis; here's an essay that denies itself the health it seeks. Why couldn't Woolf summon the explicitness she was calling for?

Occasioned by the centennial, a small publishing house, the New Menard Press, has released a new edition of "On Being Ill," complemented by essays from twelve contemporary writers on illness. This incarnation of the essay speaks to its durability: unlike human bodies, essays sometimes achieve immortality, or at least extraordinary longevity. It also calls to mind the fact that "On Being Ill," originally published in T. S. Eliot's *New Criterion* magazine, was reprinted three months later in an American journal, *The Forum*, under a different title: "Illness: An Unexploited Mine." It cannot be said that the mine remains unexploited today. The intervening century has qualified, if hardly refuted, the claim that sickness is neglected in fiction. In recent decades, narratives of illness have become more frequent, as the *omertà* around the body, particularly the once extra-unmentionable female body, has faded.

Even in Woolf's time, the metaphorical mine was not exactly unexploited. Appropriately enough, its foremost miner was an actual coal miner's son. D. H. Lawrence's "Sons and Lovers" (1913) and "Women in Love" (1920) both predated "On Being Ill" and featured illness in unignorable ways. Lawrence's passionately living, intensely feeling characters are afforded bolts of spiritual clarity, even revelations, by their sickbed spells. Abysmal bronchial

health dogged Lawrence throughout his life, the wages, perhaps, of a childhood spent inhaling coal dust in a mining town. A bout of pneumonia in November, 1911, when he was twenty-six, appears to have been particularly clarifying. When he emerged from illness in February, he called off his engagement to Louie Burrows ("My illness," he wrote to her, "has changed me a good deal, has broken a good many of the old bonds that held me") and soon afterward met Frieda Weekley, who became his wife. Woolf, too, saw illness as a state of heightened perception, one that disclosed "undiscovered countries."

In "On Being Ill" she nods to the posh Marcel Proust and the Oxford-educated Thomas De Quincey, but, by ignoring a peer for whom illness was such a shaping force, Woolf—that true genius, that unrepentant snob—weakens her own case. Her first public mention of Lawrence, a disapproving review of "The Lost Girl" (1920), suggests one reason for the omission: "We conceived him to be a writer . . . for whom the body was alive and the problems of the body insistent and important. It was plain that sex had for him a meaning which it was disquieting to think that we, too, might have to explore." Later, she insisted, unpersuasively, that "the greatest writers lay no stress upon sex one way or the other," complaining that Lawrence, Joyce, and Hemingway "spoil their books for women readers by their display of self-conscious virility." Sex becomes something to be shut down in the manner of a glaring headmistress silencing a cheeky teen-ager. And yet, in "On Being Ill," Woolf calls for a new language of the body, one that is "primitive, subtle, sensual, obscene." Who, if not Lawrence, was primitive, subtle, sensual, and obscene?

In fact, Lawrence was no simple counterexample to her thesis. In "Sons and Lovers," Paul's pneumonia is rendered from within as a "ghastly, sickly feeling of dissolution," and his mother's dying body is observed with almost pitiless exactness, complete with what her daughter calls "a lump as big as my double fist." But a few years later, in "Women in Love," the body all but disappears

when Birkin takes to his bed. Even while sick—especially while sick—Birkin is more mind than body on the page. He likes being sick, Lawrence tells us, because then “things came to him clear and sure.” Lawrence, the apostle of the body, had turned the sickbed into a chamber of metaphysical revelation. Depictions of illness, as Woolf puts it dryly, tend to “taper into mysticism, or rise, with rapid beats of the wings, into the raptures of transcendentalism.” Woolf’s own ambivalence about embodiment is pronounced and, at times, passionate: she refers to “this monster, the body, this miracle, its pain.” Attraction and recoil seem almost inseparable. Some part of her reticence may simply have been *pudeur*, a reluctance to render bodily matters too explicitly. Even such a visionary feminist thinker as Woolf could not, it seems, surmount the strictures of her social rank and break this taboo.

A century later, that inhibition has weakened considerably. How I’d like to press Christine Smallwood’s ironically titled novel “The Life of the Mind” into Woolf’s hands, with its opening scene of simultaneous double excretion: shit and bloody miscarriage material are being expelled as we meet the novel’s heroine, Dorothy, in a toilet stall in a library of an élite university where she teaches. Smallwood’s 2021 novel is one of a number of recent books by women who write graphically about the processes and pain of the body. A fresh addition, Lena Dunham’s memoir “Famesick,” in which the writer’s hysterectomized uterus is described as “the Chinatown Chanel purse of nightmares, full of both subtle and glaring flaws,” might be another good contender for blowing Woolf’s mind—and perhaps returning her to her body, too. As Woolf admits in her review of “The Lost Girl,” “We always dread originality, yet with the sense that once the shock was received we should rise braced and purified.” Shock, in other words, might be a tonic, even a form of medicine. But a patient doesn’t always welcome her treatment.

Needless to say, Smallwood and her contemporaries aren’t the first writers to rid themselves of corporeal squeamishness. In Woolf’s

own time, Joyce as well as Lawrence had already breached forms of bodily decorum in ways she found dismaying; later writers would make sex, menstruation, excretion, pregnancy, and physical decay increasingly difficult to exclude from serious literature. (Philip Roth is so well remembered for his characters' priapism that we can forget the meticulously detailed back pain of "The Anatomy Lesson" or the heart disease of "The Counterlife.")

Yet the strange disparity Woolf identified persists. We have grown much more willing to put the body on the page without necessarily becoming much better at putting illness there. It isn't that literature has ever been shy about death, that final health crisis. The canon abounds with wounds, murders, consumptions, and deathbeds. Real people, however, mostly die not from florid and punctual acts of violence but from drawn-out sickness. Even Tolstoy's "The Death of Ivan Ilyich," one of the most central depictions of illness in fiction, is more concerned with the existential ramifications of impending mortality than, per Woolf's prescription, the "daily drama of the body." Likewise, in the canon of *AIDS* literature from the nineteen-eighties onward, more attention is paid to loss than to the day-by-day specificities of the ravaging sickness that induces it.

In short, Woolf remains basically right: illness still doesn't have the salience in literature that it has in life. Why? Shame and decorum are obviously not the whole story. Woolf proposes another explanation: "English, which can express the thoughts of Hamlet and the tragedy of Lear, has no words for the shiver and the headache." Let a patient attempt to describe the particular sensation of a headache, she writes, "and language at once runs dry." A deeper problem, then, may be the strange elusiveness of language for an experience that eludes none of us.

While suffering from tabes dorsalis, a complication of syphilis involving the slow, excruciating degeneration of the spinal cord, the nineteenth-century French writer Alphonse Daudet embarked on the doomed and invaluable project of trying to put his

experience into words. The resulting posthumously published book, “In the Land of Pain,” has since come to embody (as it were) the idea of the incommunicability of pain. When the literary scholar Elaine Scarry, in “The Body in Pain” (1985), states that “physical pain has no voice,” and that “the pains occurring in other people’s bodies flicker before the mind, then disappear,” she’s echoing Daudet, who asks, “Are words actually any use to describe what pain (or passion, for that matter) really feels like? Words only come when everything is over, when things have calmed down.” Like many accounts of illness since, “In the Land of Pain” takes the form of jotted notes and fragments. Who, after all, can sustain long, continuous paragraphs while under physical duress? Woolf’s observation that “illness makes us disinclined for the long campaigns that prose exacts” refers to reading, but she might as well have been discussing writing.

The theme of inexpressibility shades many of the essays in the new edition of “On Being Ill.” The photographer and writer Lina Scheynius, for example, admits that in trying to describe her migraines, she is “attempting the impossible” since “I know I won’t come close to describing them as they truly were.” Here’s one paradox of illness: during an episode of pain, we can think of nothing else, even as it obliterates all thought. So much so that, as Scheynius admits, “I could never attempt to write anything from that place.” Afterward, another difficulty presents itself. We remember *that* we suffered, often very vividly; but the sensation itself can be strangely difficult to summon. The writer thus faces a peculiar predicament: when the pain is present, it may defeat language; once language returns, the pain becomes hard to recapture. How then can a writer meet the double challenge: to first imaginatively retrieve, and second, adequately render, their experience of suffering? We all know how it feels to be unable to say how it feels.

Ralph Waldo Emerson, in his essay “The Poet,” insists (in keeping with the gendered conventions of 1844) that the poet is “the man

without impediment, who sees and handles that which others dream of, traverses the whole scale of experience." As he rather formidably contends, there's nothing, including pain, that the poet shouldn't be able to express.



"Have
<u>you</u>
ever seen a bird?"
Cartoon by Liana Finck

Woolf herself, curiously enough, supplies evidence for Emerson's case. In the consulting room of her diary, the body is anything but elusive. During her period of ill health in the fall of 1925, convalescence strands her in "that odd amphibious life of headache"; shortly after sending the essay to Eliot, she records "a good deal of rat-gnawing at the back of my head," while the tiredness of her body is such that "it lay like a workman's coat." Whatever difficulty pain presents to language, Woolf clearly possessed a language for her own malaise—at least when writing in private. In this way, her reticence in "On Being Ill" really does look less like incapacity than inhibition.

Emerson's proposition gains further support from Garth Greenwell's remarkable novel "Small Rain" (2024), in which the narrator experiences a medical catastrophe in the form of an aortic dissection—a tear in the body's main artery. And, yes, it's as bad as it sounds. The precise descriptions that follow—the lacerating specificity of I.V.-line insertion (it "hardly hurt at all," until the nurse begins "pushing it in more deeply and moving it side to side") or the dull, relentless discomfort of a blood-pressure cuff—are proof that acute suffering needn't escape depiction. It's probably no coincidence that Greenwell, a poet before he was a novelist, is also one of our best contemporary writers about sex, that other hemisphere of the near-universal and supposedly inexpressible. Greenwell's narrator is a poet, too, and, as he reflects in one of his reprieves, what he cares about most is "devotion to the actual."

This devotion, however, is paired with the contradictory-sounding wish to "pull away from the concrete, to make it representative." And so Greenwell's formulation poses another challenge: How can writing remain faithful to the particular while allowing it to become representative? For most of "Small Rain," the narrator's world scarcely extends beyond his hospital bed, where his body becomes a terrain of eloquent fascination, horror, and tenderness. The narrowness of Greenwell's optic authenticates an important property of suffering: the immediate emergency of the body eclipses everything else.

Inconveniently for literature, the suffering body can even eclipse story. Pain may be difficult to put into words; illness can be harder still to put into plot. The chronic kind, especially, may offer neither the clean resolution of recovery nor the finality of death. It threatens us with plotlessness. Writing six years after the Spanish-flu epidemic had killed an estimated fifty million people and sickened countless more, Woolf imagined that "the public would say that a novel devoted to influenza lacked plot; they would complain that there was no love in it." Katherine Anne Porter's

1939 novella “Pale Horse, Pale Rider” is indeed “devoted to influenza” and, contra Woolf, supplies both love and a highly consequential plot. (“Illness,” our wise Woolf notes, “often takes on the disguise of love, and plays the same odd tricks.”) Miranda survives influenza; her beloved Adam, infected while caring for her, does not. The solitary derangement of illness thus gives way to the perhaps even less communicable derangement of grief. Dramatically speaking, the latter has more force. Porter’s story works because influenza is attached to those older narrative engines, love and death.

“The Magic Mountain,” however, suggests another possibility: instead of rescuing illness from plotlessness, a novelist can make plotlessness the point. Published in English the year after “On Being Ill,” Thomas Mann’s great novel of protracted sickness is set in a sanatorium where tuberculosis has suspended the ordinary lives of its inhabitants. Mann does on a grand scale what the Lawrentian sickbed epiphany does on an individual one: illness effects a caesura. Time seems to pause; patients enter an eerie, irresolute realm of exemption in which contemplation can flourish because action has stalled. The sanatorium becomes a space of ideas, its patients’ tuberculosis-tethered lives opening onto questions about civilizational decay.

Yet this solution introduces another difficulty. If illness does not readily generate action, there’s a powerful temptation to make it generate meaning instead—to turn the sick body into allegory or revelation.

No writer has objected more forcefully to this tendency than Susan Sontag. In her 1978 book “Illness as Metaphor,” written after her own treatment for breast cancer, she attacks the imaginative distortions that gather around disease and demands “real geography” rather than “sentimental fantasies.” Two egregious examples preoccupy her: the old myth of tuberculosis as the disease of the sensitive and spiritual, and the modern notion that

cancer afflicts “the sexually repressed, inhibited, unspontaneous,” or those “incapable of expressing anger.” Illness, as anyone who has ever been ill knows, is not a metaphor. Its exactions call for something more like testimony: here is what happened; here is what it felt like to this specific body.

Yet as a rule for writers, Sontag’s injunction may be too absolute. Devotion to the literal need not preclude the representative. Indeed, Greenwell’s novel suggests the opposite: close enough attention to the actual may be what allows an account of one body to acquire meanings beyond it. The rootedness of testimony in facts and sensation may be what’s needed for a narrative of illness to take flight into the universal.

Anne Boyer’s righteously furious memoir, “The Undying,” demonstrates how this can work. Her book details the graphic horror of chemotherapy and a double mastectomy—“everything we were supposed to keep inside of us now seems to fall out”—but refuses the imaginative smallness that ill health often inflicts, pushing outward from the suffering body to the world in which that body suffers. Rather than making cancer an occasion for spiritual transformation, she situates herself as a political subject, reckoning with a country in which corporations profit from sick citizens and the logic of individualism tries to impose its own narrative on cancer: “of the atomized individual done right, self-examined and mammogramed, of disease cured with compliance, 5K runs, organic green smoothies, and positive thought.” Boyer’s illness means something, then, but not because it reveals some hidden truth about her soul. Its significance lies in the material arrangements surrounding it. In this sense, her memoir realizes what Greenwell’s narrator aspires to: both the particular and the general.

Boyer tells a recovery story only of the cold and broken kind. In her book’s unpitying and radiant last pages, she writes, “I lost some neural mitochondria and my looks and many of my memories and a

lot of my intelligence and an optimistically estimated five to ten years of life span to the curative forces of medical decimation." Yet her insistence on the material conditions of illness does not exclude more existential meanings: "It's like the condition of *lostness* is, when it comes to being a person, what finally makes us real."

Lostness sounds like a condition of solitude, and illness certainly is one. As Woolf writes, "Here we go alone." But that is only half the truth. Illness is also a shared misfortune in the most literal sense. The sick depend on doctors, nurses, lovers, families, institutions. How does literature enlarge its field of vision without forgetting the singular body whose suffering gave the subject its urgency in the first place?

Epidemics, even more than sanatoriums, make the problem unmissable. Albert Camus's 1947 novel "The Plague," in which the Algerian coastal town of Oran is besieged by bubonic plague, enjoyed a remarkable revival during the early months of *COVID*. The appeal was obvious. Camus's plague is both a collection of individual bodily ordeals and an affliction of an entire society. Often read as an allegory of Nazi occupation, the novel, with its grisly descriptions of the lancing of swollen buboes, has plenty of nonmetaphorical specificity. Plague may operate with "the efficient impartiality of its ministrations," as Camus's narrator observes, but its consequences are anything but equal; common danger is no guarantee of common feeling. The novel's moral center is the doctor Rieux, whose vocation requires him to apprehend the epidemic in the aggregate while tending to its victims, again and again, one sick body at a time. Cures are not always forthcoming and sainthood is unattainable. But being present to life, as Emerson exhorts, is possible.

The premise of literature, of course, is that we can be both patients and doctors. José Saramago's "Blindness" (1995), in which a doctor becomes a patient, takes the question of collective suffering still further. Its premise seems almost aggressively allegorical: an

inexplicable pandemic of sudden, total blindness strikes an unnamed town of unnamed inhabitants. Yet Saramago refuses to let his sufferers disappear into metaphor. Blindness remains insistently bodily: a predicament of touch, orientation, hunger, filth, exposure, and dependence. The first victims are sequestered in a derelict mental asylum, where fragile bonds of coöperation soon give way to terror and degradation. As unspeakable acts are witnessed by the reader who can "see" what Saramago's characters can't, any notion of suffering as a basis for solidarity seems laughable: here's humanity as selfish, violent, and base as it gets. Yet after the befouled asylum is abandoned, a small community of mutual aid slowly, falteringly takes shape; its members' reliance on one another is a kind of grace. *Here we go alone*. But not entirely: suffering may isolate us, but the sick body depends on other people.

Woolf's diaries make a similar turn outward. In November, 1925, after recording the rat-gnawing headache and the body lying like a workman's coat, she writes, "The best of these illnesses is that they loosen the earth about the roots. They make changes. People express their affection." The enclosing experience of illness opens onto other people—and, for Woolf, onto writing, as well. Five years later, not long after typesetting a limited edition of "On Being Ill," Woolf was again confined to bed. Recovering, she remembered how, during earlier illnesses, she would furtively pull a piece of paper toward herself, out of the nurse's sight: "what a tremendous desire to write I had." After a few more days, and another of her "usual" headaches, she announced her recovery in the terms that were the most meaningful to her: "I will signalise my return to life—that is writing—by beginning a new book." ♦

Hermione Hoby first contributed to The New Yorker in 2016. She is the author of the novel "Virtue."

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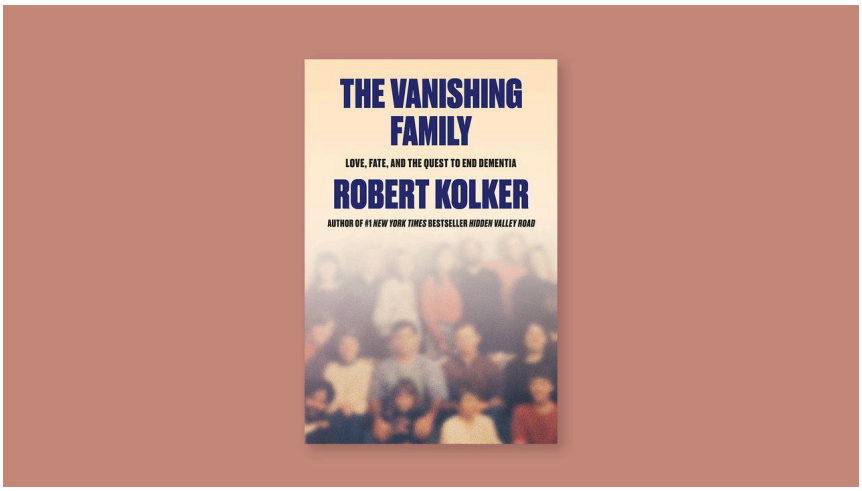
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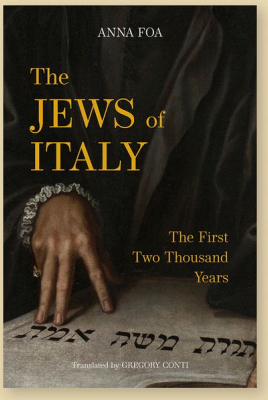
Briefly Noted

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October 5, 2026

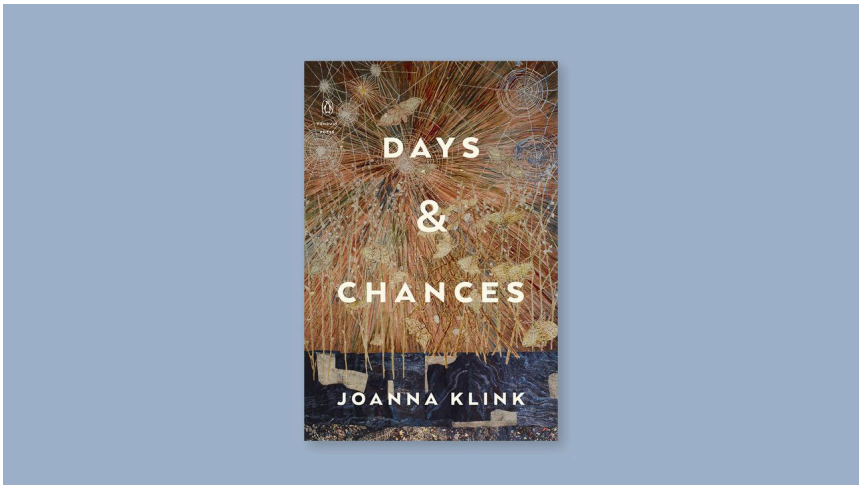


The Vanishing Family, *by Robert Kolker (Doubleday)*. Unlike Alzheimer’s, frontotemporal dementia often begins in midlife. In this searching and suspenseful chronicle, nine adult siblings reckon with the disease’s imprint on their family—their mother began to show signs of illness in her late forties—and with the question of whether to find out, through genetic testing, if they are carriers. Kolker’s granular portrait is interwoven with enlightening snippets of scientific history, but the book’s most powerful strand is about two sisters, one of whom, Sue, begins caring for the other, Christy, in her early thirties, and does so for decades. By the end, Kolker writes, their lives were “completely enmeshed, like one life lived for each other.”



The Jews of Italy, *by Anna Foa, translated from the Italian by Gregory Conti (Princeton)*. This panoramic account, spanning two millennia, argues that, without Jews, Italy would not be Italy. Although Italian Jews shared many experiences with Jewish communities elsewhere in Europe, Foa shows, the Catholic Church's outsized role in the region distinguished their history: papal doctrine protected Jews' presence while consigning them to a subordinate position, and the same institution that prevented generalized expulsion also established ghettos. Foa examines the effects of this dual standing, from Christians' enthusiasm for Kabbalah during the Renaissance and the vital part of Jews in the Risorgimento to the passing of racial laws under Fascism.

I Made You Up Inside My Head, *by Marta Pérez-Carbonell, translated from the Spanish by Rosalind Harvey (Riverhead)*. "All the versions of a story coexist, like the colors on a Rubik's cube," proposes Alicia, the narrator of this début novel. "And it is hard to get them all to align." One night, on a sleeper train from London to Edinburgh, Alicia listens to a stranger relate his side of a divisive incident in which he used the life of a friend as fodder for a best-selling novel. Alicia, in turn, decides to share a dark piece of her own past for the first time. "Confessions, outbursts, and revelations" abound as this whimsical narrative contemplates what it means to bear witness to another person, and how doing so can alter us permanently.



Days & Chances, *by Joanna Klink (Penguin)*. The carefully crafted poems in this collection explore the porousness of the boundary between inner life and external phenomena, articulating how an individual can seem grounded in space and time as a discrete being yet also be at one with the world. “Some days I am so filled with myself / I can see nothing,” one poem begins, but “Some days I’m nothing more than hearsay, / a story read back to me that makes no sense,” another muses. Klink is attuned to the ways that both nature and social environments can be suffused with memory, longing, and foreboding. Her curiosity and tenderness toward other entities, whether human, animal, or plant, is sharpened by a feeling of terminal separateness from them.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/the-vanishing-family-the-jews-of-italy-i-made-you-up-inside-my-head-days-and-chances

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Books

How Test Engineers Decide What Counts as Good Enough

Test engineers stage reality, sometimes by extreme means, to make sure airplanes don’t fall apart, children can’t open pill bottles, and bears won’t break into coolers.

By **Gideon Lewis-Kraus**

October 5, 2026



Even the best models are little match for the incomprehensibly dynamic complexity of the universe. Illustration by Lisa Sheehan

A run-in with human snacks transformed Kobuk the Destroyer’s mother into a “problem bear.” A native of the Alaskan wilderness,

the grizzly was possibly ruined by a dumpster or a cache of campsite refuse, teaching her that food was simply there for the taking—a rewarding hack for the perennial dinnertime problem. This never ends well, and it was only a matter of time before her taste for free-range chickens got her killed by a rancher. If she was the problem, the two cubs she left behind were recruited to help with the solution.

The bear-resistant container was invented to arrest the inadvertent cultivation of problem bears. A new cooler or compost bin cannot be marketed as bear-resistant until bears have been given a fair chance to break into it and fail. The gold standard is set by a consortium called the Interagency Grizzly Bear Committee, or I.G.B.C. Its original certification program was mechanical. Testers dropped heavy weights from considerable heights onto the containers and used metal fangs to make stabs at perforation. These things, needless to say, lacked the wits of the animals they were meant to represent. The cubs, Kobuk in particular, found their calling at a West Yellowstone sanctuary where the I.G.B.C. enlisted the bears as product testers. Human employees would fill new containers with fish, peanut butter, honey, and dog biscuits, snap the locks shut, and deliver them to their ursine colleagues for compliance testing. Candidates pass by withstanding precisely sixty minutes of no-holds-barred “bear contact time” without sustaining holes larger than a quarter of an inch.

The pioneering roboticist Rodney Brooks once commented that “the world is its own best model.” No bear surrogate, in other words, is as good as an actual bear. Kobuk justified his tenure on the federal payroll and earned the nickname “the Destroyer” not because he was savage (although he was) but because he was canny. He handily manipulated latches designed to defeat paws. The I.G.B.C. justifies its own tenure on the federal payroll because the definition of “bear-resistant” cannot be left to bears. We need people to decide that a product has failed if it can be opened in the buzzer-beating fifty-ninth minute of a bear attack.

The bears involved are expected to behave naturally. They bite and claw and futz. The humans involved must follow rules of their own devising. They structure experiments, agree on sensible measurement criteria, and publish evaluations. The bears represent the world as it is. The people represent the world as it could be—reassuringly free of problem bears. The tension between these roles is the organizing principle of Alex Davies's "Kobuk the Destroyer, and Other Tales from the Wild, Unseen World of Test Engineering" (Norton). The book is an appealingly droll and zippy contribution to the genre of admiring case studies in professional competence. It is also an effort to vindicate human judgment once and for all. Davies believes that the deployment of bears is an essential part of the scientific process. He wants us to appreciate the same thing about ourselves.

Test engineering might sound like a dry subject, but it turns out to be a terrific vector for the delivery of high-quality anecdotes. Davies introduces the discipline as one that has always gone in for the sorts of stunts we now associate with YouTube's finest content creators. Underwriters Laboratories, known for the ubiquitous "UL" imprimatur it provides to consumer products that pass its battery of safety and reliability exams, started out with the madcap energy of a "Looney Tunes" factory. When the organization's engineers wanted to verify that a particular safe could be trusted to protect valuable documents in a fire, they stuffed a sample with magazines and loose-leaf paper, covered it with kindling, doused the whole thing with half a bathtub of kerosene, and tossed in a lit match. Further trials subjected the safe to hours in an industrial furnace and a thirty-foot dive onto a pile of artfully scattered bricks.

No quest for realism has proved too extreme. An airplane's black-box flight recorder, Davies writes, is exposed to "the level of sadism required to mimic what can happen when a jet flies at near supersonic speeds into a mountain or plunges from the stratosphere into the ocean." It is fired from forty-foot cannons into chunks of

aluminum honeycomb before being drowned in a pressurized tank of salt water. These tasks require an unusual combination of brute physicality and procedural rigor. They select for nerds in shirtsleeves.

In many cases, test engineers reveal a theatrical flair. In late-nineteenth-century St. Louis, the new Eads Bridge was baptized by a series of increasingly ponderous locomotives. (This method has been updated only slightly; in the nineteen-nineties, engineers checked a Michigan bridge for corrosion by parking M60 tanks on it.) In another effort to convince the public that the Eads Bridge was sturdy, its builders marched an elephant across its span. The engineers, Davies adds, were probably aware that trains are heavier than elephants. They were equally aware of the popular folklore that “elephants could sense, and would avoid, unstable ground.”

Humans aren’t crazy about plummeting, either. Elisha Otis made the world safe for skyscrapers when he devised a fail-safe elevator. In 1854, he wowed visitors to an industrial exhibition by riding a platform to a height of thirty feet and then asking someone to sever its hoist cable. The slack triggered a spring mechanism that locked into notches in the rails and halted his fall. Informal daredevilry would remain a counterintuitive mainstay of safety. In the aftermath of the Second World War, the Air Force sought to assess a pilot’s capacity to survive ejection and other forms of radical acceleration. John Stapp, a military surgeon, strapped himself into an open rocket sled that clocked in at more than six hundred miles an hour in only five seconds. A second and a half later, he was nudged to a stop with the force of a collision into a brick wall. His face turned purple, and his vision was reduced to what he described as a “shimmering salmon colored field”; it took him about eight seconds to draw a single breath. He landed on the cover of *Time*, the era’s primary recommendation engine.



“Fine, you were right—‘Cavorting with the Devil’ is not a good band name.”
Cartoon by Ali Fitzgerald

Despite a seemingly inexhaustible supply of demented volunteers, it’s not always feasible to perform such feats in the wild. For as long as humans have flown, humans have flown into birds. Wilbur Wright survived the first avian strike; another early pilot, who might have thought it would be funny to surprise a flock of seagulls, did not. Few people are eager to rehearse an engine failure in midair. Presumably the same goes for the birds. The “bird ingestion test” is a classic example of a situation in which testers must operate under facsimile conditions. They rig up a hangar with a specialized cannon that shoots thawed bird carcasses into the blender of a spooled-up engine. The protocol has been formalized with great care. It begins with a single four-pound chicken, moves on to a fusillade of eight members of a smaller bird species, and concludes with sixteen tiny feather balls. The risk is deemed acceptable if an engine retains at least three-quarters of its power.

The statistical reasoning is sound, even if the ingestion test’s verisimilitude is a little hand-wavy. Bird populations change; migratory patterns, or what experts call “waves of biomass,” are fickle. In almost half of the bird-strike incidents investigated by the Federal Aviation Administration, the turbine’s charnel house is so messy that the culprit’s species remains anybody’s guess. (Davies,

who has a wonderful ear for niche jargon, is pleased to report that bird slurry is called “snarge.”) We can be fairly certain that no snarge can be traced to chickens, which do not fly. From 1990 to 2019, Davies writes, “the FAA recorded more bearded seal strikes (one) than chicken-on-plane encounters (zero).” Testers resort to chicken artillery in the absence of a robust supply chain for osprey.

The use of blameless chickens reflects a compromise between workability and similarity. Experimental results are credible only if the procedure is practical, repeatable, and standardized. We don’t fly in planes because someone pulled it off once. At the same time, the results are informative only if the procedure is a serviceable approximation of the actual circumstances we expect to face. Often, some basic gimmickry will suffice. Manufacturers assess the usability of medical equipment by putting it in the hands of its intended users, sometimes in fake hospital rooms filled with real beeping, where nurses might be interrupted by some nudnik asking if they own “the blue Chevy whose alarm is going off.”

Other instances are more challenging. John Stapp, of the rocket sled, had a detached view of his body—he once noted that “to the human engineer, man is a thin, flexible leather sack filled with thirteen gallons of fibrous and gelatinous material, inadequately supported by an articulated bony framework”—but most of us regard the flesh with greater sentimentality. The safety features on cars, for example, have often been evaluated with cadavers, which aren’t typically at risk of further harm. Nevertheless, Davies observes, the dead “have their weaknesses.” For one thing, they do not brace for impact, and they frequently suffer from preëxisting conditions. They’re also expensive and tricky to source ethically. Crash-test dummies are more readily produced, and their uniformity allows for better experimental control, but they’re imperfect substitutes. Manufactured in the image of the “average” male of a skinnier era, they are intended to be one-size-fits-all. They are poor proxies for women, children, and the “average” male of today.

The testing industry, Davies emphasizes, consists of trade-offs all the way down. Although some products that made it to market were needlessly dangerous—there was never a reason for the Little Lady Hot Stove, a postwar toy, to be able to reach six hundred degrees, or for contemporaneous science kits to include actual uranium—other products aren't useful if they can't hurt you. The ideal balance isn't always straightforward. In the nineteen-sixties and seventies, sixty thousand people a year reached into their lawnmower chutes to unclog them and ended up in the emergency room. In 1974, technocrats at the newly formed Consumer Product Safety Commission campaigned on behalf of the nation's yard workers, eventually advocating for a dead man's switch on every push-mower handle. In four studies, hundreds of volunteers moved their hands from a mower handle to the discharge chute; the results clustered at around three seconds. Once engineers confirmed that an affordable mechanism could stop the blade within that interval, three seconds became the standard. Industry lobbyists thought the rule was too stringent; safety advocates thought the blade should stop faster. The C.P.S.C. made a middle-of-the-road call, weighing minor additional costs against modest safety gains, and it prevailed.

Table saws went the other way. Davies recounts the story of an amateur woodworker named Steve Gass, who invented an electrical method to cut into America's thirty thousand annual shop mishaps. (In need of a stand-in for his own meat digits, he settled on hot dogs.) The contraption worked beautifully, but, because it added hundreds of dollars to the price of the appliance, it was soundly defeated by Big Saw.

The medicine-cabinet poisoning of children was an analogous problem with an ingenious and effective solution. Just as lawnmowers and saws can't function with rubber blades, drugs can't be replaced with placebos. They could be stored in bottles that were challenging to open, but, if the bottles were too challenging, people would just leave the caps off, making things worse. The remedy appeared in the form of the Palm N Turn

container, which charted a path between the Scylla of a child's ability to access pills and the Charybdis of an adult's inability to access them. Such containers are punctiliously calibrated. They must stump at least eighty per cent of a panel of fifty little kids in the course of ten minutes, even after the children are explicitly shown the winning technique. Then, within five minutes, they must submit to the will of at least ninety per cent of a panel of a hundred adults between the ages of fifty and seventy. Since the early nineteen-seventies, deaths from unintentional childhood poisonings have fallen by four-fifths.

The bulk of "Kobuk the Destroyer" is a story of unacknowledged legislators—modest people who do thankless things for good reasons. Its characters are generally engineers, scientists, and bureaucrats, often in the employ of large corporations or the federal government, who refused to take certain menaces for granted, applied themselves with honor, ingenuity, and persistence, and brokered delicate accords between competing interests. As a cheerful tour of invisible expertise, the book earns its place alongside Michael Lewis's "The Fifth Risk" or his latest, "Blockers."

Davies has an ambition beyond narrative companionability. Testing engineers, he thinks, do more than keep us safe; they tell us something crucial about the prerequisites for progress. His account is underwritten by scholars concerned, in different ways, with science and technology, among them the sociologists Trevor Pinch, John Downer, and Charles Perrow and the philosopher Ian Hacking. This tradition emphasizes that what we understand about the world cannot be separated from how we have decided to understand it, and to what end.

Good engineers recognize that their decisions affect the evidence they gather. Kobuk is clearly a workable bear. He is near to hand and executes in the clutch. But, as far as his kin in the wilderness go, is he adequately similar? Alaska might very well have grizzlies

that make Kobuk look like Winnie-the-Pooh, and, as Davies writes, “the four-year-olds certifying the medicine bottle as child-resistant are not the same four-year-olds who’ll try this at your home.” In some domains, this issue can be mitigated by the piecemeal scrutiny of individual units. For decades, tea examiners sampled every incoming shipment of imported tea to pass federal judgment on its taste. (There was a time when it was basically an office with a single official, in a viciously productive cycle of overcaffeination.) This process was burdensome and ridiculous, but for Lapsang souchong it was at least possible. Doing the same with AirPods would be overkill, so Apple relies on statistical samples: it can tolerate a negligible fraction of defective units, provided that the defect is tinny sound rather than a tendency to blow up in your ears. Vaccines, in turn, have a different risk profile. “Safe” and “reliable” mean different things in different contexts, and this semantic coördination is part of the institutional job.

Experimentalists also accept that laboratory conditions can be not merely unrepresentative but actively misleading. When the de Havilland company sought to divine the reliability of its Comet, the first commercial jetliner, its engineers subjected sections of the fuselage to an elaborate series of mock pressurizations, to assess their strength and then their vulnerability to fatigue. The test sections survived sixteen thousand cycles, apparently vindicating a projected lifetime of fifteen thousand flights. In 1954, though, a Comet broke apart over the sea after only about twelve hundred flights; three months later, another, with even fewer hours aloft, did so. As it turned out, the engineers had run their tests in an inauspicious order. The extreme-pressure test partly healed tiny cracks around the rivets, delaying their growth during the fatigue testing that followed. The experiment inadvertently made its specimen more durable than the planes it was meant to represent. It wasn’t an ideal situation to be winging it, but de Havilland’s engineers had little choice: the relevant behavior of stressed aluminum wasn’t yet understood.

We can, and do, try to game out reality in advance. But even the best models are little match for the incomprehensibly dynamic complexity of the universe. In a fascinating section about the effects of skyscrapers on street-level weather, Davies describes the construction of an “atmospheric boundary-layer wind tunnel,” where researchers blow bespoke gales through scale replicas of proposed cityscapes—complete with “balconies, trees, parapets”—to predict wind patterns. These researchers would like to spare visitors to an outdoor café the unpleasantness of gusts exceeding 5.6 miles per hour. The wind tunnel is fairly accurate, Davies writes, for rectangular buildings. The atmospheric physics of curved façades, by comparison, are often too cosmically labyrinthine to be domesticated. We would need to construct the actual skyscraper and then send people out to sip their coffees, which would defeat the entire point of testing.

The folly of this sort of thing is the joke at the heart of Tom McCarthy’s novel “Remainder” or Nathan Fielder’s series “The Rehearsal,” but in the virtual world we do it all the time. Formula 1 teams, Davies explains, use software to optimize aerodynamics and receive only one chance each year to take their prototypes for a preliminary spin on the track. They inevitably discover some residue of reality that they haven’t factored into their computations and, with that lesson in mind, refine their designs before the season begins. The cars race along in a perpetual feedback loop of improvement. If the Grand Prix gets boring, or the odds too predictable, Formula 1’s governors change the rules to keep the sport lively.

In all these examples, people imagine the goals, people invent the metrics, people run the trials, and people learn from their errors. The anecdotes pile up to form a brief in defense of human judgment. It’s easy to understand why Davies thinks this is needful. As he puts it, “Ours is a precarious moment, scarred by a pandemic and stunned by an accelerating climate crisis, run-amok tech companies, torrential misinformation, and eroding trust in public

institutions.” The political environment has been resolutely hostile to those who develop, maintain, and enforce our civilization’s rules. They are—in the view of both the young, inexperienced men who worked for Elon Musk’s *DOGE* and the older, more experienced appointees who have stripped regulatory and scientific agencies of their power—plodding, blank-faced dullards with nothing better to do than slow things down. Davies properly recasts his subjects as diligent, rigorous, imaginative public servants who protect our fingers from lawnmower blades and our children from white-hot toy ovens.

That’s not all. The engineers’ aspiration to stage reality inside the lab further demonstrates, Davies argues, that “perfect similarity is unattainable, and all testing relies on a leap of faith.” We started with vaguely bearlike weights and vaguely clawlike hooks, then replaced them with actual bears, which we, in turn, replaced with better bears—the greatest of which has lent its name to Davies’s book. The whole endeavor has something noble and priestly about it: the work is never done.

“The fact that the difference between a test and reality can be minimized but never eliminated is a fundamental, underappreciated reality,” Davies writes, with a little more epistemological grandiosity than one ordinarily encounters in a pop-science book. The persistence of this gap is why he believes we can’t get along without test engineers. If we could reproduce the world with perfect fidelity, we would no longer require their services. We would just simulate for ourselves the sunlit uplands of the future. Because no simulation will ever be perfect, test engineers are indispensable. In Davies’s account, trial and error is not just a good way to learn about the world but, in fact, the only way.

If “Kobuk the Destroyer” was motivated in part by the ascendancy of the Musk mind-set, it was also motivated by Musk’s ultimate justification for *DOGE*: artificial intelligence. Many people in Silicon Valley take for granted the hopeless inadequacy of human

judgment. Consider an ongoing debate about the F.D.A., regarded by tech libertarians as retrograde and risk-averse—a reliquary of fax machines and dot-matrix printers which mostly thwarts medical progress. The reason we continue to depend on expensive, time-consuming, often inconclusive clinical trials, they maintain, is that we lack a rigorous understanding of biological law. Once A.I. creates a perfect digital simulacrum of a cell, we can circumvent the bottlenecks of the physical world. Although many of A.I.'s most enthusiastic boosters have begun to walk back such claims in favor of a Formula 1-like feedback loop, it is still common to hear that an artificial superintelligence, as one observer put it, could infer general relativity from three frames of a falling apple.

There are all sorts of reasons to find the claim about falling apples and general relativity dubious. Davies makes the case that theorists and experimentalists need each other. Just as Formula 1's modellers learn from trial-lap results, aerospace engineers have learned from physicists; we now have good whiteboard accounts of what went wrong in de Havilland's fuselage tests. The prospects for digital clones remain an open question. What's more, it shouldn't matter whether a computer can ultimately infer relativity from apple footage. The goal of the tests Davies describes is not perfect mimicry. It is to reproduce enough of the world to serve our evolving purposes—to have pill bottles that children can't open, airplanes that don't fall apart, cafés where our newspapers don't blow away, and racecars that go zoom but not boom. The hard part is deciding what, exactly, a model needs to get right and what trade-offs among competing goods we are prepared to accept. Those decisions, we might hope, will continue to be made by neither computers nor bears but people who can be asked to answer for them. ♦

Gideon Lewis-Kraus is a staff writer at The New Yorker covering technology, academia, and books, among other topics. He is the author of the memoir "A Sense of Direction."

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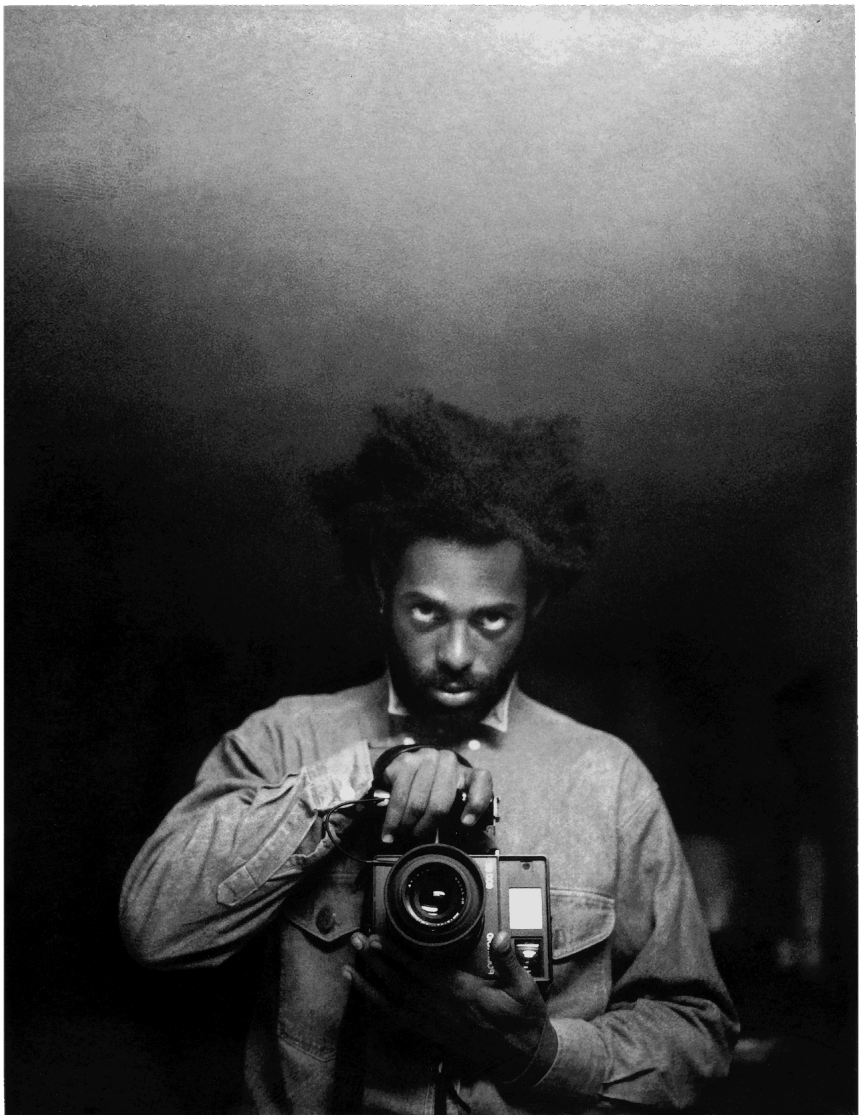
The Art World

Arthur Jafa’s Odyssey of Appropriation

In “I Am Tony,” a retrospective at the New Museum, the artist takes his remixing of the past to its outer limits.

By **Zachary Fine**

October 5, 2026



“Monster” (2017), a self-portrait by Jafa in gelatin silver print.
Art works by Arthur Jafa / Courtesy the artist / Gladstone

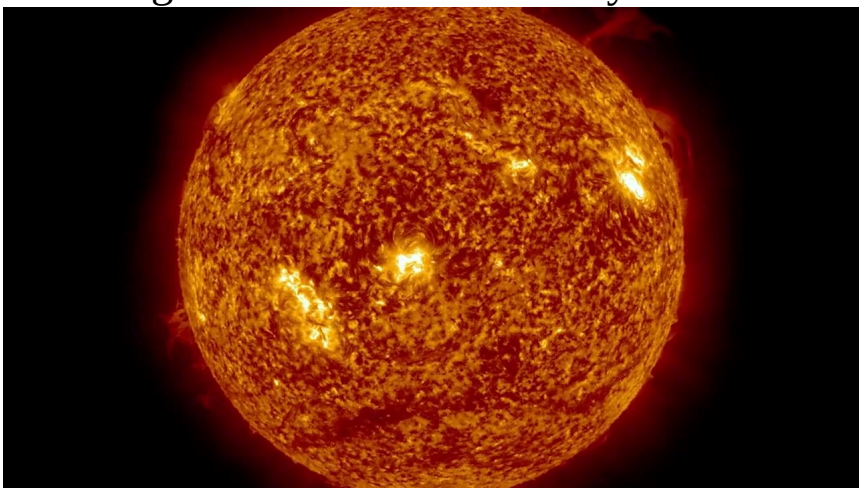
Is Arthur Jafa a rearguard artist or an avant-garde one in disguise? It’s hard to say. “I Am Tony,” a major retrospective at the New Museum, doesn’t frame him one way or the other, but it does make

you wonder about the moat of praise around his work, and whether it has discouraged reflection on some of his more conservative tendencies. Jafa's most famous piece, "Love Is the Message, the Message Is Death" (2016), selected by *ARTnews* as the best work of the twenty-first century, arranges clips of found footage into a non-narrative montage—a common technique in documentary film and commercial media, and a mainstay of the art world since at least Bruce Conner's "A Movie" (1958)—and the exhibition has lots of pieces that read as reheated Pop-type gestures, such as a big cutout of the Hulk (or, rather, an off-brand version that Jafa calls LeRage) and retooled press photos of Jimi Hendrix and Justin Bieber. But Jafa has never seemed interested in making new art, per se. His work is more about shocking the past back to life—not with irony or quotation marks but like a medic in a disaster zone.

In "Love Is the Message," seven and a half minutes of clips rush by: the March on Washington; Serena Williams at Wimbledon; Mahalia Jackson singing; Odell Beckham, Jr., making a one-handed catch; Walter Scott being gunned down by the police; a fragment of D. W. Griffith's "The Birth of a Nation"; a child screaming at his mother; people dancing; people collapsing; people wading through a flood. The distilled vision of Black struggle and joy struck a nerve in 2016, when the video was first exhibited, at Gavin Brown's Enterprise, and again in 2020, when art institutions made a show of displaying it in solidarity after the murder of George Floyd. Jafa was bothered by reports of people crying, using the video as a prop for catharsis or absolution, but it's hard to deny that it's edited for emotional intensity. Even the soundtrack, the gospel-fuelled "Ultralight Beam," by Kanye West, suggests that tears are in order. Each clip lasts just long enough for a feeling to ripen, at which point it's smothered by another clip, until you're left standing in the wreckage of dozens of unpurged, conflicting emotions.

Jafa was born in Tupelo, Mississippi, in 1960, and raised mainly in Clarksdale, in the Delta. When he was a child, his parents' house

was burned down by the Ku Klux Klan. His school formally integrated when he was in first grade, but Clarksdale clung fiercely to de-facto segregation. At ten, Jafa saw Stanley Kubrick's "2001: A Space Odyssey" in a theatre on the white side of town, and, even though he didn't understand what the movie was about, it changed his life. Jafa says he's still chasing an art experience comparable to that one, something that can "simultaneously alienate and ravish."



A still from "Love Is the Message, the Message Is Death" (2016).

I was reminded of "2001" in the show's opening rooms. In Kubrick's prologue, an ape realizes that a bone can be used as a weapon, then flings it into the sky, where it pinwheels and suddenly becomes a spaceship, the narrative leaping forward millions of years. It's the old Freudian lesson of civilization as sublimated aggression, and Jafa seems keen to rehearse it. "Ex-Slave Gordon" (2017) is a plastic sculpture based on a famous photo of a man who escaped a Louisiana plantation, his back covered in scars from being whipped. The man isn't humanized or made whole by the incarnation; the plastic makes his wounds look chintzy, like a wall ornament you could buy on Temu. The implied critique, that Black suffering is just another commodity in our online superstore, is produced by transforming an image of nineteenth-century violence into contemporary kitsch. That's Jafa's go-to method when creating objects in two or three dimensions. Like the time warp of the rotating bone-ship, his work entangles opposites across a historical divide, generating friction between an old medium and a new image, or vice versa.

Jafa launched his career as a cinematographer, and if you go back to his early work there are traces of the future video artist. At the start of Spike Lee's "Crooklyn" (1994), for which Jafa served as the director of photography, the camera flits around Bed-Stuy, showing un-narrated snippets of life: children racing down the street, jumping rope, and playing hopscotch; adults looking out windows or chatting in the sunshine. The critic bell hooks, in a review of the film, noted how Jafa's sequence subverted the typical suffering of Black characters in American cinema, depicting instead the pleasures of Black life. Jafa has said that he doesn't do remedial art, that he sees himself as more of an "undertaker" than an uplifter, but at the New Museum there's plenty of exuberance and uplift—such as "akingdoncomethas" (2018), an hour-and-forty-five-minute video of gospel choirs and church sermons spliced together. Admittedly, the gospel footage turns into something oversweet, and is punctuated by three minutes of California wildfires. ("Crooklyn," too, is ultimately a film about death.) If part of the message is about love, it's always, for Jafa, a love that leans toward the grave.

Massimiliano Gioni, who was recently named director of the New Museum, has described the installation as a "freestyle" hang. One room has a charmingly drunken salon-style layout, with pictures suspended at random heights; another has a dozen or so large cutouts of artists and intellectuals (Sid Vicious, Miles Davis, Foucault) stuffed along one wall; on the fourth floor, there's even a full-sized Pontiac Firebird. The show feels like a cross between a teen-ager's paradise and a regional-history museum in the process of deinstallation. There's also an enormous maze that winds through one room, with an exterior clad in black acrylic—so that it looks like a Minimalist sculpture—and an interior lined with images. The maze is dimly lit, so you're restricted to blurry glimpses of the art: a large ear, a massacre, a reproduction of Gentileschi's "Judith Slaying Holofernes," a self-portrait. For decades, Jafa has cut out and collected anything in magazines that's

caught his interest, and here he recodes the cool indifference of Minimalism with a personalized collage. It's a bit like cracking open a Donald Judd only to find a scrapbook inside.

A cat burglar can sample or steal, as Jafa has said, but it doesn't make him a good artist. If Jafa's signature move is appropriation, then his preferred model is the d.j.: someone who channels different songs into a mix with just enough harmony and dissonance to be interesting. In addition to the influence of Pictures Generation artists, such as Cady Noland and Richard Prince, he links his method to what he has called the "slave-ship style" of Black aesthetics—a nod to the Middle Passage, which saw people with different languages and cultures violently wrenched from their homes and crammed into the holds of ships. It's that process of removal and recontextualization which Jafa identifies as the tortured root of great Black art and music.

But appropriation isn't an easy strategy to rely on in 2026. Our screens are so frequently filled with images that have been peeled away from their referents—lifted, edited, scrambled, recombined, degraded—that you can no longer blow up a found image into wallpaper, pair it with a strange bedfellow, and expect it to acquire artistic depth. The weakness of Jafa's approach is that he often relies on visual correspondences. In his diptychs, for instance—whether of Mickey Mouse and a witch doctor, Robert Johnson and Miles Davis, or Marcus Garvey and Jimi Hendrix—it's the echo of a color pattern, an angled cigarette, or a compositional parallel that serves as some vague predicate for meaning. The historical collisions in these works might titillate with possible significance, but they aren't deepened or elucidated by the images themselves or by their remediation. Jafa's video work, by contrast, is much stronger. Pieces such as "Love Is the Message" and "BEN GAZARRA" (2024) make bold interventions into our image culture instead of merely revelling in how depleted it's become.

“BEN GAZARRA” adapts a scene from Martin Scorsese’s “Taxi Driver” (1976) in which Travis Bickle (Robert De Niro) shoots a pimp named Sport, who was originally a Black character in Paul Schrader’s script. In the movie, Sport is played by the white actor Harvey Keitel. When Jafa first saw the film, as a teen-ager, he loved the cinematography but felt that something was off, that Sport should have been Black. Years later, when he learned about Schrader’s script, he decided to perform a bit of surgery on the scene. In Jafa’s version, multiple characters are Black, and the scene loops twelve times, with little variations in the action. (One features a cameo by Stevie Wonder.) The work links the fantasy of an adolescent in Mississippi with a New York film of the nineteen-seventies and contemporary editing techniques, in order to pull the buried Black subject out of the subtext and onto the screen. Ultimately, it’s less a set piece of social critique than a way of appropriating the history of appropriation—of making the tactic feel new again, by reviving our relationship with the old materials. As a work of art, it alienates and ravishes just enough to live up to Jafa’s criteria. ♦

Zachary Fine, a contributing writer at The New Yorker, is the Kim-Frank postdoctoral fellow in criticism at Wesleyan University.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/arthur-jafas-odyssey-of-appropriation

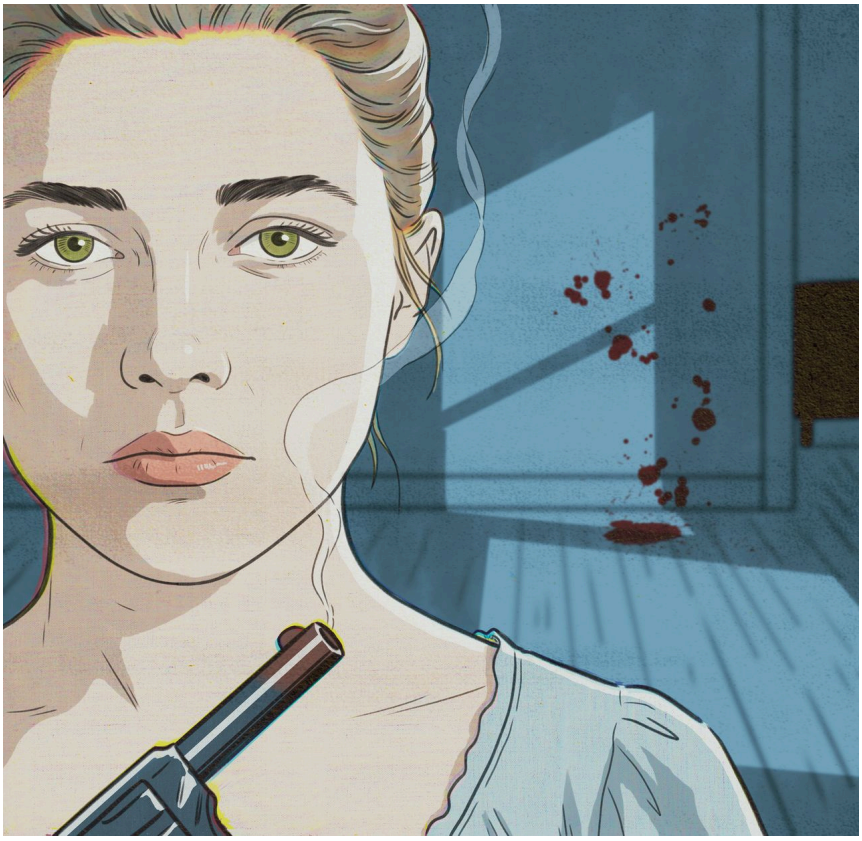
On Television

Zoe Kazan’s Heady and Bighearted “East of Eden”

While Christopher Abbott and Mike Faist duke it out as John Steinbeck’s Trask brothers, Florence Pugh’s Cathy is a gothic villain you can’t help but root for.

By Inkoo Kang

October 1, 2026



Florence Pugh, as Cathy, provides the series with a pulpy propulsion. Illustration by Alonso Guzmán Barone

Early in Netflix’s heady new adaptation of “East of Eden,” two young half brothers are set on a course of lifelong competition by their father. Cyrus Trask (Tracy Letts), a Civil War veteran, runs military drills with his preteen sons, Adam and Charles, on their Connecticut farm, until a show of solidarity interrupts the training: one of the boys helps the other load a rifle. Cyrus quickly canes

them both—the softer Adam for needing assistance, the defter Charles for providing it. When the children bring Cyrus birthday gifts, he doesn't bother to hide his preference for Adam's puppy over Charles's knife, in an echo of God's partiality to Abel's offerings over his brother Cain's in the Old Testament. Envy drove Cain, the firstborn son of Adam and Eve, to kill Abel—the Bible's first murder. But Cyrus, who demands absolute devotion from the boys, is too solipsistic to consider how the rivalry that he stokes will warp his sons' relationship with each other.

Unfit parenthood begets multiple generations of Cains and Abels in John Steinbeck's "East of Eden," the 1952 novel that the author regarded as his magnum opus. Yet the melodrama of the Trask men—and the misfortune of the women who come into their lives—has seldom been brought to the screen, most likely because of the challenges posed by the saga's narrative sprawl. The director Elia Kazan took a stab, in 1955, by retooling just the final chapters as an angsty star vehicle for the teen heartthrob James Dean. The result was as disjointed as it sounds.

The latest "East of Eden," a seven-part miniseries, is created by Zoe Kazan, Elia's granddaughter. Her version is more ambitious and similarly uneven: glossy and unsubtle, yet full of surprises and suspense. It's also a feat of translation that whittles the book down to its core components while expanding the elements that lend themselves most readily to prestige-television tropes: family dysfunction, feminist revisionism, humanizing detours into the worlds of the characters of color. Kazan dutifully dramatizes the resentments that fester among the Trask men until they explode in violence—though this dynamic, tremendously affecting with the earlier generation, hits diminishing returns when it reappears among their children. But Kazan's curiosity about two figures given short shrift by Steinbeck—Cathy (Florence Pugh), Adam's eventual wife and the show's narrator, and Lee (Hoon Lee), Adam's self-possessed Chinese American servant—stamps the show with her bigheartedness.

“East of Eden” gestures toward grandness in scope and theme, offering an allegory of the moral corruption of a nation, seen through the rise and fall of one family. (Another story line in the novel, about a large Irish clan, has been mostly excised.) The narrative stretches from the aftermath of the Civil War to the First World War—conflicts that, for the Trasks, are opportunities for profiteering. Cyrus, who becomes an administrator of veterans’ benefits, leaves his sons such large sums that Charles (Mike Faist) concludes that the old man must have raided his agency’s funds. Adam (Christopher Abbott), who turns a blind eye to the source of his inheritance, uses the money to move with his bride, Cathy, from stony New England to a ranch in California, where crops are said to grow so fast that “you have to plant and stand back so you don’t get knocked over.” But the fecundity of the land is no match for the Trasks’ failure to flourish.

These epic strokes rarely stir the heart. The show thrives instead in the interpersonal details, particularly in the many small hurts that develop into injuries to the soul. Letts makes the most of his brief screen time as a manipulator whose petty genius lies in creating an artificial scarcity for his affections. Adam and Charles’s shared fear that they are their father’s second choice curdles into rage at one another—a schism made permanent after the arrival of Cathy.

Tiny and blond with rounded, cherubic features, Pugh’s Cathy lands at their doorstep one night like an angel that crashed to the earth, her skull cracked and her dress drenched in blood. It’s a gothic entrance for a gothic character, and her presence provides the drama with a pulpy propulsion that cuts through the self-seriousness of most of the male-centric plotlines. Cathy becomes the black sun around which the series rotates, in command of an irrepressible will to power that makes her a villain you can’t help but root for.

Her backstory emerges in the second episode—a strong contender for the best hour of television this year—in which we meet her as a

cynical Lolita, testing the control she can wield over men with glances and pouts, and incurring the wrath of her disdainful father. When she flees her home—an elaborate escape in which she fakes her own disappearance—she leaves a trail of bodies behind her. Despite her gilded upbringing, which would have put a prosperous union well within reach, she pursues the sex trade before her marriage to Adam, and is driven to return to it after the birth of their twin sons. She abandons the infants without a shred of sentimentality, dryly suggesting to her husband on her way out the door that he throw them down a well. The only thing that matters to her, she says in voice-over, is her freedom—and, barring the convenient death of a wealthy relative, a woman can achieve true self-determination only as a madam. By the time Cathy, in a nearby town, runs her own brothel—known as "the most vicious and depraved in this whole end of the country," according to Adam's friend, Samuel Hamilton (Ciarán Hinds)—she cloaks herself in the sable-laced finery of a vampire queen.

Steinbeck's Cains and Abels were made by nurture, whereas his Cathy, the novel's Eve, illustrates the flukes of nature that can inflict a "malformed soul" upon any family. Kazan presents a more sympathetic spin on the character: a woman ahead of her time who, without the strictures of her era, might not have needed to act so fiendishly to get what she wanted. Despite the ruthlessness of Cathy's tactics—poison, arson, blackmail—she proves irresistible, because hardly anyone considers her capable of such evil, choosing to see her as a mender of socks or an embroiderer of handkerchiefs who will uncomplainingly fulfill their innermost longings. Pugh's performance is a master class in physicality and flair, one of her career bests. She makes Cathy unpredictable without sacrificing the character's psychological transparency, and even her quietest scenes boast the tension of a coiled snake.

There is some danger in this. Cathy's gravitational pull is such that the further the miniseries veers from her, the more it tends to plod. After Cathy's departure, the ranch's saving grace is Lee, who

effectively becomes the primary parent of the Trask twins, Cal and Aron. Kazan alludes to but skims over the historical circumstances that restrict Lee's possibilities for a complete life: in the late nineteenth century, anti-miscegenation laws and an entry ban on Chinese women conspired to prevent Chinese laborers from marrying or starting families. Lee, who arrives at the Trasks' homestead speaking pidgin and wearing his hair in a queue, is revealed to be a rare Chinese American, having been born to railroad workers, his mother in the guise of a man. Among the Trasks, Lee finds the closest thing he has to a family, wresting back dignity from the world through decency and a wry wit. But, in a breakthrough performance, Hoon Lee never lets the viewer forget the heavy toll exacted by his character's spiritual homelessness.

Lee's efforts to break the cycle of paternal negligence for the sake of Cal and Aron (played as teen-agers by Joseph Zada and Joe Anders) become one of the few sources of emotional resonance in the weaker later episodes, which draw the boys into Cathy's dark orbit. "East of Eden" rushes the brothers' coming of age, and the relative wholesomeness of their adolescent troubles ushers in a fresh breeze that ends up strangely off-putting. I found it far preferable to soak up the stagnant air in Cathy's room at the brothel, where she schemes to increase her sway over the town while falling victim to a morphine addiction precipitated by that first bloody night. Even in her grimy decline, there's no one else whose company we'd rather keep. Shut off to the revelries outside her door, she elects to speak to the dead, who alone can see the fullness of all that she endured, and all that she'd dared to be. ♦

Inkoo Kang, a staff writer, has been a television critic for The New Yorker since 2022.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/east-of-eden-tv-review-netflix

The Current Cinema

Tom Cruise Is a Scream—and a Gas—in “Digger”

In Alejandro G. Iñárritu’s conceptually elaborate apocalyptic farce, hectoring satire and visual sublimity fight to a draw.

***By** Justin Chang*

September 30, 2026



Playing an oil tycoon responsible for an environmental catastrophe, Cruise hurls himself into a bellicose oratorical frenzy.
Illustration by Emiliano Ponzi

Digger Rockwell is a funny name to give an oil tycoon. Like nearly every joke and jab in “Digger,” a doomsday-themed comic fantasia from the director Alejandro G. Iñárritu, it feels both on the nose and slightly off, as if the script had started with something more obvious—say, Driller Rockefeller—and then bent it awkwardly sideways. The name carries a rich legacy; over Digger’s mantelpiece hangs a shovel with which his grandfather struck black gold in Texas, in 1917. A scion of no small fortune or influence, Digger is played by an equivalent titan of industry, Tom Cruise, wielding a Southern accent and enjoying an overdue respite from “Mission: Impossible” heroics. Not that the star has left physical bravado by the wayside: he tumbles from a deck at sea and storms off a plane mid-flight. In a particularly Ethan Hunt-ish twist, the

actor wears a rubbery disguise—a potbellied suit, a scraggly gray comb-over, and a smattering of old-guy makeup. It may be the craziest stunt Cruise has ever pulled off: at sixty-four, he's finally acting his age.

A terrible new day is dawning, though Digger, who commands, plunders, and exploits the world's resources at will, is bound to be shielded from its worst consequences. An early tour of his estate, provided by the swirling camerawork of Emmanuel Lubezki, reveals a catalogue of crimes against the animal kingdom, with antlers and furs festooning every surface. Digger loves his critters, so long as they're dead or nearly so; his closest companion is an ailing, bedraggled white feline, Maggie, who might be the ugliest movie cat since Mr. Bigglesworth, from the "Austin Powers" franchise. A weird air of unreality persists. Why do the slow-rising curtains in Digger's bedroom resemble the ruffled drapes adorning a theatrical stage? And why do the pastel skies and misty landscapes outside his window look painterly to the point of artificial? Before we can protest, the plot is upon us. A methane leak at one of Digger's oil platforms, in the Arctic, has triggered a huge explosion, ripping away a chunk of ice shelf in Greenland. Now a rogue popsicle five times the size of Washington, D.C., may be floating toward northern Europe, spelling an environmental and humanitarian catastrophe that will kill or displace millions of people and cause more than eighteen trillion dollars in property damage.

Someone else might have spun a tense, straight-faced thriller from this premise, which is out there but not, in movie terms, wholly outlandish. (Compared with Roland Emmerich's "Moonfall," from 2022, "Digger" is almost a documentary.) But Iñárritu, who co-wrote the film, cares not for taut dramatics, and he has little use, and even less aptitude, for suspense. He's the most gaseous of Hollywood auteurs, and he has, in a striking confluence of form and content, inflated this methane-fuelled farce with fiery gusts of hot air. The movie is an epic series of harrumphs and harangues,

propelled from room to room—and, in time, out into the world beyond the estate—by a spirit of impudent absurdism and corrosive cynicism which seems to emanate from Digger himself. Hearing that several employees have perished in the Greenland blast, Digger thinks only of salvaging his rig. Learning that countless more people will lose their lives on account of his neglect, greed, and stupidity, he is pressed, reluctantly, into a most self-serving mode of damage control.

A circus of bombast ensues, some of it courtesy of the score, by the British composer Cosmo Sheldrake. Digger is lambasted by his half sister, Emma (Sandra Hüller), a superficially liberal-minded Shiv Roy type, with her own eco-friendly initiative. For presence and volume, though, Emma is soon eclipsed by the President of the United States (John Goodman), a bellowing buffoon in a Trump-red tie. He arrives at the Rockwell estate with a gormless Vice-President (Michael Stuhlbarg) and what appears to be an entire Cabinet of Pete Hegseths in tow, all of them praying for God's mercy one minute and prescribing the "nuke-ular" option another. The lone voice of sanity is Dr. Ganesh (Riz Ahmed), Digger's head of environmental safety and security, who explains various disaster scenarios, in an elegant cascade of high-tech graphics. In a room full of fascists and fools, Ahmed's projection of competence—and of the spluttering exasperation that is the lot of the competent—proves a genuine balm.

It falls to Ganesh to address the public, and to lay the blame for the crisis at Digger's cowboy-booted feet. But the tycoon seeks to turn the tables, and he unleashes a tirade that is insufferable yet enthralling. Staring down an assembly of the outraged, Digger spells out the ruthless logic of global capitalism and claims the world's fuel dependency as the ultimate vindication. "Oil is what we have. Oil is what God gave us," he snarls. "You demand, and I supply." The crowd does not respond favorably, and, in the chaos, someone flings a shoe at Digger—shades of George W. Bush in Iraq. But Cruise's oratorical frenzy holds you; he hurls himself into

the proceedings with unrelenting bellicosity and a bold indifference to the audience's sympathies. Watching Cruise here, I was reminded of what a good screamer he can be. There was the motivational mansplainer he played in "Magnolia" (1999), not to mention his monstrous Hollywood mogul in "Tropic Thunder" (2008). I also thought of "A Few Good Men" (1992), this time imagining Cruise, not Jack Nicholson, as the belligerent dispenser of truths we can't handle.

High-wire big-budget filmmaking has become harder to find and tougher to market, and the past several weeks of pre-release speculation have not been kind to "Digger." Now that Iñárritu's film is before us, the question arises: Is it a disaster flick or a straight-up disaster? I'd say it's a comedy of errors, both deliberate and otherwise. He has admittedly set a high bar for himself, stranding us in a barking-mad netherzone between the apocalyptic-farce terrain of "Dr. Strangelove" (1964) and the dystopian media satire of "Network" (1976). Other cinematic allusions are a bit more subtly flaunted: the ghostly pallor of the characters' faces, and of Lubezki's palette in general, bring to mind the surreally deadpan comedies of Roy Andersson, in which the living already look as if halfway to the grave. Even so, a bracing theatricality persists. Should you happen to notice the poster for John Cassavetes's "Opening Night" (1977) planted on a wall in one shot, you will have made Iñárritu very happy indeed.

On balance, he does seem rather upbeat. "Digger" may wag its finger about climate change, fossil-fuel dependency, and the bottomless corruption and stupidity of our incestuously entwined corporate and political classes. But, for Iñárritu, the wretched state of the world has always been more of a starting point, a baseline narrative assumption, than a determinant or register of mood. And his film, at once proudly unlikable and meticulously realized, is both a daring display of craft and a rude sign of life—which is to say, the opposite of depressing. Iñárritu has retained the visual grandeur of "Bardo," his quasi-autobiographical folly from 2022,

but shaken off the self-mythologizing torpor; gone, too, are the stultifyingly glum metaphysics of “The Revenant” (2015). For reasons that are both obvious and not, the movie of his to which this one harks back the most, conceptually and tonally, is the inside-Broadway comedy “Birdman” (2014). In that film, it’s the show that must go on; in “Digger,” it’s the world.

Unsurprisingly, Iñárritu wrote the film with two of his “Birdman” screenwriters, Alexander Dinelaris and Nicolás Giacobone. (There is also a fourth credited writer, Sabina Berman.) I’d venture that “Digger” is actually a better, more fluid film than “Birdman”—less contrived and constrained in its staging, more mysterious in its intentions and effects. There is, you may have guessed, a hidden formal and structural conceit at work here that—like the identity of a peripheral character, played by Jesse Plemons—I’m loath to say more about. What can’t go unremarked upon, though, is the surpassing wonder of Dennis Gassner and Richard Johnson’s production design, a near-Brechtian marvel of diaphanous screens, rotating parts, and other ingenious devices. Seldom have I encountered a greater disjunction between the bludgeoning overkill of a film’s verbiage and the playful sublimity of its visuals.

Iñárritu’s technique transcends gimmickry. The sense of a continuous, organic form, which he chased so aggressively in “Birdman,” springs to life here in all manner of unintended ways. A shift from one room to the next can suddenly whisk us onto another plane of reality; a change of context can unpack hidden layers in Cruise’s performance, locating a flash of human tenderness beneath Digger’s corrosive self-interest. In the final moments, the virtuosic interplay of camera and scenery transports us into a state of both wonderment and despair; it also gently destabilizes our perception of time and place. We’re left to question, as we wander out of our own theatres and back into the world, whether the apocalypse looms—or if we’ve been living through it all along. ♦

Justin Chang is a film critic at The New Yorker.

https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/digger-movie-review

Poems

- ## “Old Story: October”
  By Cynthia Zarin | “When is enough enough?”
- ## “Democracy”
  By Sophie Cabot Black | “Always those horses up on the hill, each / To their own pasture.”

Poems

Old Story: October

***By** Cynthia Zarin*

October 4, 2026

A mortal circle of leaves,
crimson, the maple tree

bent down, a diviner,

knee-deep in its own
dry rattle. A massacre.

How could we have

missed it, even distracted
as we are, dumbfounded,

stitching a handkerchief,

a tulle skirt, each seam
what we saw when our gaze

went astray, mortal (again),

as you would say, a bridge
too far, though not without

its small mercies—a little

folderol, the lion faces
of the pansies, the umber

moths fanned embers

in the beech tree. Where there’s
water, there’s water,

where there’s air, air—

this morning, the flame bush
aglint, a chandelier

of ice, the water brackish

in the coiled hose, a rat
gnawing the wooden spoons.

When is enough enough?

I am where my fancies
take me, I am not what

I am—the blackened maple

burning its leaves, the jackdaws
circling, the moth’s wing charred,

beating and beating.

Cynthia Zarin, a regular contributor to The New Yorker since 1983, teaches at Yale. She is the author of the novels “Estate” and “Inverno” and the poetry collection “Next Day: New and Selected Poems,” among others.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/old-story-october-cynthia-zarin-poem

Poems

Democracy

***By** Sophie Cabot Black*

October 4, 2026

Always those horses up on the hill, each
To their own pasture, the higher ground

Trued until one cannot see the other—
How great the grass of no one else, the silence

Of four corners made clear. But resolute the wind
Rattling each gate as if to open, as if the perfect

Green would go everywhere
Without sunken post or wire, while time

Finds its way: a latch breaks,
Loosens into many parts, and one horse sets out,

Nowhere to go but through
Us, where we gather, where we shift

Back and forth, where we practice
The arc of resting neck on neck, breath

On breath, closing in to sleep
With one of us awake, watching the trees—

That horse must come down
To where we lean and pivot

Together like a wheel into the cold hard rain—
Our mouths full of the wild field

And dirt, working the root, the past tense
Into the present. For out of the tread

Of many hooves comes the more wondrous grass
Made listening to each other through each night.

Sophie Cabot Black has been contributing to the magazine since 2006. Her books include the poetry collection "Geometry of the Restless Herd."

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/10/12/democracy-sophie-cabot-black-poem

Puzzles & Games

- **The Crossword: Tuesday, September 29, 2026**
  By Patrick Berry | A moderately challenging puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Tuesday, September 29, 2026

A moderately challenging puzzle.

By ***Patrick Berry***

September 29, 2026

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Patrick Berry has been publishing puzzles since 1993 and lives in Athens, Georgia.

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